



Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

BJP LIKELY TO ADD 1 SEAT TO TALLY IN RAJYA SABHA POLLS

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NEW DELHI: The BJP which has 116 MPs in Rajya Sabha is all set to gain a seat in the Upper House where it is already the single largest party. The Election Commission on Tuesday announced that biennial elections to fill 10 vacancies from Uttar Pradesh and one from Uttarakhand will be held on October 16. It will also hold a bypoll in West Bengal. →P5

2 ACCUSED IN JAMUI MOLESTATION CASE HELD AFTER FIRING

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PATNA: Two primary suspects in the alleged harassment and molestation of two minor school students in Bihar's Jamui district were arrested on Tuesday after an encounter.

One of them suffered a bullet injury and the other was injured while trying to flee, said police officers. →P6

INDIA GREENLIGHTS APPOINTMENT OF NEW B'DESH ENVOY

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday formally okayed the appointment of Bangladesh foreign secretary Asad Alam Siam as the next high commissioner to New Delhi, people familiar with the matter said. Siam, who joined the Bangladesh Foreign Service in 1995, will replace Riaz Hamidullah in New Delhi in the coming weeks. →P7

Three men posing as cops rape minor in south Delhi park

Safety gaps exposed in heart of Capital; 17-yr-old girl went to Aastha Kunj park on birthday with friend

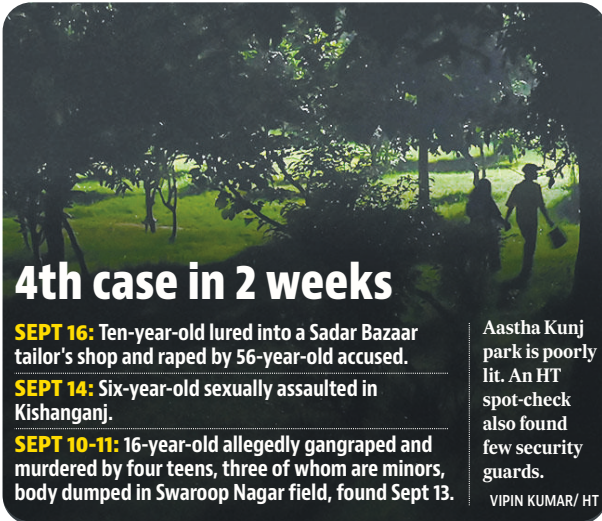
Jignasa Sinha

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NEW DELHI: A minor school student was gang-raped allegedly by three men on Monday evening inside Aastha Kunj park, a stone's throw from Kalkaji temple, hours after she turned 17, the latest in a string of crimes against women raising serious questions about policing in the Capital.

The girl, a resident of Faridabad, and her 17-year-old friend, a resident of south Delhi, reached Kalkaji temple around 7pm on Monday to mark her birthday, said police officers. After visiting the temple, they headed to the vast Aastha Kunj park, managed by the Delhi Development Authority, around 7.30pm, the officers said.

They were seated on a bench when the three men – Asif, 25, and brothers Mukesh Singh, 24, and Hemant Singh, 31 – posed as police personnel and threatened to call the duo's parents and a PCR van, before separating them. The survivor's male friend was taken to a corner and slapped around, and the minor girl was allegedly raped by the three men, said police officers.



4th case in 2 weeks

SEPT 16: Ten-year-old lured into a Sadar Bazaar tailor's shop and raped by 56-year-old accused.

SEPT 14: Six-year-old sexually assaulted in Kishanganj.

SEPT 10-11: 16-year-old allegedly gangraped and murdered by four teens, three of whom are minors, body dumped in Swaroop Nagar field, found Sept 13.

Aastha Kunj park is poorly lit. An HT spot-check also found few security guards. VIPIN KUMAR/HT

'WOMAN KILLS SELF AFTER GANGRAPE

A 19-year-old woman died by suicide on Tuesday after she was gang-raped by six people, including three minors, in UP's Jhansi, police said on Tuesday. Her family said the suspects threatened to circulate a video of the crime. →P6

morestories

Inside the park: Few guards, no lights

Minor's detailed account helped cops nab accused

LSR suspends physical classes, seeks security

continued on →8

SC to EC: Address voter concern on SIR notices

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday asked the Election Commission to take steps to "inspire confidence" among voters in Delhi's ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, questioning whether notices issued to 3.3 million electors were being sent "mechanically" or were even "computer generated".

The court asked the EC to clarify the category of "logical discrepancy" and also asked the poll panel to examine whether the notices clearly told voters what information or documents would suffice to answer the discrepancies flagged against them. It directed the Election Commission to file a status report on the steps taken to address the concerns.

The bench, comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and

continued on →8

"Nobody who feels an infraction of Article 25, 26 rights would be subjected to penal consequences. For a conscientious objector, not to recite one or all the stanzas of the national song is not going to subject himself to criminal prosecution."

— SUPREME COURT



Penal action for not singing Vande open to scrutiny: SC

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday declined to examine whether Vande Mataram should be recognised as the National Song or whether its official rendition should comprise two or six stanzas, saying

the choice of national symbols and the aspirations associated with them fall within the remit of an elected government, even as it agreed to examine whether that recognition can carry criminal consequences for a citizen who, on grounds of conscience or religion, chooses not to sing it. →P5

SC DIRECTS U.P. TO REPLACE PUBLIC PROSECUTOR IN LAKHIMPUR CASE

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Uttar Pradesh government to replace the public prosecutor conducting the 2021 Lakhimpur Kheri violence trial against Ashish Mishra, son of former Union minister Ajay Mishra, after being told crucial witnesses were being given up by the present prosecutor. The court, however, dismissed the plea seeking removal of the presiding officer accused of intimidating one witness. →P6



Matthew Aaron VanDyke

MAN BAILED IN ARMS TRAINING CASE TO SEEK DISCHARGE IN IMMIGRATION CASE

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NEW DELHI: American citizen Matthew Aaron VanDyke, whom the National Investigation Agency (NIA) charged with violating the Immigration and Foreigners Act this month, has paid ₹5.5 lakh as compounding charges to the Foreigners Regional Registration Office in Delhi before moving an application seeking his discharge, people familiar with the development said on Tuesday. →P7

India joins global grouping to defend multilateralism

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: India joined the European Union (EU), Australia, Brazil and Canada to launch a platform aimed at defending multilateralism and promoting peace and inclusive prosperity on the margins of the UN General Assembly, with external affairs minister S Jaishankar emphasising the need for participative deliberations and transparent decision-making.

Jaishankar joined European Council President Antonio Costa, Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, Brazil's foreign minister Mario Vieira, Bar-

bados Prime Minister Mia Motley, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney and Kenyan President William Ruto for the inaugural Partners for multilateralism, international law, peace and prosperity (P4M) Summit in New York on September 21.

Jaishankar, who is leading the Indian delegation to the UN General Assembly, noted that India is glad to join the initiative as a co-sponsor at a time when the global order is "under stress". "Reformed multilateralism is therefore essential. More participative deliberations and more transparent decision-making are both overdue," he said at the meeting. →P6

U.S., IRAN OFFICIALS MET ON TUESDAY, SAYS TRUMP AFTER THREAT

President Donald Trump said US and Iranian officials met on Tuesday, shortly after threatening in his address to the UN General Assembly that he may "annihilate" the Islamic Republic if a deal isn't reached soon to end the nearly seven-month war. Trump confirmed the talks in an exchange with reporters but offered few details about how the talks transpired or the substance of the exchange. →P11

53 STUDENTS DIED ACROSS IITs IN 5 YRS, GOVT DATA SHOWS

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NEW DELHI: At least 53 students died across IITs between 2020-21 and 2024-25, with more than half involving students from SC, ST and OBC categories, according to official data accessed by HT. The figures are in line with student intake from these marginalised groups in the government-owned institutions. →P7

DELHI MOVES TO SET UP NITI AAYOG-LIKE POLICY THINK TANK

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has prepared a cabinet note for setting up the Delhi Institute for Transformation and Innovation (DITI), a policy think tank on the lines of Centre's NITI Aayog, that will help frame development plans, including a "Vision Delhi 2047" document. HTC

STEEP FINES, 4-WAY SEGREGATION IN NDMC WASTE RULES

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has framed new waste management byelaws for Lutyens' Delhi, mandating four-way segregation of waste at source, imposing steep fines for sanitation violations and reworking monthly user charges, civic officials said on Tuesday. HTC

CPWD ASKS KRISHI, SHASTRI BHAWANS TO CLOSE BY SEPT 30

Soumya Chatterjee

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NEW DELHI: The Central Public Works Department (CPWD) has asked government departments to vacate and hand over the Shastri Bhawan and Krishi Bhawan premises by the end of September, paving the way for construction of Kartavya Bhawan (KB) 4 and 5 in central Delhi.

The tender for the construction of the buildings, floated in June, pegs the cost of the project at ₹3,155.41 crore.

Green nods for ports now valid for 20 years

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NEW DELHI: The Union environment ministry, through a gazette notification, has extended the validity period of environmental clearances (ECs) for ports, harbours, breakwaters and dredging projects from the existing 10 years (which can be increased by one year) to 20 years (which can be increased by five years each twice), making it the same as for mining projects.

This is valid for prior ECs as well, the gazette states. Officials familiar with the matter said this was being done to improve ease of business.

The gazette notification, dated September 21, states the Centre has from time to time, rationalised the validity period of ECs – especially for projects and activities which have "high gestation period" due to "various issues which are often beyond the control of the project proponent". →P7

→QUALITY RULES FOR SCREENGUARDS, P7

MEN'S TEAM SCRAPES PAST JAPAN BY 2 RUNS

Axar Patel choked Japanese batters just in time as India flirted with defeat before winning a rain-curtailed one-off T20 by just two runs here on Tuesday. The match was reduced to five overs each due to inclement weather and the moisture on the surface offered more turn than expected. The conditions narrowed the gulf in talent as India managed only 32 for 4 in five overs against Japan, ranked 41st in the world. →P14



India captain Harmanpreet Kaur poses with the medal. P11

Aditya Bhattacharya

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NEW DELHI: Four days into the Asian Games, India have clinched their first gold medal with the women's cricket team, led by Harmanpreet Kaur, delivering a thumping 147-run win over Sri Lanka in the final on Tuesday.

In a repeat of the 2023 final, the Indian batters put on a show, with Smriti Mandhana top-



ASIAN GAMES

scoring with 79, Shafali Verma contributing a stroke-filled 48 and Richa Ghosh living up to her role of a finisher as India posted a strong 216/3. Sri Lanka, in response, were bundled out for 69.

India defeated Sri Lanka three years ago in 2023 Hangzhou and, in last week's Asia Cup final. They made it three wins in a row against them in big-ticket multi-nation finals. The win took India's medal tally to seven. →P13

{ REPEAT OF 2023 FINAL }

India clinch first gold in Japan as Mandhana helps women's cricket team brush Lanka aside

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{ MY INDIA } IMPACTS REGIONAL PEACE

India condemns Pak strikes on Afg border



India on Tuesday condemned Pakistan's air strikes on border areas of Afghanistan that resulted in civilian casualties, and said Islamabad's acts of "aggression" against a sovereign neighbour would impact regional peace and security. The external affairs ministry's response to the Pakistani attacks was in line with New Delhi's stance of consistently backing Kabul during a flare-up of regional tensions. Taliban officials said Pakistan's air strikes killed three civilians and injured four more. "We strongly condemn the attacks from Pakistan, the air strikes which were launched on Afghanistan in Kunar and Paktika provinces..." MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said. "Such instances of aggression against a sovereign neighbour is something that goes against regional peace and security, it vitiates regional peace and security. And it is yet another occasion of aggression from the Pakistani side."

HTC

{ BUSINESS } JPMORGAN CHIEF

'US shouldn't punish India for Russian oil'



India and global oil markets shouldn't be punished as the US seeks to pressure Russia to end its war in Ukraine, JPMorgan Chase & Co chairman and chief executive officer Jamie Dimon said in an interview, pointing to the challenges refiners face in switching crude supplies. "I think hopefully America will sit down and understand all those issues and, you know, not end up punishing India and the world oil markets while doing what we need to do to combat Russia," Dimon said in an interview with CNBC TV18 in Mumbai on Tuesday. Refineries are typically designed to process certain grades of crude, limiting how easily buyers can switch suppliers. "If they don't buy it here, they have to buy it elsewhere," Dimon said. "It might not be the right kind of oil for those refineries."

BLOOMBERG

{ WORLD } DETAILS OF HER DEATH

Book by Diana's brother triggers royal pushback



A book published on Tuesday by the brother of the late Princess Diana has made headlines around the world with its damning allegations about Diana's ex-husband, now King Charles III. In "Swan Song: Diana, My Sister," Charles Spencer alleges that he argued with the then-Prince Charles over palace plans for Prince William and Prince Harry, then 15 and 12, to walk behind their mother's coffin during her 1997 funeral procession. Spencer says he told Charles that Diana, who was killed in a car crash in Paris at the age of 36, would not have wanted her boys to undergo the ordeal. He claims the prince "went ballistic" during the argument, and told him: "Rest assured, we'll forget her soon enough." Spencer also accuses Charles of having "contempt" for his ex-wife and of sounding "elated" after her death. After excerpts of the book were published last week, Buckingham Palace responded with a strongly worded statement that's rare by the measured standards of the royal household.

PTI

{ BUSINESS } SAYS AVIATION MIN

SpiceJet finances, ops under DGCA scrutiny



The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) is carrying out operational and financial scrutiny of SpiceJet, civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu said on Tuesday even as the airline grapples with flight cancellations and delays. "The immediate activity in the ministry regarding SpiceJet is that we have operational and, to a certain extent, financial scrutiny also being done from the ministry through the DGCA because we don't want any lapse in safety," Naidu said. As per the latest DGCA monthly data, SpiceJet's domestic market share dropped to 1.6% in July from 1.9% in June. Naidu said the ministry was continuously engaging with the airline. "In terms of the future, we are continuously engaging and seeing how best we can facilitate the ministry side," the aviation minister said.

PTI

{ BUSINESS } EIGHT-STOREY TOWER

Juhu house sold for ₹711cr in record deal



The founder of one of India's biggest retail stockbrokers snapped up a luxury tower in Mumbai for ₹711 crore, marking the most expensive known purchase of a single residential unit in the country. Dinesh Thakkar from Angel One purchased the sea-facing eight-storey tower spread across 63,000 square feet in the upscale neighbourhood of Juhu, the developer, Embassy Developments, and Thakkar said in a statement on Tuesday. Embassy's shares rose as much as 8.3% in early trade, before ending the day down 0.8%. Embassy Developments entered the Mumbai real estate market in January with a plan to invest ₹4,500 crore for residential towers across the city. One of its projects in the neighbourhood that Thakkar bought his residence in has a gross development value of over ₹3,000 crore and offers a single residence across every floor with sea-facing views.

BLOOMBERG

India's Russian oil imports fell in Aug, data shows

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NEW DELHI: Russia's share in India's oil imports fell in August, while supplies from the Middle East (West Asia) increased as Abu Dhabi National Oil Co (ADNOC) sold oil from the region from outside the Strait of Hormuz, data from trade sources showed.

United Arab Emirates' state-run ADNOC has strengthened its shipping operations, shutting oil from its fields inside the Strait of Hormuz for sale from storage and export terminals at Fujairah and Sohar.

In addition to its own crude, ADNOC is also buying oil from neighbouring producers such as Iraq for resale.

India's Russian oil imports fell 16.5% in August from the previous month to about 2.1 million barrels per day (bpd), the data showed. Russia remained India's top oil supplier, followed by the UAE and Venezuela.

The world's third-biggest oil importer's purchase of Iraqi oil surged by about a quarter to about 171,000 bpd, the data showed.

Imports from the UAE fell 5.4% from July to about 620,000 bpd, while those from Saudi Arabia, which offered crude oil from ports outside the Strait, rose 1.5% to 328,000 bpd.

INDIA'S RUSSIAN OIL IMPORTS FELL 16.5% IN AUGUST FROM THE PREVIOUS MONTH TO ABOUT 2.1 MILLION BARRELS PER DAY (BPD)

India boosted purchases of Russian oil after US-Iran tensions led to a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz.

However, India's Russian oil imports are estimated to decline to 1.9 million bpd in September, according to preliminary data from Kpler.

Indian refiners are tapping spot markets for October and November supplies as they fear they may have to reduce purchases from Moscow to protect India's wider economic interests if U.S. President Donald Trump decides to impose up to a 100% tariff on countries buying Russian oil.

New Delhi, which is negotiating a trade deal with Washington, has said it remains "firmly committed" to ensuring energy security for its people and would continue to source supplies from diverse sellers based on market dynamics.

Overall, India's oil imports fell 8.8% in August to 4.44 million bpd, the data showed.

India rejects Pak's bid to rake up IWT issues with UNSC

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NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday rejected Pakistan's effort to take up the Permanent Court of Arbitration's order setting aside New Delhi's decision to suspend the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) with the UN Security Council and said this was another attempt by Islamabad at "distorting the reality".

Late last month, India had rejected the Permanent Court of Arbitration's order setting aside New Delhi's decision to suspend the treaty in 2025 on the grounds that it had never recognised the existence of the "illegally constituted" court in The Hague. India also rejected the court's order on interim measures prohibiting New Delhi from building certain structures of the Ratle hydroelectric project in Jammu and Kashmir.

Following this, Pakistan's foreign minister Ishaq Dar had sent a letter to the Permanent Court of Arbitration's ruling to the UN Security Council in an effort to bolster Islamabad's position on the issue. However, external affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal dismissed Pakistan's efforts, describing it as part of a "malicious propaganda" campaign.

"Pakistan has a habit of misrepresenting facts and propagating falsehoods to serve its malicious propaganda," Jaiswal told a regular media brief-

ing. "For starters, the so-called ruling is not a ruling by the Permanent Court of Arbitration, as sought to be projected by the Pakistan minister, it is a ruling by an illegally constituted court."

India perceives these efforts as "just one more attempt by Pakistan at distorting the reality", he said. "Our position on this issue is very clear and we have reiterated it several times," he added.

Soon after the court in The Hague issued its ruling last month, the external affairs ministry said India's decision to hold the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance remains in force.

India suspended the Indus Waters Treaty as part of a package of punitive diplomatic and economic measures unveiled in April 2025 in response to the Pahalgaon terror attack, which was carried out by a proxy of Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT).

Pakistan, which has said any denial of its share of waters of cross-border rivers will be considered an act of war, approached the court in The Hague in March this year to determine the status of the water-sharing treaty.

The external affairs ministry had said the "so-called Court of Arbitration" was illegally constituted in breach of the terms of the Indus Waters Treaty and noted that New Delhi had rejected all its pronouncements.



Asian Games get on track, and field

As the track and field events get underway at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games from today, here's a look at some of the top Indians to watch out for.

ANCY SOJAN (WOMEN'S LONG JUMP)

Ancy Sojan broke one of the longest-standing records in Indian athletics when she leaped to 6.88m at the Inter-State athletics in Odisha earlier this year. Ancy surpassed Anju Bobby George's 22-year-old national record of 6.83m set at the Athens Olympics and has now set sight on the 7m mark.

AVINASH SABLE (MEN'S 3,000M STEEPLECHASE)

He made an impressive return to steeplechase from an ACL injury a year ago just in time to prove his form and fitness for the Asian Games. The defending champion in steeplechase clocked 8min 32.39sec at the India Athletics Final Series at the JLN Stadium in New Delhi earlier this month. He hasn't competed in top international meets for the last one year but given his experience, Sable could make heads turn.

PARUL CHAUDHARY (WOMEN'S 3,000M STEEPLECHASE/5,000M)

An experienced campaigner, Parul Chaudhary will go into the Asian Games as defending champion in 5,000m and silver medalist in the women's 3,000m steeplechase. At the Asian Championships last year, she won silver in both events. Having bettered her national record in 5,000m (15:04.26), the 31-year-old would be expected to finish on the podium.

GULVEER SINGH (MEN'S 5,000M/10,000M)

Gulveer's sensational showing at the Glasgow CWG where he won silver in 10,000m and bronze in 5,000m has raised expectations. The Armyman has shown great form in recent times. He won gold in both events at the Asian Championships last year and it puts him as a strong gold medal contender in both races in Aichi-Nagoya.

MURALI SREESHANKAR (MEN'S LONG JUMP)

The 27-year-old finished with a silver at CWG 2026 behind former world champion Tajay Gayle. Sreeshankar, who missed the Paris Olympics with a left patellar tendon rupture, won the World Athletics Continental meet after Glasgow with a jump of 8.38m, his best since his comeback from injury.

YASHVIR SINGH (MEN'S JAVELIN)

For some years now, India's buzz at most multi-discipline sporting events has grown around Neeraj Chopra, the country's two-time Olympic and Worlds medalist. He is out of the Games with an ankle injury and the onus now rests on Yashvir and Rohit Yadav. Yashvir won bronze at the Glasgow CWG last month.

DID YOU KNOW?

PT Usha holds the record for most medals won in a single Asian Games by an Indian — 4 gold and 1 silver at the 1986 Seoul Games. She won gold in 200m, 400m, 400m hurdles, 4x400m relay and the silver in 100m.

INDIA AT ASIAN GAMES IN ATHLETICS

Year	City	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total
1951	New Delhi	10	12	12	34
1954	Manila	5	3	6	14
1958	Tokyo	5	2	2	9
1962	Jakarta	5	5	4	14
1966	Bangkok	5	1	5	11
1970	Bangkok	4	5	5	14
1974	Tehran	4	7	5	16
1978	Bangkok	8	7	3	18
1982	New Delhi	4	9	8	21
1986	Seoul	2	4	9	15
1990	Beijing	4	2	6	12
1994	Hiroshima	2	1	3	6
1998	Bangkok	6	2	7	15
2002	Busan	7	6	4	17
2006	Doha	4	4	9	17
2010	Guangzhou	5	5	5	15
2014	Incheon	3	8	13	24
2018	Jakarta -Palembang	8	9	3	20
2022	Hangzhou	6	14	9	29

Gold 85

Silver 102

Bronze 96

Weak rains leave trail of wilted crop, dry plots

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NEW DELHI: When Lal Singh Thakur sowed soybean on his three-acre farm in Pipla, Nagpur, in July, he was hoping the monsoon would revive his crop. Instead, the rains failed, his 300-foot borewell dried up and the soybean plants withered.

"I will not earn a penny from it this year. I had invested ₹40,000 in it," said Thakur, who used soybean saved from last year's harvest as seed.

Last year, he harvested about 18 quintals from the same land and earned around ₹1 lakh after expenses.

This year, he does not expect to recover his investment. The field is now so dry, he said, that even animals have little to graze on.

Thakur is not alone. His misfortune in Maharashtra's Vidarbha region is a reflection of the stress being reported from several rain-dependent farming areas as the southwest monsoon draws to a close with a 15% rainfall deficit across the country. India received 703.7mm of rain against the normal 827.2mm between June 1 and September 21, according to the latest India Meteorological Department (IMD) data.

The deficit has been particularly sharp in several agricultural regions. Rainfall is 27%

below normal in the south peninsula, 26% below normal in east and northeast India and 10% below normal in northwest India. Marathwada has recorded a 37% deficit. Telangana 21%, coastal Andhra Pradesh 37%, while Karnataka's three main subdivisions have deficits ranging from 28% to 32%.

The India Drought Monitor, maintained by the Water and Climate Lab at IIT Gandhinagar, puts 52.5% of the country's area in drought category, compared with 47.5% classified as normal. Maharashtra is among the states with the largest drought-affected areas, at 83.5%, according to the monitor.

The impact on crops, however, is unlikely to be uniform.

Former agriculture secretary Devesh Chaturvedi said well-irrigated areas such as Punjab, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh are unlikely to see significant yield declines. The bigger impact is expected in drought-affected parts of Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Karnataka, where farmers remain more dependent on rainfall.

"Overall output will be lower than last year," Chaturvedi said, pointing out that 2025-26 was a bumper production year.

That assessment is in line with the government's own production target. It has set the



Crops have been sown on 110.4 million hectares, down 1.3% from a year earlier, with paddy acreage down 3.7% and maize acreage down 2.2%.

SAMIR JANA/HT PHOTO

2026-27 kharif production target at 176.16 million tonnes, only marginally higher than the 176.04 million tonnes produced in 2025-26.

The Centre has also set a paddy procurement target of 70.864 million tonnes for the 2026-27 Kharif Marketing Season, beginning October 1. This is lower than the 72.074 million tonnes procured as of August 5 this year and the 70.885 million tonnes procured during the 2024-25 season.

Chaturvedi, however, said a lower harvest should not translate into a food shortage. India already produces a substantial

surplus of several crops, he said, and should have enough food to meet domestic requirements.

Farmers adjusted acreage in response to the weather

Crops have been sown on 110.4 million hectares, down 1.3% from a year earlier, with paddy acreage down 3.7% and maize acreage down 2.2%.

But the decline in acreage has so far been much smaller than the rainfall deficit. A recent CRISIL report said kharif sowing stood at 98% of normal area and 96% of last year's level.

The recovery in rainfall during July helped water-intensive

crops such as rice and sugarcane recover after a dry June. In rain-stressed areas, farmers also shifted towards shorter-duration crops such as maize, bajra and moong, CRISIL said.

This has shifted the main risk from acreage to yield. Rainfall was about 35.4% below normal in June before recovering to around 1% above normal in July. The deficit widened again to about 16% in August, while September rainfall has remained weak and uneven.

CRISIL identified cotton, bajra, maize, tur, groundnut and soybean as being particularly vulnerable because of deficient

rainfall and limited irrigation coverage in some regions. Groundnut acreage, for instance, recovered in Gujarat, but only 49.3% of the state's groundnut area was irrigated in 2024-25, leaving parts of the crop exposed to weaker rainfall later in the season.

There is, however, a larger buffer than in the past. Irrigation coverage has risen to about 60% of net sown area in 2024-25, from 48.8% in 2015-16, according to CRISIL.

The crop impact will also differ by variety and region. Paddy acreage has fallen mainly in southern states as farmers moved away from rain-dependent cultivation, while soybean productivity is likely to come under pressure in parts of Maharashtra and Karnataka. Relatively drought-resistant crops such as urad, jowar and bajra, which require less water, could perform better, Chaturvedi said.

For many farmers like Thakur, however, the impact is already visible.

He has not planned his rabi crop because he does not expect enough water to cultivate it. His borewell, which sustained his soybean crop for a while after sowing, has dried up. Thakur said local officials have begun surveys to assess crop losses, but he is not hopeful of receiving state assistance. In Nagpur, he said, large residential societies with borewells reaching about 1,000 feet are the only ones still able to access water.

MY BENGALURU

{ KASTURIRANGAN REPORT ON WESTERN GHATS }

Assembly rejects Centre's 7th draft

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka Assembly on Tuesday unanimously rejected the Centre's latest proposal to declare 20,668 sq km of the Western Ghats an Ecologically Sensitive Area, asking the Union government to keep the notification on hold for a year while the state carries out physical surveys and addresses land and livelihood concerns.

The resolution, moved by chief minister D K Shivakumar during a three day special session on the Kasturirangan report, opposed the seventh draft ESA notification issued by the Centre on July 27, 2026, in its present form. The proposed area covers 1,449 villages in 10 districts of Karnataka.

Shivakumar said the state had attempted to understand concerns of residents before taking its position, including through visits to Udupi, Shivamogga, Chikkamagaluru and Hassan districts. "The Western Ghats are a major natural asset of Karnataka and are vital to biodiversity and ecological balance. At the same time, the concerns of the people living in the region need to be addressed before the ESA notification is finalised," he said.

The resolution said the proposed boundaries had been prepared using satellite data without a joint physical survey and without precise demarcation based on survey numbers.

"The inclusion of agricultural land, plantations, residential houses and public amenities along with forest areas would create problems relating to house construction, division of family properties and inheritance rights," Shivakumar said.

The resolution said the draft also failed to adequately address pending issues involving Bagar Hukum claims, forest rights, deemed forests, land grants, appeals and cases before courts.

The Assembly also objected to the provision under which an entire village could be included in the ESA if one fifth of its area falls within forest limits. The resolution described the method as unscientific and said it had caused considerable discontent among residents.

Karnataka has asked Centre to restrict the ESA designation to notified forest areas and other actual forest land. Agricultural and horticultural land, planta-



Western Ghats are a major natural asset of Karnataka and are vital to biodiversity and ecological balance. At the same time, concerns of the people living in the region need to be addressed before ESA notification is finalised.

DK SHIVAKUMAR, CM

tions, human settlements and areas used for public activities should remain outside the proposed zone, the resolution said.

The state has also asked for existing issues concerning Bagar Hukum claims, forest rights, deemed forests, land grants, appeals and court cases to be taken into account before the final boundaries are determined.

The government plans to conduct physical measurements and identify forests, settlements, agricultural areas and ecologically sensitive zones separately on the basis of survey numbers.

A high level committee headed by a retired judge will oversee the exercise. Revenue and forest officials, representatives of farmers and industry, and forestry and environmental experts and scientists from academic institutions will be part of the panel. The committee will examine the deficiencies in the Kasturirangan report and recommend modifications.

The state will also constitute committees at the gram panchayat level, including elected representatives, to assist the state level panel with the exercise and provide local inputs.

Shivakumar said the government deliberately chose to bring the matter before the legislature rather than settle it only through an administrative decision. "The government should be the voice of the people. We must give value to what people say and to their feelings. That is why we organised a special session and invited a discussion," he said.

The resolution seeks a one

year extension from the Centre to complete the physical survey and submit the state's findings.

It also asks the Union government to formulate guidelines for alternative livelihoods and financial assistance for farmers and workers who may be affected by restrictions resulting from the ESA declaration.

The state asked that Centre refrain from taking a final decision until Karnataka completes its exercise and submits its report. "After the state government submits its report, the Government of India should hold a detailed discussion with the state government on the issue and only thereafter take a final decision," the resolution said.

The Assembly's resolution therefore seeks to replace satellite based demarcation with a survey number level exercise before Karnataka's portion of the Western Ghats is brought under the final ESA notification.

K'taka to appoint senior counsel to present state's stand in Supreme Court

Karnataka will appoint a senior lawyer to present the state's position before Supreme Court on the Centre's notification concerning Kasturirangan report, Shivakumar said on Tuesday.

Responding to a question from Leader of Opposition R Ashoka on National Green Tribunal and implementation of Kasturirangan report, Shivakumar said the state would put forward its position before the SC. "Regarding the notification issued by the Centre in connection with the Kasturirangan report, a senior lawyer will be appointed to clearly present the state's position before the Supreme Court," he said.

He said that, according to the information available to him, the NGT had directed the Centre to take a decision on issuing the final notification in connection with the implementation of the Kasturirangan report.

Shivakumar said the state was not rejecting the recommendations made by the Kasturirangan committee on ecologically sensitive areas in the Western Ghats.

"We are not disrespecting the recommendations made by the Kasturirangan committee regarding ecologically sensitive areas of Western Ghats. Instead, we are requesting they be scientifically revised keeping interests of our state in mind," he said.

CID probe: 60-80 KPSC questions leaked

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BENGALURU: The CID investigation into alleged irregularities in the Karnataka Public Service Commission's veterinary officers recruitment has traced a money trail of about ₹1.52 crore and found evidence suggesting that as many as 60 to 80 questions were leaked to candidates, according to the probe report submitted to the government.

The investigation has so far identified payments running into tens of lakhs of rupees, cash transactions, frozen bank accounts and purchases of jewellery allegedly linked to people being investigated in the case.

"Of the money traced by the CID, ₹92 lakh was deposited into two accounts, one held with Om Lakshmi Souharda Sahakari Sangha in Tilakwadi and another with Kotak Mahindra Bank. The deposits, ranging from ₹1 lakh to ₹10 lakh, were allegedly made by candidates identified in the investigation as Siddharth, Basavaraj V, Mahendra and Niranjana," said an official in the know.

The report also records alleged cash payments by three other candidates. Kiran Gowda is accused of paying ₹10 lakh, Mohammed Sohail ₹20 lakh and Salim Onti ₹30 lakh, according to the officer.

The CID has debit frozen ₹69.2 lakh in the two accounts. A further ₹71.18 lakh has been frozen in the bank accounts of Basavaraj Kannale, identified by investigators as a key suspect and alleged mastermind in the case, and his wife. Investigators also recovered ₹5.76 lakh in cash from Kannale.

The probe has also followed the alleged use of proceeds from the recruitment racket to purchase jewellery. Investigators recovered a diamond and gold necklace valued at about ₹22 lakh, which the report says was allegedly purchased by IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar

CID INVESTIGATION INTO ALLEGED IRREGULARITIES IN VETERINARY OFFICERS RECRUITMENT HAS TRACED A MONEY TRAIL OF ABOUT ₹1.52 CRORE

for his woman friend, Yaashi Jaiswal. The CID has recorded Jaiswal's statement.

Gangwar, a 2016 batch IAS officer, served as KPSC controller of examinations from February 2024 until March 2026. He was transferred to the post of Director of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises in June, the officer added.

Gangwar and Kannale are now in the custody of the Enforcement Directorate, which is conducting a separate investigation into the alleged irregularities. Both had earlier been arrested and questioned by CID.

The CID has questioned 40 candidates so far, including 29 who were named in the first information report, the report said. Investigators have alleged that Kannale approached several candidates either personally or through intermediaries.

The alleged question paper leak forms a central part of the investigation. The CID report says between 60 and 80 questions were leaked to candidates. About five candidates were allegedly given practice in answering the leaked questions.

An intermediary identified as Pawan is alleged to have explained to investigators how the question leaks and practice sessions were organised.

The CID has recovered digital evidence as part of the investigation, including WhatsApp conversations involving Kannale, candidates and intermediaries. Documents connected with the veterinary officers recruitment examination have also been seized.

CM: Considering shutting down KPSC within legal framework

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BENGALURU: Chief minister D K Shivakumar on Tuesday said Karnataka was examining whether Karnataka Public Service Commission should be shut down, a day after the high court ordered a fresh investigation into alleged irregularities in the selection of veterinary officers.

"There are increasing scams in KPSC. I am discussing with experts whether it can be shut down within the legal framework," Shivakumar told reporters in Bengaluru.

The remarks came after the Karnataka high court constituted a five-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) to conduct a de novo probe into alleged irregularities in recruitment of 400 veterinary officers through the KPSC. The court declined a request for a CBI investigation and directed the SIT, headed by IPS officer Alok Kumar, to complete its probe within 100 days. It must submit progress reports every 30 days.

Shivakumar welcomed the court's decision to constitute the SIT but objected to the state not having a role in choosing investigators. "I welcome the high court directing the formation of an SIT. The Enforcement Directorate is also investigating. But our police department is also conducting the investigation very well," he said.

He said HC could have monitored the state police investigation instead of determining composition of the new team. "The court directing an SIT investigation is right. But the freedom to appoint the investigating officers should have been given to the state government. We have received calls from Delhi and other states regarding this. I will seek the opinion of



Karnataka CMD K Shivakumar and deputy CM G Parameshwara during state legislative special assembly session in Bengaluru.

legal experts," the CM said.

The high court has directed the CID to hand over all records, documents, electronic evidence and other material collected during its investigation to SIT. The team has been authorised to pursue evidence involving other people, offences or transactions connected to the case and has also been directed to cooperate with the Enforcement Directorate, which is separately investigating the alleged financial aspects of the case.

The veterinary recruitment case is one of the several controversies surrounding KPSC. The petitions before the high court alleged large scale irregularities in the recruitment of 400 veterinary officers, including manipulation of marks and examination material. The suspended KPSC chairman Shivashankarappa S Sahukar is among those accused in the case. The court said recruitment malpractice involving manipulation of marks, tampering with answer scripts or OMR sheets and purchased selections affected the constitutional guarantee of equality in public employment.

The investigation has also widened beyond the recruitment process. The CID has

questioned candidates in the case and examined alleged financial links involving candidates, middlemen and officials. Suspended IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar, who had served as KPSC controller of examinations, has been arrested in connection with the case, while the ED is examining the alleged money trail.

Shivakumar said investigators had already gathered documents that could reveal the extent of the alleged wrongdoing. "Some fraudsters have entered KPSC. We selected officials by placing our trust in them, and they are doing all this. The members there have opened a shop of their own. Our police officers have collected the documents. One day, everything will come out," he said.

The CM linked the issue to the prospects of thousands of candidates who depend on government recruitment examinations. "We have to think about the future of our children. That is why Siddaramaiah reduced the number of members in the KPSC during his tenure. If we select officials transparently and send them there with trust, they are also doing such things," Shivakumar said.

Milk producers' unions protest



Members of various milk producers' unions stage a protest demanding an immediate price hike of ₹8 per litre in Bengaluru on Tuesday. Karnataka's cooperative milk producers' unions have urged the state government to raise Nandini milk procurement and retail prices by ₹8 to ₹10 per litre, citing rising input and production costs. A delegation of the milk unions also met chief minister D K Shivakumar at Vidhana Soudha on Tuesday and submitted the demand.

PM Modi unveils Sri Vishwesha Tirtha Swami centenary logo

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday met Sri Vishwaprasanna Tirtha Swami of Udupi's Sri Pejavar Adhokshaja Mathain in New Delhi. The PM unveiled the logo of the birth centenary celebrations of Padma Vibhushan Yatikula Chakravarti Sri Vishwesha Tirtha Swami. He said that his life of devotion, learning, and service continues to inspire countless people.



PM Narendra Modi being felicitated at the event in New Delhi on Tuesday.

Modi added that the various initiatives being undertaken in the run-up to his birth centenary will further carry forward his noble ideals.

"Met Sri Sri Vishwaprasanna Tirtha Swamiji of Sri Pejavar Adhokshaja Matha, Udupi, along with other dignitaries. Unveiled the logo of the Birth Centenary Celebrations of Padma Vibhushan Yatikula Chakravarti Sri Vishwesha Tirtha Swamiji. His life of devotion, learning and service continues to inspire countless people. The various initiatives being undertaken in the run-up to his birth centenary will further carry forward his noble ideals," Modi said in a post on X.

{ 2012 DHARMASTHALA RAPE AND MURDER CASE }

DNA on clothing opens fresh probe into case

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BENGALURU: Hair belonging to people other than Santosh Rao were found on the victim's clothing, providing DNA material that the Supreme Court said can still be compared with samples from suspects identified in a fresh investigation into the Dharmasthala rape and murder case.

The evidence, recovered from Material Object 15, identified as the victim's churidar top, was cited by the Supreme Court while rejecting the argument that the passage of time had made a meaningful reinvestigation impossible.

Vinod J Lakkappan, assistant director of the Toxicology Division, Madivala, Bengaluru, who conducted the DNA analysis, told the court that the hairs found on the garment did not belong to Rao.

Lakkappan also testified that blood samples could still be collected from people who emerge as suspects and compared with the DNA material recovered from the clothing.

The Supreme Court held that this left useful forensic evidence available for the fresh investigation. The court also took note of eight potential witnesses whom the earlier investigating agencies had failed to identify and examine.

The petitioners had named the eight in their plea, following which the apex court ordered protection for them on April 29, 2026. The Karnataka government traced and protected them within three weeks.

The court questioned why the earlier investigations by Belthangady police, the Criminal Investigation Department and the Central Bureau of Investigation had not identified and examined the eight people when the state government was able to locate them within weeks.

The Supreme Court has directed Karnataka to constitute a new Special Investigation Team, headed by a senior state police officer and comprising officers with expertise in modern technology.

Officers who were part of the earlier investigations cannot be

SUPREME COURT TOOK NOTE OF EIGHT POTENTIAL WITNESSES WHOM THE EARLIER INVESTIGATING AGENCIES HAD FAILED TO IDENTIFY AND EXAMINE

included in the new team. The SIT has been given three months to complete its investigation.

The court has excluded Santosh Rao from the fresh probe because the Sessions Court acquitted him on June 16, 2023. The trial court had found no material connecting him to the crime and held that the prosecution had failed to prove the charges.

The Supreme Court held that Rao cannot be investigated or prosecuted again for the same offence under Article 20(2) of the Constitution and Section 300 of the CrPC. It noted that the per-

son prosecuted had been "held to be incapable of committing the offence".

The SIT has nevertheless been allowed to investigate the roles of Malik Jain, Dhieraj Jain and Uday Jain. The court made clear that this should not be understood as expressing even a prima facie opinion about their roles.

The SC also took issue with the manner in which the earlier investigation was conducted. "Clearly, the investigation has been conducted in a manner that causes injustice to the victim," it said, adding that the possibility of the actual perpetrator or perpetrators manipulating the investigation could not be ruled out.

The court further said that "such lax and improper investigation gives premium to the Investigating Officers who failed to do their job correctly and diligently."

It also said that while an injustice to a person falsely charged could be compensated, "injustice to the victim who was brutally raped and then murdered can never be compensated."

The court referred to material suggesting that people who had information about the crime had not been properly examined. It noted that witnesses and others who came forward had maintained that Rao was not the culprit and had alleged that investigators were attempting to shield the actual perpetrators.

The Supreme Court's order follows the Karnataka high court's 2024 decision, which accepted the need for reinvestigation but rejected the plea on the ground that evidence was unlikely to remain available because of the passage of time.

Home minister Priyank Karge said the state government would discuss the Supreme Court's directions with chief minister Siddaramaiah and D K Shivakumar before deciding on further action.

"The Supreme Court's order has not officially come out yet. It might be released by this evening. I will speak and discuss this with chief minister DK Shivakumar, and we will take whatever action needs to be taken," Karge said.

K'taka facing severe drought amid financial crisis, claims LoP Ashoka

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BENGALURU: Karnataka is reeling from a severe drought amid a financial crisis, with the state government facing constraints in funding key relief measures such as drinking water, fodder and borewell repairs, Leader of Opposition R Ashoka claimed on Tuesday.

Participating in a debate on the drought situation in the legislative assembly, the BJP leader cited a September 17 finance department note to claim that the state had exhausted its borrowing capacity and would find it difficult to finance new schemes announced in the 2026-27 budget.

He said the state was facing a "financial drought" alongside the natural calamity and alleged that the government had failed to take timely precautionary measures despite warnings of deficient monsoon rainfall.

"Drought has struck the state, and farmers are migrating. On the one hand, there is a drought,



R Ashoka

and on the other, the government treasury is empty, and there is a financial drought," Ashoka said.

He claimed the finance department had pointed out that schemes worth ₹1,000 crore had not been included in the budget and that Karnataka's fiscal deficit stood at 2.95 per cent, against the 3 per cent limit under the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Act.

The state's revenue deficit stood at ₹22,952 crore, while outstanding liabilities as a percentage of GDP had reached 24.94 per cent against the permissible 25 per cent, he said.

Ashoka alleged that the state had effectively exhausted its borrowing capacity and questioned how the government would mobilise resources for drought relief and other new schemes. "Where is the money for drought relief and drinking water?" he asked, adding even funds earmarked for other departments, including SCSIP and TSP allocations, might have to be diverted for relief.

The LoP said pending bills for government works amounted to around ₹2 lakh crore, while pending bills in four departments, including Public Works and Water Resources, stood at ₹36,136 crore.

He alleged that transport, irrigation and power corporations were facing financial difficulties.

Ashoka said the finance department's communication, which he claimed exposed the government's inability to fund fresh announcements, was dated September 17, before the Cabinet meeting in Mangaluru that decided on several projects.

SOUTH REGION

{ CMRL-EXALOGIC BRIBERY CASE }

Keralam orders inquiry against Vijayan and kin

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Keralam government on Tuesday ordered an inquiry against Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and his son-in-law and CPI(M) MLA PA Mohammed Riyas in connection with the allegations of bribery in the CMRL-Exalogic case, state home minister Ramesh Chennithala said.

The order comes weeks after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) wrote to DGP Ravada Chandrasekhar seeking the registration of an FIR under the Prevention of Corruption Act against Vijayan and others based on the "evidence" it had gathered. Chennithala said that his office had sought legal opinion from the Attorney General on the ED report, following which he held consultations with chief minister VD Satheshaan on Tuesday.

"The ED has the right (to seek the registration of a case). Under section 66(2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), it must share its information with a law-enforcement agency. In the Vijay Madanal vs Union of India case, the Supreme Court made it clear that a law-enforcement agency, upon receipt of such communication, cannot ignore it. The government has to act legally," Chennithala told reporters. The state minister added that the police are bound to conduct a preliminary inquiry before registering an FIR in a case where a cognisable offence is not revealed. He said that the nature of the probe will be decided by the DGP.

Officials familiar with the matter said a special investigation team under the Crime Branch wing of the state police is likely to probe the case.

Meanwhile, Riyas said he is ready to face any inquiry. "I have not committed any crime. Therefore, I am confident of facing any level of inquiry," he said. He pointed out that the Congress was among the few non-BJP parties to oppose ED probes and the way the agency collects evidence and testimonies across the country. "So when a Con-



LoP Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and CPI(M) MLA PA Mohammed Riyas



gress-led state government is opening an inquiry by believing an ED report, the society will certainly discuss it," he said.

Vijayan did not respond to requests for comment on the police inquiry. However, on September 9, at a political event, Vijayan had termed the ED's allegations against him as "shameful and ludicrous".

"I am an open book and the people here are aware of the life I led. Your lies, hatred and revenge cannot destroy my personal life. Such claims cannot destroy me or the party. We will fight them legally and politically," he had said.

Earlier this month, ED had written to the state DGP seeking the registration of a corruption case against Vijayan and others based on "evidence" it found of the former chief minister receiving kickbacks from Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL), a Kochi-based minerals manufacturer, through Veena T and the now-defunct Exalogic Solutions. The central agency has alleged that Vijayan received bribes amounting to ₹3.28 crore from the private firm in exchange for favours in the minerals sector. The agency claimed that the funds were routed abroad through "hawala channels" with the help of Riyas.

The allegations are linked to the CMRL monthly payments case in which Veena and Exalogic allegedly received ₹2.78 crore from CMRL even though no services were rendered. The Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) has also probed the case and filed a preliminary report in a court in Ernakulam district, arraigning Veena and top officials of CMRL in the case.

What led up to this?

2019

• **January:** Income Tax raids premises of minerals manufacturer CMRL in Kochi, finds documentation of bribes to politicians

2023

• **June:** Income Tax Interim Settlement Board finds Exalogic, run by Veena, received Rs 1.72 crore from CMRL sans services

2024

• **January 13:** Corporate Affairs Ministry announces inquiry against Exalogic Solutions

• **January 31:** Inquiry handed over to Serious Fraud Investigations Office (SFIO)

• **February 16:** Karnataka HC dismisses Veena's plea seeking quashing of SFIO probe

• **March 27:** ED registers case against Veena T, Exalogic, CMRL officials

• **May 6:** Vigilance court in Trivandrum rejects Cong MLA's petition for court-monitored probe into case

• **July 29:** Vijayan made no personal gains from CMRL - Exalogic transactions, state tells Kerala HC

2025

• **March 28:** Kerala HC dismisses plea seeking vigilance inquiry against Vijayan

April 3:

SFIO files prosecution complaint against Veena, top CMRL officials for corporate fraud

August 13:

Kerala HC denies BJP leader Shone George's plea for access to SFIO documents in case

2026

• **May 26:** Kerala HC dismisses pleas filed by CMRL officials against ED probe into case

• **May 27:** ED conducts searches at premises linked to Veena in Thiruvananthapuram, Kozhikode, finds hand-written notes, digital evidence

• **June 5:** Kerala HC division bench upholds single judge order allowing ED probe into case

• **June 8:** Kerala HC allows ED access to SFIO documents in case

• **June 9:** ED summons Veena T for questioning in CMRL monthly payoffs case

• **August 18:** ED searches 8 locations in Kozhikode, claims evidence of hawala channels

• **September 8:** Keralam DGP receives letter from ED seeking FIR against Pinarayi, Veena, Riyas under Prevention of Corruption Act

September 22: Keralam govt orders inquiry

KERALA HC GRANTS BAIL TO NEWS CHANNEL EXEC IN EXCISE CASE

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala high court on Tuesday granted bail to Reporter TV managing director Anto Augustine in the excise case against him for possession of liquor beyond permissible limits at his home in Wayanad district.

Justice Kausar Edappagath passed the order on the petition for bail by Augustine's counsel, after noting that recovery in the case had already been made and that the accused did not have criminal antecedents.

Excise officials had seized around 67 litres of liquor, including foreign-made foreign liquor, Indian-made foreign liquor and wine, during raids conducted on September 16 at Augustine's home in Muttill in Wayanad district.

Augustine has been charged under sections 55(a), 55(i) and 58 of the Kerala Abkari Act.

The liquor seizure took place as part of statewide raids in the probe into alleged irregularities in connection with the failed Messi planned visit of Messi and the Argentine football team to the state, an event which did not materialise.

Former staffer arrested over Veeramani's video

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: A former employee at Pcoso-accused granite baron R Veeramani's firm was arrested on Tuesday after he was found in possession of a video showing the industrialist allegedly acting inappropriately with a girl, the Central Crime Branch (CCB) of Tamil Nadu police said.

According to police, the accused, identified as Ganeshan, worked at Gem Granite company for 23 years and managed Veeramani's financial transactions.

A senior police officer aware of the investigation said Ganeshan was also instrumental in selling the 84-year-old granite baron's East Coast Road property to certain people who helped him evading arrest in the case.

In a statement, the CCB said, "Ganeshan, who worked for 23 years at Gem Granites and is currently employed at another private firm, was arrested for having a video on his mobile phone showing Veeramani acting inappropriately with a young girl and failing to report it to the police."

INVESTIGATORS SAID GANESAN WAS KEY IN THE SALE OF VEERAMANI'S PROPERTIES TO PEOPLE WHO HELPED HIM EVADE ARREST

He was produced before the court and remanded in Puzhal Central Prison, the CCB said.

On August 29, Veeramani and his associates Shanthi and her husband Mahandra Simhan, were arrested in a Pcoso case for sexually assaulting a minor. The police have confirmed that the girl in the video in question was the minor linked to the case. Police said they would investigate who had sent the "explicit" video to Ganesan and why he failed to inform the police.

The police are trying to verify a claim by a social media user that Veeramani's East Coast Road property was sold at ₹120 crore and another one in Ooty at ₹10 crore, and that the money was paid to some people, including police officers, media persons and political personalities,

to help him in the case. Additional commissioner of police (South) Narenthiran Nayar has been appointed to lead a team of police officials in order to conduct a probe in the alleged financial transactions. To conduct investigation in the alleged sexual crimes, another team has been formed under the leadership of additional commissioner of police, central crime branch, PC Thennmozhi.

Police have also confirmed that they have summoned the person who is the son of an officer bearer of railway employees federation. It is alleged that the son was involved in financial transaction of the aforementioned properties, which have taken place during the investigation period.

According to the police, the case was booked the case on October 7, 2025 following a complaint received on October 6, 2025. In February 2026, the police preferred to drop the case citing lack of evidence. However, a special court directed them to conduct a fresh probe.

HT reached out to the promoters of GEM Group of Companies and their legal team but received no response.

35-yr-old man held for setting woman ablaze



Police officers outside the district hospital in Tiruvallur where the attack on the woman took place on Tuesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: A 35-year-old man was arrested on Tuesday for allegedly throwing petrol on a 26-year-old woman and setting her ablaze, leaving her seriously injured, at the district government hospital in Tamil Nadu's Tiruvallur, police said.

Tiruvallur district is located about 50 km to the west of Chennai.

According to police, the incident took place on Monday night when the assailant, identified as 35-year-old Prakash set ablaze Rajeshwari, who works as a temporary employee at the

hospital. The attack took place as Rajeshwari was leaving the hospital premises, said officers.

She suffered around 50% burn injuries and is under treatment at the Kilpauk Government Medical College Hospital in Chennai, police said.

Meanwhile, Prakash was caught in Madhavaram early Tuesday after he was shot in the leg when he allegedly tried to attack police with a sickle, police said. An officer said investigation was on to determine whether the attack was due to a personal dispute.

Prakash was admitted to a hospital and police are questioning him.

CPI(M) alleges Congress-BJP nexus spurred inquiry, BJP calls for VACB to take over probe

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The CPI(M) on Tuesday alleged a "Congress-BJP conspiracy" behind the UDF government's move to order an inquiry against Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan and his son-in-law CPI(M) MLA PA Mohammed Riyas in the CMRL monthly payoffs case.

The preliminary police inquiry, announced by home minister Ramesh Chennithala, was based on the Enforcement Directorate report claiming "evidence of bribery and use of hawala channels to route money abroad" against Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and Riyas.



CPI(M) state secretary MV Govindan addresses an LDF protest event near the Secretariat in Thiruvananthapuram on Tuesday. PH

The CPI(M) alleged that the ED had "coerced" people to file statements against Vijayan and Riyas and that many such witnesses had moved courts to withdraw their statements.

"It is unheard of that an inquiry is being ordered based on statements in the ED report that stand withdrawn. It is clear that Pinarayi Vijayan and Riyas are being targeted politi-

cally," said CPI(M) state secretary MV Govindan at a press briefing.

"We are not scared of the probe and we will fight it legally and politically. The probe is a result of a conspiracy between the Congress and the BJP," he added.

BJP MLA V Muraleedharan called for the inquiry to be handed over to the Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) instead of Crime Branch.

"When Income Tax department, SFIO and ED have probed the case and found evidence, what's the need for a preliminary inquiry by the Crime Branch. This points to the UDF reaching a compromise with the LDF," he said.

Vizag man absconds after girlfriend's death

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HYDERABAD: A man from Visakhapatnam is allegedly absconding after bringing his girlfriend's body to Osmania General Hospital in Hyderabad on Tuesday, police said, adding that a murder case was registered and a probe launched.

The couple were found to have checked in at a hotel at Madhapur on Monday afternoon, said a police officer.

The deceased was identified as Sharon Nikhitha Topno, a private employee also from Visakhapatnam. Her boyfriend, identified as Srinivasa Ravi Teja, left the hospital shortly after Sharon was declared dead and switched off his phone. "On Tuesday morning, we received information from Apollo Hospital, Kothaguda, that the woman was brought to the hospital in an unconscious condition by her boyfriend Ravi Teja, with the

assistance of the hotel staff," a statement from Madhapur police said.

Investigators reached the scene and noticed signs of injuries and swelling on the woman's face and head. Officers inspecting the couple's hotel room reportedly found blood stains on the walls and bedsheet. A Clues Team was called to the spot to collect forensic evidence. Empty beer and whisky bottles were also reportedly recovered from the room.

The woman's body was sent for post-mortem examination. The police are suspecting that the couple may have had a serious argument that escalated into assault.

An analysis of Ravi Teja's mobile phone signals indicated that he was last located in the vicinity of Secunderabad Railway Station, said police, adding that they were also examining CCTV footage from the hotel and its surroundings.

{ AHEAD OF POSSIBLE ONSET OF CYCLONE ARNAB }

Andhra govt steps up cyclone preparedness

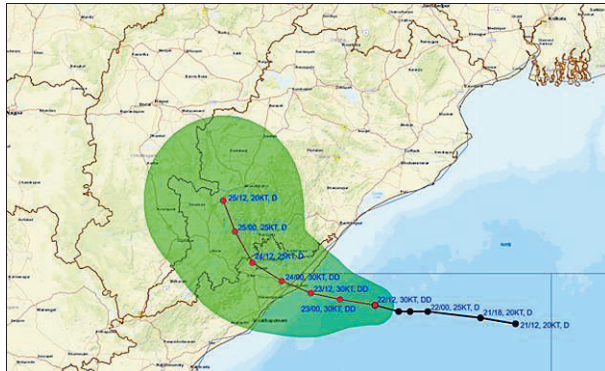
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HYDERABAD: The Andhra Pradesh government has stepped up preparedness to face the impact of a possible cyclonic storm, named Arnab, on the north-coastal districts as a depression over the west-central and adjoining northwest Bay of Bengal is moving westwards towards the Andhra Pradesh-Odisha coast, officials said.

In a bulletin on Tuesday, the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Amaravati said the system is likely to intensify into a deep depression within the next 12 hours and bring heavy to very heavy rainfall, gusty winds and thunderstorms to several parts of the state.

On Tuesday morning, the depression was moving westwards at around 18 kmph during the past six hours and was located around 200 km south-east of Gopalpur in Odisha, 200



IMD said that the prevailing depression was expected to move west-northwestwards and intensify further in depth. SPLARRANGEMENT

km east-southeast of Kalangapatnam in Andhra Pradesh, 210 km south of Puri and 290 km east of Visakhapatnam. "The system is expected to move west-northwestwards and intensify into a deep depression over the west-central and adjoining northwest Bay of Bengal during the next 12 hours. It is expected to cross the

coast between Visakhapatnam and Gopalpur between September 23 night and the early hours of September 24."

The bulletin predicted heavy to very heavy rainfall at many places, with extremely heavy rainfall at isolated places, over coastal Andhra in the next 24 hours. Thunderstorms accom-

panied by lightning are likely at isolated places with gusty winds reaching up to 60 kmph.

On September 24, heavy to very heavy rainfall is likely at isolated places over Coastal Andhra Pradesh and Yanam, along with thunderstorms and lightning. Strong winds of 50-60 kmph.

Minister for home and disaster management Vangalapati Anitha, who reviewed the situation on Tuesday, urged people to remain alert and directed officials to take all precautionary measures to prevent loss of life and property. She instructed authorities to keep control rooms operational round the clock and continuously monitor the weather situation. She advised people to stay away from trees, large hoardings and dilapidated structures, particularly during periods of strong winds.

Srikakulam district has already been receiving widespread rainfall, prompting the administration to remain on

high alert. Agriculture minister Kinjarapu Atchannaidda said in a statement that he was in regular contact with the district administration to monitor the situation.

He directed officials from the Irrigation, Revenue and Electricity departments to remain vigilant and take preventive measures.

"Officials from all departments have been directed to coordinate closely and remain prepared for emergencies. A control room has been established at the Srikakulam Collectorate to monitor the situation. People requiring assistance or further information can contact the control room at 08942-240557," a statement said.

Meanwhile, Srikakulam collector Swapnil Dinkar Pundkar declared a holiday for schools and Anganwadi centres on Wednesday in the district in view of the weather conditions. Similar instructions were issued by Vizianagaram administration.



MK Stalin

CANNOT BE HELD RESPONSIBLE FOR ALL SOCIAL MEDIA POSTS BY DMK WORKERS: STALIN

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BENGALURU: Former Tamil Nadu chief minister and DMK president MK Stalin on Tuesday told the Madras high court that he cannot be held responsible for "every social media post" made by different wings or functionaries of the party.

"Though I am the head of the party and I exercise administrative control over the office-bearers of various wings of the party, I cannot be legally responsible or liable for any individual acts of the members or wings of the party," Stalin said in a counter in a civil defamation suit against him by TVK minister Aadhav Arjuna.

In his counter affidavit filed before Justice K Govindarajan Thilakavadi, Stalin also denied having instructed or approved a post by the DMK IT Wing that had linked Arjuna to a man named John Britto, who was booked by ED in a narcotics case.

Arjuna has sought ₹1 crore in damages from Stalin and the DMK IT Wing, alleging that the June 8 post falsely claimed that Britto, described as the mastermind of a drug-trafficking operation involving the seizure of narcotics worth ₹258 crore, was his close relative. The suit claimed that his relative, P John Britto, had approached the Greater Chennai Commissioner of Police alleging that he was being wrongly identified.

Stalin argued that Arjuna failed to show he suffered any loss of reputation as a result of the post. He further referred to criminal cases involving Arjuna's family members.

"Therefore, the applicant's claim that linking him to an accused person has ruined his reputation is bizarre when there are pending criminal cases against his immediate family members and one criminal case pending against him," he said.

SC to examine penalty for not singing National Song

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday declined to examine whether Vande Mataram should be recognised as the National Song or whether its official rendition should comprise two or six stanzas, saying the choice of national symbols and the aspirations associated with them fall within the remit of an elected government, even as it agreed to examine whether that recognition can carry criminal consequences for a citizen who, on grounds of conscience or religion, chooses not to sing it.

A bench, comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joyymalya Bagchi and V Mohana made it clear that its scrutiny would centre on the penal consequences attached to the 2026 amendment to the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, which extended criminal protection under Section 3 to the "National Song", alongside the National Anthem.

The bench also indicated that the law laid down by the Supreme Court in Bijoe Emmanuel Vs State of Kerala (1986) would continue to govern the field. "Nobody who feels an infraction of Article 25, 26 rights would be subjected to penal consequences," said the bench, adding that "for a conscientious objector, not to recite one or all the stanzas of the national song is not going to subject himself to criminal prosecution."

The observations came on a petition filed by Carnatic vocalist, author and Ramon Magsaysay Award recipient TM Krishna, who has challenged the constitutional validity of the amendment as well as Ministry of Home Affairs directions prescribing the complete six-stanza version of Vande Mataram for specified governmental, ceremonial and cultural occasions.

The amendment substituted Section 3 of the 1971 Act to provide that anyone who intentionally prevents the singing of the National Anthem or National Song, or causes disturbance to an assembly engaged in such singing, can be punished with imprisonment of up to three years, or fine, or both.

Krishna's challenge invokes alleged breach of fundamental rights relating to equality, religious freedom, free speech and right against discrimination, arguing that the amendment and the MHA directions effectively compel citizens to participate in the rendition

SG, Muralidhar trade barbs

NEW DELHI: A heated exchange broke out in the Supreme Court on Tuesday between Solicitor General Tushar Mehta and senior advocate S Muralidhar during the hearing of TM Krishna's challenge to the penal protection accorded to Vande Mataram.

The exchange began after Muralidhar argued that questions concerning a national symbol should ideally evolve through public opinion and consensus rather than through a "top-down" legislative approach.

Intervening, Mehta said: "Law-making is as per the Constitution. Law-making cannot be as per the Naxalites' idea."

Muralidhar immediately objected and sought withdrawal of the expression. "This does not behave a law officer. I have never heard a law officer use this expression," he said.

Mehta declined to withdraw it, saying he was referring to an ideology and not labelling any-

one personally. "I am not sorry about it," he said when Muralidhar pressed for a withdrawal. Senior advocate Sanjay Hegde then remarked: "To think is not to be a Naxalite."

The CJ-led bench then sought to steer the hearing back to the constitutional issue, saying it had not taken note of the exchange.

The discussion, however, resurfaced after Muralidhar, a former high court judge, registered his "strongest protest". The bench then stressed the importance of constitutional institutions and equal rights, with Justice Bagchi observing that even a person alleged to be a "naxalite" and a terrorist retain constitutional rights and must be dealt with through law. "We have continuously fought against extra-constitutional forces," said the bench, emphasising that the credibility of constitutional courts rests on constitutional decision-making and due process.

The bench was not persuaded to examine the larger question at this stage. It noted that "by customs and usage, the National Song has always been mentioned and understood as Vande Mataram", while distinguishing that question from whether a citizen could be prosecuted for refusing to sing it.

Muralidhar argued that for nearly eight decades Vande Mataram had generally been treated as comprising its opening two stanzas for official purposes and questioned the move to prescribe all six stanzas with penal consequences.

"So for the first time, after almost 80 years, they are trying to tell us it's not two stanzas," submitted Muralidhar, arguing that national symbols in a democracy should evolve through public consensus rather than compulsion.

The bench, however, indicated that it was not the court's role to determine the content of national sentiment. "Perhaps this stage is the best to articulate national aspirations," it observed, while making clear that the criminal-law aspect remained open to scrutiny.

The petition contends that the last four stanzas of the six-stanza version contain references to Durga, Lakshmi and Saraswati and that compulsory rendition would infringe the freedom of conscience and religion of those who object to such devotional expression. It further alleges that the State action has a disparate impact on non-Hindu citizens and violates the constitutional guarantee of secularism. The petition also challenges the MHA directions as executive instructions lacking an independent statutory basis, arguing that an office memorandum cannot itself create criminal liability or restrict fundamental rights.

During the hearing, Muralidhar and Solicitor General Tushar Mehta also sparred over the latter's reference to "Naxalites" while defending Parliament's legislative authority. Muralidhar objected strongly to the expression and sought its withdrawal, saying it was inappropriate for a law officer to use such language during a live hearing. The bench stressed the importance of constitutional courts as institutions where even persons accused of serious offences retain legal rights, observing that the credibility of the constitutional system rests on adherence to its processes. The bench ultimately directed that the petition be furnished to the solicitor general and gave the Centre two weeks to file its response.

belonging to the Jehovah's Witnesses faith who had refused to sing the National Anthem because their religious beliefs prohibited them from participating in such singing. The children nevertheless stood respectfully when the anthem was played. The Supreme Court held that their refusal to sing, based on a genuine and conscientious religious belief, did not amount to disrespect to the National Anthem and could not be made a ground for their expulsion.

It is this distinction between respect for a national symbol and compelled participation in its expression that the present bench indicated could apply to the amended law covering Vande Mataram. The issue arose when senior advocate S Muralidhar, appearing for Krishna, argued that the amendment had introduced the expression "National Song" into a penal statute without defining what constituted the National Song or which version of Vande Mataram was covered.

Muralidhar argued that the MHA directions prescribing all six stanzas could not be converted into the basis for criminal prosecution, particularly when the original 1971 law had made no reference to a National Song.

of all six stanzas, including portions that expressly invoke Hindu deities. But the bench drew a clear line between the State's choice of a national symbol and the State's power to enforce participation in it through criminal law. "It is not the remit of the court to second-guess what are the national sentiments and aspirations associated with Vande Mataram. It is for the State," said the bench.

At the same time, it made clear that such State recognition could not override a genuine conscientious objection. "To the extent of penal consequences the Act provides, (that) can be gone into," said the bench, while observing that "in a democracy, State is best placed to give aspiration to the national song. But no conscientious objector can be subjected to penal consequences."

The bench also indicated that it would not enter into a religious adjudication over the lyrics. "From the very beginning of this hearing, we have said we are examining no religion. We are confining only to the legal issue under the Constitution," it said.

The court's reference to Bijoe Emmanuel is significant. In that 1986 judgment, the Supreme Court protected three schoolchildren

RS polls on Oct 16: BJP looks to add 1 seat to tally; BSP faces exit

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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which has 116 MPs in the Rajya Sabha, is all set to gain a seat in the upper House where it is already the single largest party. The Election Commission of India on Tuesday announced the schedule for biennial elections to fill 10 vacancies from Uttar Pradesh and one from Uttarakhand. It will also hold a bypoll for a single seat in West Bengal. All elections will be held on October 16.

Of the 10 seats going to the polls on October 16, the BJP is expected to win 8 and the Samajwadi Party, 2 (a gain of one seat). The BJP is also comfortably placed to win the seats from Uttarakhand which will fall vacant after the completion of



The ECI announced the schedule for biennial elections on Tuesday.

ANI

Nareish Bansal's term on November 25 and West Bengal, which fell vacant on the resignation of TMC's Rukmini Mallick in July.

The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) that has a single member will not have any representation

in the upper House after the elections.

Nine seats in Uttar Pradesh will fall vacant when the terms of the incumbents end on November 25; a tenth, is already vacant, after the resignation of Dinesh Sharma on September 11, after he was appointed L-G, Andaman and Nicobar. His term too was to end on November 25. The nine seats are currently held by Arun Singh, Geeta alias Chandraprabha, Neeraj Shekhar, Brijlal, BL Verma, Seema, and Union minister Hardeep Singh Puri, all from the BJP; Ram Gopal Yadav from the SP; and Ramji from the BSP.

While the SP which has 101 MLAs in the Uttar Pradesh assembly is positioned to win two seats, the BSP, with no MLAs will no longer have a single member in the upper House.

This will be the first time since the 1994 debut of the party that it will have no presence in the Rajya Sabha.

The BJP's tally will increase by one as the party will win the West Bengal seat which has been vacated by Mallik who was sent to the Upper House by the TMC. The BJP-led NDA's tally strength in the house is expected to be 154.

With elections in Uttar Pradesh scheduled for next year all eyes are now on the candidates that the BJP will pick for the upper House. Given the importance of caste in the state, the party's representation of various castes will be keenly scrutinised. A party leader speaking on condition of anonymity said it is likely that the ruling party will not repeat any of the retiring members.

ALLOW PRADHAN TO FIGHT BYPOLL IF GRANTED BAIL: HC

KOLKATA: The Calcutta high court on Tuesday told the West Bengal government to allow Milan Pradhan, the Congress candidate in the Nandigram assembly, to contest the upcoming bypolls on condition of him getting bail in the five cases for which he has been arrested and was sent to judicial custody, according to the Congress leader's counsel.

Pradhan's counsel said a bail petition will be moved in the high court on Wednesday. "The bench of Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya orally remarked to the state to allow Pradhan to contest the by-elections if he gets bail in the cases in which he has already been arrested," Ajitesh Pandey, Pradhan's counsel told HT.

Pradhan was initially arrested on Friday in connection with a 2007 murder case, hours after former chief minister Mamata Banerjee declared that her party would back Pradhan in the October 6 bypolls. He was later shown arrested in four other cases pending against him. At least 11 cases, including six murder cases, were registered against Pradhan in 2007. Banerjee's announcement came after her party's candidate, Sanchita Pradhan Dey, withdrew her nomination. Byelection in Nandigram was necessitated after Adhikari, who won from the assembly seat and Bhabanipur in the May assembly polls, decided to retain Bhabanipur and vacated Nandigram.

HTC

PM to assess ministries during Chintan Shivir

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will chair a two-day Chintan Shivir (brainstorming session) beginning Wednesday with Union ministers to assess the performance of each ministry, review objectives and outcomes, and to strategise for the remainder of the government's third term in office, people aware of the details said.

Sessions at the meeting will see ministries, grouped thematically, presenting an account of their performance, especially in key sectors and also the draft for the upcoming term in office, said one person. "Review meetings are conducted at regular intervals and there is also realtime monitoring of each ministry and department through interactive dashboards on their websites," said the person cited above.

"No aides or bureaucrats will take part in the discussions. There was a briefing earlier that outlined the structure of the brainstorming session, so that appropriate planning could be done," another person privy to the details said.

The meeting comes at a time when the Opposition has stepped up pressure on the government over a host of issues, including the prices of essential items and fuel following the



Narendra Modi

West Asia crisis. It also coincides with the government's ongoing outreach to blunt the anger of the younger demographic, particularly the students who are restive over deficiencies in the examination process and over lack of employment avenues.

According to the second person cited above, the two-day meeting was preceded by the formation of eight-member ministerial groups that were given the mandate to focus on specific areas for self-improvement, administration and communication.

"The agenda of the meeting and background notes have not been circulated. The council of ministers have been divided into groups of 14 and each team has been assigned a leader. For instance, Union minister Piyush Goyal will lead one team which will make a presentation on the theme Vibhaag ki Safalta or successful ministerial functioning," the second person said.

HC WARNS MALLYA AGAINST POSTING DOCS ON PENDING CASE ONLINE

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MUMBAI: The Bombay high court on Tuesday warned Vijay Mallya against putting documents related to his pending criminal case on social media after the Enforcement Directorate objected to the tycoon putting the central agency's affidavit in court on his X account.

ED, in its affidavit filed before the high court, had accepted that it had recovered ₹14,000 crore from Mallya, and paid the amount to the banks he owed money to.

On September 10, in a series of posts on his X account where he has 4.9 million followers, Mallya wrote: "And may I say again, an affidavit filed in Court by the most feared criminal agency the Enforcement Directorate confirms that they handed over ₹14,000 plus crores to the Banks in 2021. Forget what I say if you don't trust me. Focus on what the Enforcement Directorate said."

Taking note of the post, a single-judge bench of justice Milind Jadhav warned Mallya against putting such crucial information on social media while his trial is pending. It also directed the State Bank of India (SBI) to file a fresh affidavit after considering the disclosures made by the agency. The matter will next be heard on October 13.

The high court is hearing Mallya's plea seeking closure of criminal proceedings against him. His original 2020 petition challenged an order passed by a special Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court which had allowed a consortium of lender banks led by the SBI to utilise assets confiscated by ED to recover his unpaid dues.



DKS weighs shutting KPSC amid allegations

BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday said he was examining whether the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) can be shut down, a day after the state's high court ordered a fresh investigation into alleged irregularities in the selection of veterinary officers.

"There are increasing scams in KPSC. I am discussing with experts whether it can be shut down within the legal framework," Shivakumar told reporters in Bengaluru.

CBI: Man booked for fraud on US citizens

NEW DELHI: CBI has booked an Ahmedabad-based man and his aides for allegedly targeting US citizens through technology-enabled fraud and identity theft by impersonating as American federal agents and defrauding over 20 victims of \$6 million, people aware of the matter said.

Bihar principal held for molesting girls

PATNA: A 52-year-old headmaster of a government-run middle school in Bihar's Nawada district has been arrested after several girl students accused him of persistent sexual harassment, inappropriate touching, and voyeurism, police said on Tuesday.

CM: K'taka to place its position before SC on Kasturirangan report

BENGALURU: Karnataka will appoint a senior lawyer to present its position before the Supreme Court on Centre's notification concerning the Kasturirangan report on the Western Ghats, chief minister DK Shivakumar said on Tuesday.

The state assembly also rejected the Centre's proposal to declare 20,668 sq km of the Western Ghats an 'Ecologically Sensitive Area', asking the Centre to keep the notification on hold for a year while the state carries out surveys and addresses land and livelihood concerns.

CMRL case: Probe ordered against Vijayan, kin

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala government on Tuesday ordered an inquiry against leader of opposition Pinarayi Vijayan, Communist Party of India (CPI-M) MLA PA Mohammed Riyaas and Vijayan's daughter Veena T in connection with the allegations of bribery in the CMRL-Exalogic case, state home minister Ramesh Chennithala said.

The inquiry comes weeks after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) wrote to Kerala DGP Ravada Chandrasekhar seeking the registration of an FIR under the Prevention of Corruption Act against Vijayan and others based on the "evidence" it found

while probing the case.

Chennithala said that his office had sought legal opinion from the Attorney General on the ED report, following which he held consultations with chief minister VD Satheesan on Tuesday.

"The ED has the right (to seek the registration of a case). Under section 66(2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), it must share its information with a law-enforcement agency. The Supreme Court made it clear that a law-enforcement agency, upon receipt of such communication, cannot ignore it. The government has

to act legally," Chennithala told reporters. He said that the nature of the probe will be decided by the DGP.

Meanwhile, Riyaas said he is ready to face any inquiry.

"I have not committed any crime. Therefore, I am confident of facing any level of inquiry," he said.

He pointed out that the Congress was among the few non-BJP parties to oppose ED probes and the way the agency collects evidence and testimonies across the country. "So when a Congress-led state government is opening an inquiry by believing an ED report, the society will certainly discuss it," he said.

Vijayan did



not respond to requests for comment on the police inquiry. However, on September 9, at a political event, Vijayan had termed the ED's allegations against him as "shameful and ludicrous".

Earlier this month, ED had wrote to the state DGP seeking the registration of a corruption case against Vijayan and others based on "evidence" it found of the former chief minister receiving kickbacks from Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL), a Kochi-based minerals manufacturer, through his daughter Veena T and the now-defunct IT firm Exalogic Solutions she ran. Meanwhile, the CPI(M) on Tuesday alleged a "Congress-BJP conspiracy" behind the order.

SONIA, RAHUL CONTEND ED'S NATIONAL HERALD CASE IN DELHI HC

NEW DELHI: Senior Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi have opposed before the Delhi high court the Enforcement Directorate's petition against the trial court's refusal to take cognisance of its charge sheet in the National Herald case, contending that the case is the only instance in the country where the agency has proceeded on the basis of a private complaint, using it as the foundation for initiating proceedings under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

In separate affidavits filed on September 18, the leaders asserted "It is writ large that the words 'private complaint' or 'a complaint by a public person/citizen', do not find any place in the entire statutory framework. In this context it is also significant that the instant case provides the only instance where a non-statutory complaint by a private person has been made the foundation of initiating proceedings under the Act..." **SHRUTI KAKKAR**

Shah sets Dec 2029 deadline to uproot drugs trade in India

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NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Tuesday set the end of 2029 as a deadline to eradicate the drug trade in the country, saying that the time has come to deliver a decisive blow against narcotics.

Shah was addressing senior police officers and chiefs of anti-narcotics task forces (ANTFs) from 35 states, Union Territories and central agencies at the inauguration of the 3rd conference of the ANTF heads of states/UTs in New Delhi.

During his address, Shah said it's time to move from meeting to mission mode, from reporting to delivering results, and from seizure to ending the network. To meet the targets and achieve the deadline, he outlined strategies. These include identifying and classifying vulnerable districts based on their role in the drug trade: where drugs are manufac-



Amit Shah

tured or enter the country, those serving as transportation corridors, and those where consumption takes place.

"For the past five years, we have been taking one step after another in an effort to achieve the difficult goal of a drug-free India. The time has now come to deliver a decisive blow against narcotics, which have become the most serious threat to the country and the world, and to achieve victory through collective efforts.... The fight against drugs is the most difficult of all battles, but we cannot abandon

this fight. By December 31, 2029, we will collectively succeed in uprooting the drug trade from India. Neither will we allow a single gram of drugs to enter India, nor will we allow it to go out of India," Shah said at the start of the conference.

Describing the Vision Document 2026-29, launched on June 26—which he likened to the holy book of Bhagavad Gita for all agencies fighting the war against drugs—Shah said the document contains a complete roadmap prepared after taking suggestions from all stakeholders, and it has been given to everyone with definite targets.

"While targets and timelines have been fixed in it, it will also be reviewed periodically. The focal points of this fight have already been identified, and a roadmap has also been prepared at the state level to take intelligence, investigation, financial action and prosecution in one direction," Shah said.

HC warns firm against forcing employees to wear Santa Claus caps

PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad high court has cautioned the management of a retail chain against compelling employees to wear Santa Claus red caps at workplace, observing that such compulsion may hurt the sentiments of people of different faiths and beliefs.

"This type of action is not permitted in the democratic system of the country wherein every citizen is free to follow his/her faith and belief," the court said.

Justice Saurabh Srivastava made the observation while partly allowing an application filed by one Vikram Singh alias Vishwa Vikram Singh who had challenged criminal proceedings initiated against him.

The applicant was facing an FIR under Sections 298 (uttering words, etc., with deliberate intent to wound the religious feelings of any person) and 504

(intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of the peace) of Indian Penal Code (IPC).

As per the allegations, the applicant, working at the retail chain's Agra store, compelled his subordinate employees to wear a Santa Claus cap.

The court warned the applicant and his superior authorities not to repeat this type of instruction. It added that such instructions could disturb the peaceful and harmonious atmosphere of the workplace among their employees.

Counsel for the applicant submitted that Sections 298 and 504 IPC are non-cognizable offences. It was argued that in view of the explanation to section 2(d) CrPC, a police report filed after investigation into a non-cognizable offence is required to be treated as a complaint and cannot proceed as a police case. **JITENDRA SARIN**

NEW FRAMEWORK UNDER ARTICLE 371 FOR LADAKH BEING MADE: CHIEF SECY

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JAMMU: A new framework is being worked out under Article 371 to provide constitutional safeguards suited to the specific requirements of Ladakh, chief secretary of the Union Territory Ashish Kundra said on Tuesday. This comes amid the Union home ministry tentatively fixing another meeting with Leh Apex Body (LAB) and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) over the governance model and constitutional safeguards in the UT.

"A new model is being worked out considering the aspiration of the Ladakhis which does not exist anywhere else in the country," the chief secretary said, during a consultative meeting with members of civil society from Ladakh to discuss key administrative, developmental and political issues, including constitutional safeguards, among others.

Replace Lakhimpur case prosecutor: SC to UP govt

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Uttar Pradesh government to replace the public prosecutor conducting the 2021 Lakhimpur Kheri violence trial against Ashish Mishra, son of former Union minister Ajay Mishra, after being told that crucial witnesses in the case were being given up by the present prosecutor, raising questions over a fair trial. The court, however, dismissed the plea seeking removal of the presiding officer alleged of intimidating one witness, entrusting Allahabad high court to deal with the allegations and an ongoing administrative inquiry against the judicial officer.

Mishra is accused of mowing down farmers gathered to protest against the now-repealed farm laws in 2021 at a time when his father was a central government minister.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant directed the Uttar Pradesh government to replace incumbent prosecutor PB Mishra with a senior public prosecutor having a "fair experience" of conducting trial within two weeks.

The bench, also comprising justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V



Ashish Mishra

Mohana, said, "What is unusual is that on a given date when the witnesses are called, why should the public prosecutor give up those witnesses. They are eyewitnesses. This may not be a very fair prosecution if the PP (public prosecutor) gives up on witnesses."

The order was passed on an application moved by the victims raising concerns over the prosecutor dropping crucial witnesses and the presiding officer, Shiva Kumar Singh of the district and sessions judge, Lakhimpur Kheri, where the trial is pending, of intimidating them by issuing non-bailable warrants against one witness who sought exemption from appearance on medical grounds.

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the victims, pointed out that the presiding judge is facing administrative enquiry initiated by the Allahabad high court after some "disturbing" things

were noted in his court. Bhushan said that the judicial officer in question has invited scrutiny for withdrawing to himself from cases under SC/ST Prevention of Atrocities Act and Narcotics Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act and granting bail and acquitting persons in others.

"There will be gross miscarriage of justice if this presiding officer continues. Even in this case, where a witness produced an illness slip along with a medical certificate, NBW (non-bailable warrant) was issued. The police went to the witness' house and intimidated the family pursuant to which the witness does not want to appear anymore," Bhushan said, requesting the presiding officer to be changed.

The court directed the application to be forwarded to the Allahabad high court chief justice as it said, "The registry of this court is directed to forward a copy of the application to the chief justice of the Allahabad high court with a request to look into the matter to take appropriate remedial action." The court further directed the high court to share the report in a sealed cover pursuant to action taken by the high court chief justice. However, the court refused to move out the presiding judge as it maintained that it is only monitor

ing the present trial and the high court is best placed to deal with allegations against the judicial officer. Further the bench said the judicial officer cannot be faulted for issuing NBW when the top court is constantly issuing orders to expedite the trial. "We can understand the trial court's sense of urgency where the warrant goes to the witness and the prosecutor is unable to produce a witness. You also have been praying for the trial to be expedited. Maybe there is a genuine case where a witness is not there. It is for the public prosecutor to inspire confidence that the witness is not appearing due to genuine difficulty," it said.

A total of eight people were killed on October 3, 2021, in the Lakhimpur Kheri violence. Mishra was arrested within six days of the incident. As per the police charge sheet, the killings were pre-planned as Mishra arrived in a Mahindra Thar SUV along with a convoy of 3-4 vehicles at the site where the farmers were protesting. Infuriated by this act, protesting farmers pulled out three occupants from the car and lynched them. He is currently out on bail on the condition that he cannot stay in Lakhimpur and should not directly or indirectly influence witnesses.

2 accused in Bihar molestation case arrested after encounter

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PATNA: Two main accused in the alleged harassment and molestation of two minor school students in Bihar's Jamui district were arrested on Tuesday after an encounter with police, in which one suffered a bullet injury and the other was injured while trying to flee, police said.

With this, five people, including three minors, have been held in connection with the September 19 incident, which came to light after a video of the episode went viral on social media.

DIG, Munger Range, Rakesh Kumar said, "Nandan Yadav, one of the main accused seen in the video, suffered a bullet injury in his right leg, while his accomplice Hareram Yadav fractured his knee while trying to escape."

He added, "Both of them are undergoing treatment at Sadar hospital. Earlier, we had picked up three minors, who will be dealt with by the juvenile justice board. We may pick up a few more people after interrogating Hareram and Nandan upon their recovery."

"It was Hareram who was seen in the clip with his face wrapped in a scarf, leading the group," he said.

Police said both Nandan and Hareram have criminal antecedents including cases related to illegal sand mining.



An accused who was shot in the leg during an encounter being carried in Jamui on Tuesday. PTI

Jamui SP Biswajeet Dayal said police took suo motu cognisance as neither victim had initially filed a complaint. The victims were traced with the vehicle registration number visible in the video.

Police said one of the three accused minors recorded the incident and shared it with another person before it was circulated widely. The incident has triggered a political exchange in Bihar. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi called it "deeply disturbing" and demanded action under the Pocco Act, while RJD leader Tejaswini Yadav alleged a "collapse of law and order". However, the BJP came out with a social media post claiming, Nandan, who often wore a saffron "gamcha" and sported a red "tilak", was "a devotee of Lalu Prasad", RJD's founding president.

TWO HEADING TO ODISHA SHRINE ASSAULTED; 2 HELD

BHUBANESWAR: Two people travelling to a popular shiva shrine in Odisha's Dhenkanal district were allegedly stopped and assaulted by a group of men, with a video of the incident surfacing days after a similar attack in Bihar, police said on Tuesday, adding that two people have been detained.

According to police, the incident took place on September 18 on the Kapilash-Tangi road in Dhenkanal district but it came to light only on Monday after footage of the alleged assault circulated widely on social media.

The video shows the 26-year-old man, a resident of Cuttack district, being verbally abused and allegedly assaulted by a group of men. It also showed some men behaving inappropriately towards the woman.

Dhenkanal SP Abhinav Sonkar said an investigation was underway. "We have detained two people in this regard and appropriate action will be taken based on the findings of the investigation," he said, adding, a team has been sent to the spot and a nearby village to question people.

DEBABRATA MOHANTY

EX-EMPLOYEE HELD OVER VEERAMANI'S POCSO VIDEO

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: A former employee at Pocco-accused R Veeramani's firm was arrested on Tuesday after he was found in possession of a video showing the industrialist acting inappropriately with a girl, the Central Crime Branch (CCB) of Tamil Nadu police said.

According to police, the accused, Ganeshan, worked at Gem Granite company for 23 years and managed Veeramani's financial transactions. A senior police officer said Ganeshan was also instrumental in selling the 84-year-old granite baron's East Coast Road property to certain people who helped him in evading arrest in the case.

In a statement, the CCB said, "Ganeshan was arrested for having a video on his mobile phone showing Veeramani acting inappropriately with a young girl and failing to report it to the police."

He was remanded in Puzhal Central Prison, the CCB said.

GANGRAPE VICTIM DIES BY SUICIDE; KIN ALLEGE THREATS

JHANSI/KANPUR: A 19-year-old woman died allegedly by suicide on Tuesday following a gang-rape by six people, including three minors, in Uttar Pradesh's Jhansi, police said on Tuesday. Her family has alleged the accused threatened to circulate a video of the crime if she disclosed the incident.

Senior superintendent of police Jhansi Vikas Kumar said five of six accused had been apprehended, while the sixth was absconding.

On Monday, the woman went to a cattle barn for some work when the six accused allegedly caught her and gang-raped her.

"Distressed by the threats to circulate the video, she consumed poison," a family member said. Police said she was brought dead at around 4 am on Tuesday. SSP Kumar said police are investigating the allegations and the circumstances leading to her death.

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MAN SHOOTS WIFE, TWO PRIESTS DEAD DURING PUJA IN U.P.

VARANASI: A man allegedly shot and killed his wife and two priests on Tuesday at his residence in Uttar Pradesh's Azamgarh before locking himself up in a room with his children, police said as efforts continued to rescue the children and apprehend him.

The incident took place around 6pm when accused Arvind Singh returned home to see that a puja was underway. An argument broke out after he allegedly sought Aadhaar cards of priests.

Police said Singh allegedly took out his licensed pistol and opened fire, killing his wife Babita and two priests — Mahendra Pathak and Akhilesh Mishra. Efforts are on to rescue the children, said police.

HTC

{ TELANGANA }

3 infants killed in hospital fire

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HYDERABAD: Three infants died after a fire broke out in the Special Newborn Care Unit (SNCU) ward of the Rajiv Gandhi Institute of Medical Sciences (RIMS) hospital in Telangana's Adilabad in the wee hours of Tuesday, officials said.

Adilabad collector Rajarshi Shah told reporters that the incident occurred around post-midnight following a short circuit in an air-conditioning unit in the SNCU ward. "As per the preliminary information, the AC suddenly exploded, causing flames and thick smoke to

spread through the ward," he said.

The collector said at the time, 27 newborns were reportedly undergoing treatment in the unit. While three infants were safe, the remaining 24 children were affected by the incident. "Of them, one died at the spot and two died while undergoing treatment. The remaining 21 children are being provided medical treatment," he said.

Hospital staff immediately switched off the power supply to the ward and shifted the babies to an adjoining ward as emergency measures were taken.

Firefighters brought the

flames under control, while medical staff continued efforts to rescue and stabilise the affected infants.

The police registered a case of accident and launched an investigation into the incident. Officials are also examining the electrical and fire-safety arrangements to determine whether any lapses contributed to the fire.

Chief minister A Revanth Reddy described the deaths as "extremely painful" and conveyed his condolences to the bereaved families. He ordered an inquiry into the circumstances that led to the fire and told officials to submit a report.

HTC and PTI

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PATIALA: A coach from Kazakhstan has been booked for allegedly raping a 16-year-old national-level cyclist at the National Institute of Sports (NIS) in Punjab's Patiala district, police said on Tuesday.

According to the complaint filed by the girl, the incident took place on September 13 at the residential quarter allotted to the foreign national coach near the girls' hostel on the NIS campus.

The victim approached cops on September 18, following which an FIR was registered at

Civil Lines police station under Sections 64(2) and 351(3) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and Section 6 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (Pocco) Act, police said.

The accused coach had left the NIS premises by the time the police were informed. During the investigation, police found that he was staying at another camp in Delhi.

A police team from Patiala subsequently reached a camp in Delhi to apprehend him, but the accused had left before the team arrived, police said.

Patiala SP Mohit Agarwal said that special teams have been formed to nab the accused.

"Teams are conducting raids based on information about his possible whereabouts. A team had also gone to Delhi, but he was not found. His passport has been seized and a lookout circular has been issued. We are making all efforts to arrest him soon," Agarwal said.

The medical examination of the minor has been conducted, he added.

The accused had arrived in Patiala a few months ago and was staying in the NIS staff quarters, according to the police.

Police said further facts would emerge as the investigation progresses.

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India joins EU, Brazil, Canada and Australia to back multilateralism

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: India joined the European Union (EU), Australia, Brazil and Canada to launch a platform aimed at defending multilateralism and promoting peace and inclusive prosperity on the margins of the UN General Assembly, with external affairs minister S Jaishankar emphasising the need for participative deliberations and transparent decision-making.

Jaishankar joined European Council President Antonio Costa, Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, Brazil's foreign minister Mario Vieira, Barbados Prime Minister Mia Mottley, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney and Kenyan President William Ruto for the inaugural Partners for multilateralism, international law, peace and prosperity (P4M) Summit in New York on September 21.

The initiative was first outlined in a joint op-ed article by Costa, Carney, Ruto and Brazilian President Inacio Lula da Silva, who said they will support reform of the UN and other multilateral institutions to make them more representative, effective and trusted, instead of creating "another exclusive bloc". Carney helped catalyse the initiative, building on his remarks at the World Economic Forum in Davos in January that urged mid-



EAM S Jaishankar with Australian PM Anthony Albanese at the P4M Summit in New York on Monday. ANI

dle powers to close ranks to defend multilateralism.

Jaishankar, who is leading the Indian delegation to the UN General Assembly, noted that India is glad to join the initiative as a co-sponsor at a time when the global order is "under stress". Extreme competition, geopolitical tensions and conflicts have impacted an ongoing rebalancing of the international order and it is essential for multilateralism to assert itself at this juncture, he said.

"Reformed multilateralism is therefore essential. More participative deliberations and more transparent decision-making are both overdue," he said at the meeting. "That would provide the hope

and the optimism which is clearly needed by the UN system. And it would reinforce our resolve to work together."

Jaishankar emphasised the need for collaborative efforts to address issues such as international security, climate justice, emerging technologies, development finance, strengthening supply chains, preparing for pandemics and countering terrorism. "Let us recognise that whatever we have achieved so far is only through collective efforts," he said.

He also called for a range of efforts, including addressing the fallout of conflicts on fuel, food, fertilisers and finance alongside efforts for broader peace. "Where new capabilities and concerns

arise, there is a very powerful case for frameworks and guardrails. Where there is a threat of choke-points dominance and disruption, de-risking and diversifying must be encouraged," he said.

"Multilateralism will be best served when international law, rules and norms are scrupulously observed," Jaishankar said.

European Council President Costa said the meeting demonstrated that there is still a strong shared commitment to cooperation in a world of growing divisions. "That commitment extends across continents, regions and political traditions. The road ahead will not be easy. But today, we have shown that we are not walking it alone," he said.

Costa called for transforming confrontation into cooperation, and pointed to the need to create a global network based on multilateral cooperation, mutual respect and international law. He also outlined three priorities – defending the UN Charter and peaceful settlement of disputes, progress in dealing with global challenges such as climate finance, sustainable development and artificial intelligence, and reforming global institutions such as the UN "so that they are fit for tomorrow's world".

The seven signatories to the initiative tasked senior officials with establishing a coordination chan-

nel and identifying priority areas where they can work together and deliver concrete results. They also invited other countries to join the initiative.

A joint declaration issued at the meeting described the multilateral system founded on the UN Charter as "indispensable" but said it "should be renewed and reformed to be more effective, representative, inclusive and fit for purpose". Leaders will work jointly to reform and strengthen multilateral institutions to ensure they are better equipped to prevent conflict, respond to crises, deliver sustainable development, promote fair trade, protect the rule of law, and address existing and emerging global challenges, it said.

"We commit to strengthening multilateral cooperation that is open, fair, equitable, inclusive, networked and practical, including through closer partnerships with regional organisations and support for regional integration," the declaration said.

The declaration backed "fair, open, resilient, predictable and inclusive" economic cooperation, including more diversified and resilient supply chains, reform of the multilateral trading system, an improved international financial architecture and stronger coordination on global finance, digital transformation, AI and global health issues.

53 students died in IITs in 5 years, 45 by suicide

Sanjay Maurya

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NEW DELHI: At least 53 students died across the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) between 2020-21 and 2024-25, with more than half of these deaths involving students from Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST) and Other Backward Classes (OBC), according to official data accessed by HT.

To be sure, the figures – which include 45 suicides and eight unnatural deaths – are in line with student intake from these marginalised groups in the government-owned institutions.

According to correspondence seen by HT, Nilesh Chandra Srivastava, under secretary in the department of higher education (DoHE), wrote to IITs on December 1, 2025 seeking information in response to a provisionally admitted Lok Sabha Starred Question (Diary No. 3682) scheduled for December 8, 2025. Although the ministry received the responses from IITs, the data was not tabled in Parliament. Congress MP KC Venugopal had asked the questions on December 8 last year related to student suicides in IITs and other central educational institutions.

The title of KC Venugopal's unstarred question on the Lok Sabha website was "Enrolment in Post-Graduate and Ph.D. Programmes". The question contained five parts. The first two sought data on enrolment in postgraduate and doctoral programmes and whether there was a decline in enrolment and completion rates among SC, ST and OBC students. However, the remaining three parts sought information on complaints of caste-based discrimination, suicides and unnatural deaths of students, and the implementation status of the UGC (Promotion of Equity) Regulations, 2012. Unlike parts (a) and (b), these questions did not specifically restrict the information sought to postgraduate and Ph.D. students.

The figures, based on the IITs' own submissions to the ministry, reveal a sustained increase in student deaths across the country's premier engineering institutions.

The developments come amid a simmering row over the death of a student at IIT-Bombay with the family of the victim blaming caste discrimination for his decision to die by suicide.

According to the data, IITs reported five student deaths in 2020-21, six each in 2021-22 and 2022-23, followed by 17 in 2023-24 and 19 in 2024-25. Suicides

Universities must report every student death to police: Centre

NEW DELHI: The Union education ministry has reminded universities and other higher education institutions (HEIs) to immediately report every student suicide or unnatural death to the police, irrespective of where it occurred, the circumstances or the mode of study, while directing them to comply with the Supreme Court's directions on preventing student suicides and addressing mental health concerns.

In a September 16 letter to vice-chancellors and heads of centrally funded institutions, Syed Ekram Rizwi, joint secretary in the department of higher education, asked insti-

tutions to accord priority to the issue and ensure continued compliance with the directions issued by the SC on January 15, 2026.

Citing paragraph 45(iii) of the SC's order, the ministry said: "HEIs shall immediately report every student suicide or unnatural death to police authorities, irrespective of location, circumstances, mode of study or accommodation." The SC order said such incidents must be reported as soon as institutions become aware of them. The ministry also asked HEIs to submit annual reports of student suicides and unnatural deaths to UGC or other regulators. **HTC**

accounted for 84.9% of all deaths. The number of unnatural deaths also rose in the latest year, with six of the 19 deaths reported in 2024-25 falling in that category.

General category students accounted for 23 deaths (43.4%), followed by OBC students with 12 (22.6%), SC students with 10 (18.9%), ST students with seven (13.2%) and EWS students with one (1.9%). Taken together, SC, ST and OBC students accounted for 29 deaths, or 54.7% of the total.

The nature of deaths also varied across categories. Seven of the 23 general category deaths were classified as unnatural. All 12 OBC deaths, all seven ST deaths and the lone Economically Weaker Section (EWS) death were reported as suicides. Nine of the 10 SC deaths were suicides.

General category deaths climbed from zero in 2020-21 to four in 2021-22, three in 2022-23, seven in 2023-24 and nine in 2024-25. Deaths among OBC, SC and ST students also rose from 2023-24 onwards; their combined total stood at five in 2020-21, two in 2021-22 and three in 2022-23, before jumping to nine in 2023-24 and 10 in 2024-25.

IIT Kharagpur, IIT Delhi and IIT Hyderabad reported the highest number of deaths, with seven each during the five-year period. IIT Kanpur and IIT (BHU) Varanasi recorded six each, while IIT Madras reported five. On suicides alone, IIT Hyderabad recorded the highest number with seven, followed by IIT Kharagpur, IIT Delhi and IIT Kanpur with six each. IIT (BHU) Varanasi and IIT Patna

reported the highest number of unnatural deaths, with two each.

Thirteen of the 23 general category deaths were reported from IIT Kharagpur, IIT (BHU) Varanasi and IIT Delhi. Seven of the 12 OBC deaths occurred at IIT Roorkee, IIT Delhi and IIT Madras. Six of the 10 SC deaths were reported from IIT Hyderabad and IIT Delhi.

Earlier, the Union education ministry in July 2023 informed Parliament that 39 students died by suicide in the five years between 2018 and 2023 across IITs. According to an independent assessment, the number of deaths could be higher.

Academics and faculty members attribute the rise in student suicides at IITs to a combination of academic pressure, social isolation, inadequate faculty-student engagement and structural issues related to inclusion, arguing that campuses need stronger preventive support systems rather than a sole reliance on counselling.

Professor V Ramgopal Rao, vice chancellor of BITS Pilani and former IIT Delhi director, said the issue goes beyond availability of counsellors.

"Students today come from far more diverse backgrounds and face academic pressure, relative grading, isolation, limited faculty interaction and job-related anxiety. IITs need to move from crisis management to prevention, with wellbeing integrated into campus life and stronger faculty-student engagement," Prof Rao said.

According to official data, IITs had 108 counsellors across 23 campuses as of December 1, 2025.

VanDyke seeks discharge after paying penalty for illegal entry

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NEW DELHI: American citizen Mathew Aaron VanDyke, whom the National Investigation Agency (NIA) charged with violating the Immigration and Foreigners Act this month, has paid ₹5.5 lakh as compounding charges to the Foreigners Regional Registration Office in Delhi before moving an application seeking his discharge, people familiar with the development said on Tuesday.

His lawyers, Rohit Gour and Rohit Dandriyal, will move a court with the discharge application, the people said.

VanDyke was arrested under terror charges on March 13 along with six Ukrainian nationals for allegedly training ethnic armed groups in Myanmar.

The NIA on September 8 named VanDyke, who described himself as a veteran of the Libyan revolution and a former prisoner of war there, in a charge sheet filed under rather diluted charges under the Immigration and Foreigners Act sections 21 and 23. The Act governs conditions of entry and stay in India. It has provisions for either



Mathew Aaron VanDyke was granted default bail by the special NIA court on Friday.

two to three years of imprisonment or payment of a fine for compounding offences.

The NIA maintained on September 9 that it is continuing its probe under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) charges against VanDyke, who last week got bail. The judge, who granted the bail, said the agency had invoked "piecemeal" charges of sections 21 and 23 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act rather than the more serious UAPA section 18.

The court barred VanDyke from travelling outside Delhi without permission.

VanDyke was arrested at Kolkata airport under section 18 of UAPA, which relates to conspiracy, advocacy, abetment or incitement to commit a terrorist

act. The six Ukrainians, Hurba Petro, Taras Slyviak, Ivan Sukmanovskiy, Marian Stefankiv, Maksim Honcharuk and Viktor Kaminskyy, were arrested at Delhi and Lucknow airports the same day.

An NIA official said on September 8 that there appeared, so far, to be no terror conspiracy against India.

The NIA said that the seven entered India on valid travel documents in December 2025, travelled to Guwahati and Mizoram without the mandatory protected area permit or restricted area permit. It said they crossed the India-Myanmar border through unauthorised points to reach Victoria Camp, where they were to conduct pre-scheduled training for Myanmar-based ethnic armed groups in drone warfare, drone operations, assembly and jamming technology. NIA said some of those groups are linked to insurgent organisations in India.

NIA maintained that the case involved more than an immigration violation and formed part of "a larger conspiracy involving Indian insurgent groups, particularly those active in the north-eastern states".

Siam set to be B'desh's high commissioner

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday formally approved the appointment of Bangladesh foreign secretary Asad Alam Siam as the next high commissioner to New Delhi, people familiar with the matter said, against the backdrop of efforts by both sides to reset bilateral relations.

Siam, a career diplomat who joined the Bangladesh Foreign Service in 1995, will replace Riaz Hamidullah in New Delhi in the coming weeks. Hamidullah has been posted as Bangladesh's new permanent representative to the UN in Geneva.

The agrément, or formal consent sought from India for Siam's posting, was handed over to the foreign ministry in Dhaka on Tuesday afternoon, the people said on condition of anonymity. The completion of the process ended speculation in some quarters that the agrément had been held up by the Indian side.

Salahuddin Noman Chowdhury, Bangladesh's former envoy to the UN in New York, is expected to be the next foreign secretary, the people said.

Siam has served extensively in Bangladesh and abroad. He was

SIAM, A CAREER DIPLOMAT, WILL REPLACE RIAZ HAMIDULLAH IN NEW DELHI IN THE COMING WEEKS

Bangladesh's ambassador to the US for less than a year before he was appointed foreign secretary in June 2025. During 2023-24, he served as ambassador to Austria and as envoy to the Philippines during 2017-2021. He also served as Bangladesh's first consul general in Milan, Italy, assistant high commissioner in Manchester, UK, and as a junior diplomat in Indonesia and Thailand.

Dhaka decided to send its most senior diplomat as the high commissioner to New Delhi following India's move of sending Dinesh Trivedi, a political appointee and a former minister, as the envoy to Dhaka, the people said.

Siam will have to oversee efforts to reset bilateral relations, which plunged to an all-time low under the interim government led by Muhammad Yunus, which came to power after the Sheikh Hasina government was ousted during a student-led uprising in 2024.

Green nods for ports to now be valid for 20 years

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NEW DELHI: The Union environment ministry, through a gazette notification, has extended the validity period of environmental Clearances (ECs) for ports, harbours, breakwaters and dredging projects from the existing 10 years (which can be increased by one year) to 20 years (which can be increased by five years each twice), making it the same as for mining projects.

This is valid for prior ECs as well, the gazette states. Officials familiar with the matter said this was being done to improve ease of

business.

The gazette notification, dated September 21, states the Centre has from time to time, rationalised the validity period of ECs – especially for projects and activities which have "high gestation period" due to "various issues which are often beyond the control of the project proponent".

It said the environment ministry received a request to rationalise the validity period of the EC granted to ports and harbours, and referred this to both the sectoral expert appraisal committee and the expert advisory committee. Both said the existing EC validity was "insufficient", following



Officials said the decision aims to improve ease of business. AFP

which, on May 20, it issued a draft notification, seeking comments from stakeholders and the public. The initial draft suggested

increasing the initial validity of the EC from the current 10 years (with the possibility of a 1-year extension) to 15 years, with an option for an additional 5-year extension. However, the environment ministry noted it also received the minutes of a stakeholder consultation from June 16 by the ministry of shipping, requesting it to reconsider the validity period so as to align it to the project period, or thirty years (whichever is more) for port projects, in line with mining projects. ECs issued for mining projects are currently valid for 30 years or the life of the project.

The environment ministry said the comments, including the one

from the shipping ministry were referred to the expert advisory committee.

"After due deliberation, the committee recommended that the validity of ports and harbours may be increased to a period of twenty years. Provided that, the period of validity may be extended by five years, beyond twenty years..." the gazette stated.

The ministry said a second extension of five years may be granted too, in deserving cases. However, suitable environment safeguards would have to then be included in the Environmental Management Plan (EMP), as deemed necessary, it clarified.

Govt sets quality standards for smartphone screen protectors

Sejal Sharma

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NEW DELHI: Smartphone screen protectors that do not meet certain specific requirements regarding thickness, dimensions, light transmission, defects and strength and that don't carry the 'Standard' mark, will not be manufactured, stored for sale, imported, sold or distributed in India after April 1, 2027, the government has said in a notification Monday.

This comes after the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), in a notification issued on September 21, amended the Electronics and Information Technology Goods (Requirement of Compulsory Registration) Order, 2021 – which entails a list of IT and electronic products that must conform to specific Indian Standards (IS), issued by the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS),



Starting April 1, smartphone users will see products on the market with a required 'Standard' mark in India.

mentioned against the products. This list has been maintained and updated since 2012.

The ministry on Monday added "screen protectors for smartphones" as the 66th item to this list, against IS 19348:2025, originally introduced by BIS in July 2025. Even though the scope for IS 19348:2025 covers smartphones, tablets, laptops, PC screens, E-readers, etc, the MeitY notifica-

tion specifically only refers to "smartphones".

Starting April 1, smartphone users will increasingly see products on the market with a required 'Standard' mark in India. To be sure, MeitY's 2021 order does not apply to goods meant for export, which then conform to the specification required by the foreign buyer. "With a market of over 500 million units a year, this move will catalyse a ₹12,000-16,000 crore quality-driven industry, generate around 60,000 direct and indirect jobs and contribute an estimated ₹2,000 crore in GST revenues," said Pankaj Mohindroo, Chairman, India Cellular and Electronics Association.

Currently, over 90% of demand for screen protectors is met through low-cost imports, according to industry stakeholders, resulting in inconsistent quality and a largely unorganised market.

MP CONFIRMS 20 HOCH DEATHS IN REPORT TO HC

Shruti Tomar and Monika Pandey

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BHOPAL/JABALPUR: The Madhya Pradesh government told the state high court on Tuesday that 20 people died after consuming spurious liquor in Sagar district and cause of death of another seven was not clear.

Full compensation of ₹four lakh was paid to who died due to consuming hoch, ₹2 lakh was given to others, the government said in a status report filed in the high court.

A division bench comprising Chief Justice Almesh Yeshwant Kogje and Justice Vivek Jain disposed of a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) demanding an impartial inquiry and strict action against the accused granting the petitioner liberty to present their case before the judicial commission set up to probe the incident.

{ TOP COURT CITES PREVIOUS RULINGS }

SC bins challenge to SC/ST Act provisions

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday dismissed a challenge to the constitutional validity of some key provisions of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, saying safeguards laid down in its earlier judgments were sufficient to prevent misuse of its stringent arrest provisions.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said a three-judge bench had already laid down safeguards in the Prathviraj Chauhan case in 2020 and declined to entertain the petition filed as a PIL.

"Sufficient safeguards have been laid down by a decision of the three-judge bench in Prathviraj Chauhan case (2020). We are not interested in entertaining this petition which is purportedly in public interest," the bench said. This case

A BENCH LED BY CHIEF JUSTICE OF INDIA SURYA KANT SAID A 3-JUDGE BENCH HAD ALREADY LAID DOWN SUFFICIENT SAFEGUARDS UNDER THE ACT

had challenged sections 18 and 18A of the Act which denied anticipatory bail and required no prior enquiry to be conducted by the police before registering FIR. This judgment laid down the safeguards that where the complaint under the Act does not make out a prima facie case, in such cases the bar under sections 18 and 18A shall not apply.

The court was hearing a PIL filed by 19 people led by Brijbhushan Saini, who claimed to be

victims of allegedly false prosecutions under the Act.

Advocate Vishnu Shankar Jain, appearing for the petitioners, argued that the 1989 Act, amended in 2015 and again in 2018, contains stringent provisions allowing police to register a case on a complaint without conducting a preliminary inquiry. Section 18A also bars anticipatory bail for a person accused under the law.

"Section 18A of the Act is being widely misused," Jain said, referring to its impact on Section 35 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023 which allows the police to analyse if a complaint discloses credible information. The provision says "a police officer may arrest a person against whom a reasonable complaint or credible information has been received, or where there is reasonable suspicion that the person has committed a cognisable offence punishable with imprisonment of up to

seven years." The petition said that such an enquiry by police is prohibited by section 18A.

The bench, also comprising Justices Jaymyala Bagchi and V Mohana, said, "Instances of misuse can be separately looked into by the court. But that cannot be a ground to doubt the constitutional validity of the Act."

The bench said the Prathviraj Chauhan judgment had held that in exceptional cases, the constitutional courts can exercise power under the Code of Criminal Procedure (now replaced by BNSS) to quash the cases so as to prevent misuse of provisions of the Act.

It also referred to the Supreme Court's August 2024 judgment in the Shajan Skaria case, which held that the bar under Section 18 of the 1989 Act (expressly bars the application of anticipatory bail) would apply only where there is prima facie material indicating the commission of an offence.

{ EVENT HELD IN GUJARAT }

President confers National Film Awards

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NEW DELHI: The 72nd National Film Awards were presented in Gujarat's Ekta Nagar on Tuesday, marking a departure from the recent tradition of holding the ceremony at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi, with President Droupadi Murmu urging the film industry to be mindful of its influence on young audiences.

Addressing the ceremony, Murmu said popular artists, particularly those followed by children and young people, have an important influence on society. She urged successful artists to promote disciplined and healthy lifestyles and refrain from endorsing substances that are harmful to health. The President also called for greater dignity and social security for workers in the



President Droupadi Murmu confers Best Actor In a Leading Role award on Mammooty (L) and the Dada Saheb Phalke Award on Anant Nag (R) at an event in Gujarat on Tuesday.



ANI

creative economy, including assistants, small artists and those struggling to establish themselves in the industry.

Veteran Kannada actor Anant Nag was conferred the Dadasaheb Phalke Award for 2024. 'Article 370' was named Best

Feature Film, while Yami Gautam won Best Actress in a Leading Role for the film. Mammooty and Kartik Aaryan shared the Best Actor in a Leading Role award for 'Bramayugam' and 'Chandu Champion', respectively. Rajkumar Periasamy won Best

Direction for Amaran, while Ran-deep Hooda was recognised for his directorial debut 'Swatantrya Veer Savarkar'.

'Kalki 2898 AD' won Best Popular Film Providing Wholesome Entertainment, while 'Captain Miller' received the award for Best Feature Film Promoting National, Social and Environmental Values.

Awards to be held at tourist destinations

The event also formally launched the government's plan to take the National Film Awards to tourist destinations across the country. Information and Broadcasting minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the move was intended to take the awards "beyond a conference room" and connect them with India's tourism and cultural heritage.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

DELHI RAPE

the victim and her friend," said deputy commissioner of police (southeast) Vineet Kumar.

Joint commissioner of police (south) Vijay Kumar said the three men used legal language to threaten the duo that a case could be registered against them. "They then separated the girl from her friend before taking her towards a secluded area. Asif threatened the girl with a firearm and a knife and raped her while one of the accused held the male friend. The two other men with him also raped her, threatened the minors and left," he added. Police said Asif was carrying an unlicensed pistol.

Around 6am on Tuesday, Asif was arrested after a brief exchange of fire near the district magistrate's office in Amar Colony. Mukesh and Hemant were arrested from their house in Srinivasपुरi around 7am. An FIR was filed against the three under sections pertaining to gangrape, criminal conspiracy, criminal intimidation, voluntarily causing hurt, and relevant sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act.

Police said that Mukesh was pursuing a BSc (Maths) degree. Their father said that Hemant was a lawyer who practised in Saket court, though police said they found no corroborating evidence. Asif, police said, works at the Okhla vegetable market.

A police officer citing the FIR said the girl went to Kalkaji Mandir in the evening and later to the park with her friend when the three accused approached them, took her to an isolated spot and "threatened" her with a firearm and knife. The accused then took turns to rape her while also assaulting her friend, said the officer.

The male friend did not identify the accused. The girl, in her statement, said one of the suspects was "heavily built", had a "stubble" and was dressed in a "checked shirt" and jeans. The second accused was wearing a "brown T-shirt" and a dark-coloured lower while the third accused was wearing a "black T-shirt" and "black lower".

This is the latest in a string of crimes against women that have jolted the national capital and re-established concerns about safety and security of women and girls in public spaces. The incident has also underscored the widespread absence of security mechanisms - malfunctioning CCTVs, dark spots, unpatrolled streets and parks - in popular public places in the city.

On September 16, a 10-year-old Class 6 student was tied up and raped inside a tailor's shop in Delhi's Sadar Bazaar area. Police said she had gone to buy a notebook when the accused, a 56-year-old man, pulled her inside his shop.

On September 14, a six-year-old girl was allegedly sexually assaulted by a 34-year-old man in the Kishanganj area in south-west Delhi.

Earlier, a 16-year-old girl was allegedly gangraped and murdered by a group of four teenagers - three of them minors - who later dumped her body in a field in outer Delhi's Swarop Nagar. The incident took place on September 10-11 but the body was found on September 13. The police later caught the four persons.

HT found a slew of lapses in the 142.10-acre park - including poor lighting, malfunctioning lamp-posts, pools of darkness created by canopied trees, broken walls leading to unauthorised entry and exit points, and inadequate patrolling. HT only saw two guards across seven entry points.

The park abuts the Nehru Place Metro station and connects ISKCON temple, Kalkaji Mandir, Lotus Temple and Nehru Place to Garhi Village, Sant Nagar, East of Kailash, Kalkaji and other areas. It was inaugurated in 2002 and has lush gardens, seating spaces, pond and fountain spaces. DDA sought to evade respon-

sibility. "Aastha Kunj park is a large public green space with 29 gates, including wicket gates, and is frequented by visitors throughout the day. For the watch and ward of the park and the safety and security of visitors, nine security guards are deployed in each shift at strategic locations, along with supervisory and patrolling arrangements. The lighting installations in the park are functional and are inspected regularly."

The Delhi Police also followed suit, with a senior police officer saying patrolling in the park was not possible. "This is a huge park and too dense. The lights inside don't work. Are we supposed to patrol the streets or the parks?" he asked.

Senior police officers said that the accused took "advantage" of the dark and secluded spaces.

"A PCR call regarding the alleged rape of a 17-year-old minor girl by three persons near Kalkaji Mandir was received at about 8.45pm. On receipt of the information, SHO along with staff reached Aastha Kunj park, where the victim was found along with her male friend. As per the victim's statement, she and her friend had visited Kalkaji Mandir for darshan and subsequently entered Aastha Kunj park through gate no. 7," said DCP Kumar.

After the assault, the accused again threatened the minors, slapped the boy thrice and left, said police.

Police said the teenagers called 112 from the park itself and stayed there. "The girl was medically examined at AIIMS Hospital. The crime/FSL team examined the scene and relevant exhibits were collected. Accordingly, an FIR was lodged under sections of gangrape, voluntarily causing simple hurt, criminal conspiracy, criminal intimidation and Pocco Act sections of aggravated penetrative sexual assault and abetment of offence against a child," said the DCP.

Police said they recorded the boy's statement. He alleged that the accused "raped his friend in front of him".

Forensics officials told HT they recovered used condoms along with other biological evidence from the spot.

Senior police officers said that at night, when they assembled teams to probe the case, the CCTVs at the entry gate of the park were not functional. Based on footage from neighbouring roads and local enquiry, a team led by inspector Rajender Dagar managed to identify the trio at night.

"Around 6am, they found that Asif was near the district magistrate's office in Amar Colony. He had left from Okhla Mandi where he works as police were looking for him. On his way, he was waylaid by a patrolling team. He opened fire at the police party and fired three rounds. Despite being directed to surrender, he continued firing. During the exchange of fire, one round hit the bullet-proof jacket of HC Rajesh. In self-defence, HC Rajesh fired two rounds, one of which hit the accused in his right leg," added the DCP. The injured accused was immediately shifted to AIIMS Trauma Centre for treatment.

As per investigators, Hemant and Mukesh met Asif recently during a stroll at Aastha Kunj park. "The three are not friends but acquaintances. On Monday, they were walking together when they spotted the minors sitting together. They decided to target the minors as they were sitting in a secluded spot. Since Asif was carrying a weapon, they decided to pose as police personnel. Hemant started talking in a very loud and authoritative way," said the investigator, requesting anonymity.

Hemant and Mukesh's family said the siblings were picked up from their rented house at 7am. JR Dhankar, their father, told HT, "I am a practising lawyer in Faridabad. My son, Hemant, is a lawyer at Saket court. Why would he do this? My younger son is a mathematics student. He

is in his final year. The police have no proof against my sons. They are torturing my boys who are innocent. We don't know any Asif. Why would two brothers rape a girl? Police have no case and have made a fake case to trap us. My sons were not even at the park. My sons live here but the rest of our family lives in Faridabad and had no idea the police were doing this."

SC-S.I.R. NOTICES

Justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana, said that EC needed to ensure that the process did not merely generate notices but enabled voters to respond effectively.

"Please look into it. Almost mechanically notices are going...as if they are computer-generated," observed the bench during a hearing on a petition, filed by activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri, challenging the alleged failure of the EC and Delhi chief electoral officer to disclose the names of voters who had been issued notices and the specific reasons for doing so.

The court's intervention came against the backdrop of 4.76 million names having been excluded from Delhi's draft electoral roll published on August 31, while another 3.31 million voters whose names remain in the draft roll have been flagged for possible discrepancies.

The bench specifically asked EC to clarify the category of "logical discrepancy", observing that the expression needed greater clarity. The poll panel, represented through senior advocate DS Naidu, told the court that every notice contained the reason and that the 12 documents prescribed for the exercise were not exhaustive.

The bench said EC should make the process easier for voters by identifying the kind of information that would suffice to answer common queries. It suggested that where there were 15-20 recurring types of discrepancies or objections, the EC could prepare standard responses and circulate them to officials and voters.

"Maybe little bit orientation is required...to inspire confidence," said the bench, suggesting that where mobile numbers of voters were available, they could be told what information would be sufficient to answer the particular query.

The petitioners, represented by advocate Prashant Bhushan, questioned the practical burden being placed on voters who received notices. Bhushan referred to examples where discrepancies allegedly related to the age gap between an elector and his or her parents, or the gap between siblings, but the documents listed by EC did not necessarily contain information to explain such anomalies.

The bench said the 14,000 booth level officers (BLOs) deployed in Delhi could assist voters in responding to such notices. EC said 1,200 electoral registration officers (EROs) were also working on the exercise and that it had increased manpower to deal with the pendency.

The poll panel further told the bench that the deadline for completion of the process was October 29, though it was open to extending it if necessary. It assured the court that "not even a single voter could be deleted" without following the prescribed process.

The bench also asked EC to consider making its existing assistance mechanisms more accessible. When senior advocate Kapil Sibal pointed out that notices did not always specify where voters could meet the concerned officer, the bench suggested that Booth Level Officers could be made available at ward offices so that people could approach them there.

The hearing also brought into focus the particular demographic character of Delhi, where migration and movement between cities are common. The bench noted that unlike a person continuously residing in one

place, a migrant voter may have to explain that he or she was earlier registered or residing in another city before moving to Delhi.

The bench observed that such verification could serve the legitimate purpose of ensuring that a person did not have duplicate electoral entries, but said the process had to be made comprehensible to the voter.

The petitioners also questioned the manner in which voters categorised as "shifted" were being required to establish their eligibility, and raised concerns about people who may possess little documentation apart from Aadhaar.

The bench referred the parties to safeguards and interim measures it had adopted while dealing with the SIR in Bihar and West Bengal, asking EC to follow those orders where applicable and file a report on the steps taken in Delhi.

In the Bihar SIR proceedings, the court had directed the EC to publish the list of excluded electors along with reasons for exclusion and required recognised political parties to deploy their BLOs to assist voters in submitting claims and objections. It also directed that Aadhaar be accepted as the 12th document for establishing identity, while making clear that it was not proof of citizenship.

The court subsequently upheld the constitutional validity of the Bihar SIR in May this year, holding that the exercise was within EC's powers and that the statutory safeguards required notice, an opportunity to respond and a reasoned determination before exclusion attained finality.

The West Bengal proceedings similarly saw the court issue directions to make the claims-and-objections process more accessible. Among other measures, the court provided additional time for persons who had not submitted their claims, documents or objections, directed adequate manpower at Panchayat Bhawans and block offices, and provided for affected persons to be heard in person or through authorised representatives while submitting their documents.

The court's directions in the two states thus became an important reference point during Tuesday's hearing, with the bench asking EC to apply the same principle of providing practical assistance and procedural clarity to voters in Delhi.

The immediate dispute before the court concerns 33,12,919 voters whose names remain in the draft roll but have been flagged under the categories of "no mapping" and "logical discrepancies". Of these, 1,379,785 have been categorised as having no mapping with the 2002 electoral roll, while 1,933,134 have been placed under "logical discrepancies".

The petitioners have sought publication of a consolidated and searchable list of all electors issued notices, along with the precise reason or category for each notice. They have also questioned the absence of publicly disclosed criteria, definitions and operational parameters governing the "logical discrepancies" category.

The Delhi draft roll contains 9,753,577 electors, compared with 14,510,299 names on the rolls before the revision. The 4,756,722 exclusions from the draft roll were made under the categories of absent, shifted, dead and duplicate. EC has maintained that issuance of a notice does not mean that a voter has been declared ineligible and that those facing scrutiny will have an opportunity to respond before the final electoral roll is prepared.

The claims and objections process in Delhi is scheduled to continue until September 30, with disposal of notices expected by October 29 and publication of the final electoral roll on November 4. Naidu, however, on Tuesday submitted that the timeline could be extended if required.

ED files complaint against CGPSC ex-chair, 6 others

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RAIPUR: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Tuesday filed a prosecution complaint against seven persons, including former Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission (CGPSC) chairman Taman Singh Sonwani, in a money laundering case linked to alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations conducted during the previous Congress government.

The 99-page prosecution complaint, along with documents running into around 3,700 pages, seen by HT, was filed before Special PMLA (Prevention of Money Laundering Act) Court in Raipur, ED counsel Sourabh Kumar Pande said.

Besides Sonwani, the accused named in the complaint are businessman Shrayan Goyal, then CGPSC Deputy Controller (Examination) Lalit Ganvir, Utkarsh Chandrakar, nephew of K K Chandravanshi, a former personal assistant to former chief minister Bhupesh Baghel, Vikas Chandrakar, Anil Chandrakar and Chetan Borghariya, a state services officer who was posted as an officer on special duty

SONWANI WAS ARRESTED BY ED IN JULY AS PART OF ITS PROBE RELATED TO CORRUPTION, QUESTION PAPER LEAKS AND MANIPULATION OF CGPSC EXAMS

(OSD) in the office of former chief minister Baghel. Borghariya is the seventh accused named in the prosecution complaint.

It is the first prosecution complaint filed by the federal agency in the case.

According to ED investigation, Goyal allegedly provided money to an NGO, Gramin Vikas Samiti (GVS), associated with Sonwani, as part of an arrangement to facilitate the selection of his son and daughter-in-law in CGPSC examinations.

The agency has also alleged that when the CGPSC recruitment rules were amended in 2021, Ganvir played a role in removing the word "nephew" from the definition of "family", allegedly facilitating the selection

of relatives of then chairman Sonwani.

Utkarsh and Vikas Chandrakar allegedly arranged preliminary and mains examination papers for candidates and collected money from them, the agency has alleged.

Sonwani was arrested by the ED in July as part of its investigation related to alleged corruption, question paper leaks and manipulation of examinations conducted by the commission in 2020 and 2021 for posts including deputy collectors and deputy superintendents of police.

The money laundering investigation stems from an FIR registered by the Chhattisgarh Economic Offences Wing (EOW), a subsequent complaint filed by the CBI in July 2024 and three charge sheets filed in 2025.

Sonwani was also arrested by the CBI in 2024. CBI case was registered after the BJP defeated the Congress and formed the government in Chhattisgarh in November 2023.

In a statement issued on July 27, ED had alleged that Sonwani, while serving as CGPSC chairman, entered into a criminal conspiracy with other public servants and private individuals.

Blatant daylight dacoity: SC on 10-fold gap in cancer drug prices

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday questioned a 10-fold disparity in the price of an essential cancer drug, with the medicine sold to retailers for ₹2,700 but reaching consumers at ₹27,000, and asked the authorities why they had failed to act.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta, hearing petitions on drug pricing and regulation of generic medicines, said such a disparity amounted to "dacoity" and raised concerns over the burden on patients forced to sell homes and jewellery to afford treatment.

"We wonder how a patient can be cheated for an essential cancer drug. We know of a cancer drug which the manufacturer

PETITIONS SOUGHT SC'S INTERVENTION IN REGULATING PRICES OF DRUGS, EQUIPMENT AND GENERIC MEDS

sells at a price to retailers (PTR) of ₹2,700 which is then sold in the market for ₹27,000. This is blatant broad daylight dacoity, an absolute rampage and carnage they are doing to the patients," the bench said.

Questioning the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) and the Department of Pharmaceuticals, the court said, "It is surprising that the authorities supposed to take a decision on this are completely silent. If

this is not extortion then what is it? A medicine sold to retailers at 10% of MRP, why this disparity, is what we are asking?"

The petitions, filed by advocate Kishan Chand Jain and doctor Sanjay Kulshrestha, sought intervention of the court in regulating prices of drugs, equipment and generic medicines to make it affordable to common citizens.

The Centre, represented by additional solicitor general KM Nataraj, said the government did not view the proceedings as "adversarial" and would make submissions on the existing mechanisms on September 29, the next date of hearing.

Pharma manufacturers, represented by senior advocate Kapil Sibal, said retailers, rather than manufacturers, were earning the profits.

IAF VICE CHIEF: TECH ISSUES OF LCA MK-1A LIKELY TO BE FIXED IN 1 OR 2 MONTHS

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NEW DELHI: Technical issues delaying the delivery of India's latest fighter, the light combat aircraft (LCA Mk-1A), are expected to be resolved in a month or two, clearing the way for its induction into the Indian Air Force, IAF vice chief Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit said on Tuesday.

Dixit said, "HAL has clarified, and I would like to add, that in the beginning, the delay was from the engine side. We did not get enough engines. Now we have got engines, we have installed them on the aircraft, and we are doing proper and thorough testing before the aircraft is inducted. Two or three points are left to be proven, and I think in a month or two, we should be able to overcome that technical issue, and thereafter, the road is clear for the aircraft to be inducted."

His remarks came in response to a question during a briefing on Tarang Shakti, the IAF's largest multilateral air combat exercise to be held in Jodhpur from September 26 to October 12.

The IAF is eagerly waiting for LCA Mk-1A's induction, he said.

He will be the senior-most officer when IAF chief Air Chief Marshal AP Singh retires on October 31, making him the frontrunner for the top post.

"There are some issues involving radar, and maybe some integration. The issues are on the verge of resolution," Dixit said, in a rare confirmation from the IAF that the fighter is almost ready for induction.

The vice chief's comments came days after HAL chairman Ravi K said the aerospace major will begin delivering the LCA Mk-1A to the IAF by the end of this year after resolving the final radar and weapons-integration issues.

On Tarang Shakti, Dixit said invitations were sent out to 65 countries to participate in the second edition of the exercise - eight have confirmed participation with their air assets and 32 countries are coming as observers.

The foreign aircraft taking part in the air combat drills include F-35s, F-16s, Rafales, A400Ms, A330 MRTT (multi role tanker transport) KC-135s, C-130s, and other specialised platforms.

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Patience can pay when SIP returns disappoint

Short period returns can be uneven as they are inherently unequal. But equity markets move in cycles, and staying disciplined and diversified gives your money time to compound

Lisa Pallavi Barbora
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MUMBAI: The recent months have been disappointing for investors who began their equity journey with regular monthly investments through systematic investment plans, particularly in large cap mutual fund schemes. Large-cap funds are usually seen as the “safe” part of an equity portfolio. But over the past year they have lost money. A monthly SIP in large-cap funds lost about 2.9% on average.

Before giving up on monthly SIPs and their benefits of discipline and long term impact, it's worth understanding that the SIP itself does not generate returns. Your overall investment strategy and behaviour do.

SIP returns are not one broad-brush number. Look closely at your mutual fund portfolio and you'll find that schemes across different categories such as large-cap, mid-cap and small cap have delivered very different SIP returns—not just over the past year but across different time periods (Table 1). Unlike their large cap peers, small-cap funds, which are considered relatively more risky, delivered a one-year return of 9.49% on average through monthly SIPs.

Should you ditch your large-cap fund SIP and shift to small-cap funds? No. Equity markets are divided into broad market-cap segments and each has a role in your portfolio. Returns from large-caps are relatively more stable as compared to mid-and-small caps, while the latter two are typically used to generate higher excess returns in the long run.

But you must consider the basic conditions needed for sustainable long term equity investing. Unless you build these into your equity portfolio—regardless of the market-cap segment you invest in—

there will be periods when your portfolio returns not only confuse but also disappoint you.

Prices move up and down — it's normal

In March 2020, the equity market—represented by the Nifty 50—crashed 40% in a few weeks. But the rebound was just as fast with April 2020 ending with gains of around 14%.

This kind of swing, or volatility, is part of the deal. You cannot expect steady, predictable returns from equity. “Let's go back two decades. Between 2000 and 2002, investors in domestic equities made roughly 3.5% returns. This seems rather low. But anybody who held on for another four years made 14% annualised return. Markets can be irrational on the way up and on the way down, and at both times investors need to stay disciplined and do nothing,” says Kirtan Shah, founder Truvanta Wealth. He believes the gap is in expectations. He says it's reasonable to expect 10%-12% return from a 100% equity portfolio but that return won't come every year. “It is not uniform each year, you have to be prepared for lumpy returns,” he says.

Consider this: for someone invested for a three-year period from January 2013 to December 2015, the Nifty 50 gave an average annual return of 10.5%. Which means an investment of ₹1 lakh grew to ₹1.35 lakh. But the return each calendar year looked rather uneven—6.76% was the 2013 calendar return, 31.39% for 2014 and -4.06% in 2015 calendar year. In other words your portfolio value can move very differently from one year to the next.

The key is to remain invested—the longer, the better.

“In markets, a sharp fall in price is volatility, which is also termed as a price correction. When prices remain in a narrow range for a long time, neither moving up nor down much, we call it a time correction. The latter is what we're experiencing in large-caps today. But it's worth knowing that there have been multiple such periods over the years. Every year you may see a 10% odd price correction and a time correction every two to three years,” says Rushabh Desai, founder, Rupee with Rushabh Investment Services.

Don't put all your eggs in one basket

Diversify by spreading your money across different types of funds. At a big picture level you need to diversify across assets—invest a little in deposits and debt funds, a little in gold and some in equity. But even within equity, you need to be spread out across different market capitalisation segments.

Table 1 shows the difference in SIP returns across time periods for funds in different market capitalisation segments. Each segment may perform well in a different period. The short term divergence in returns, particularly over one to three years, looks stark but smoothen out over time. “Every market cap segment will perform in cycles. Large-caps haven't done well in the last four to five years and mid-and-small-caps may not do well in some other years. So diversification within equity itself is needed,” says Desai.

Short term price movement is influenced by many factors such as investor sentiment, liquidity and foreign investor interest, among others.

Over time, fundamentals and earning growth catch up, and being diversified across market segments helps manage the inherent cyclicality. Depending on your goals and your risk tolerance for short term loss, your allocation to each market capitalisation segment can differ and your investment time horizon will differ.

“We prefer to take large-cap exposure through a flexicap fund. That's for clients who want to match a 3-5 year goal. Investing in mid-caps is best aligned for goals with an investment horizon of a minimum of five years and a minimum eight years for small caps,” says Shah.

Give it time

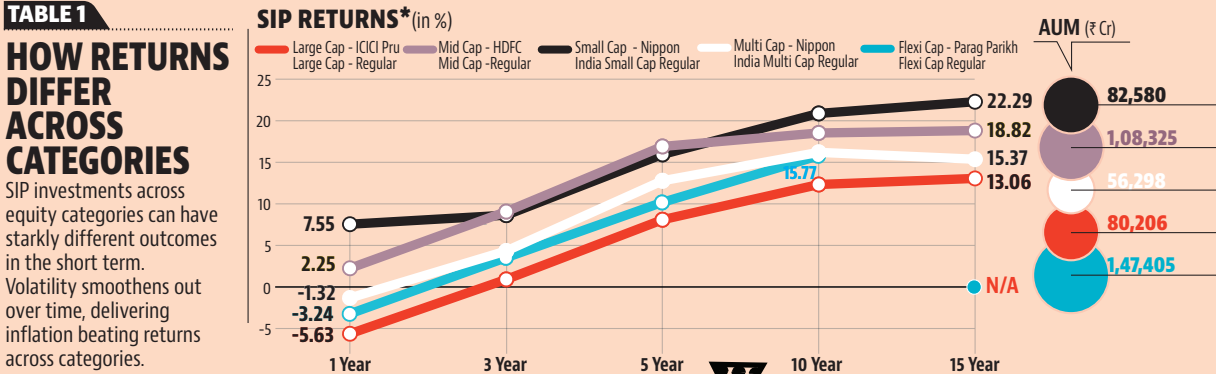
Equity returns need time to compound. Companies or businesses take years to grow and become profitable. Also rarely do businesses deliver the same profit year after year. And that means stock price also takes years to grow meaningfully—you won't get an instant jump in returns.

While prices in short term are influenced by the daily demand-supply, news and events, it does not impact the longer term potential of the underlying stock or

SIP RETURNS: KNOW WHAT YOU'RE MEASURING

TABLE 1 HOW RETURNS DIFFER ACROSS CATEGORIES

SIP investments across equity categories can have starkly different outcomes in the short term. Volatility smoothen out over time, delivering inflation beating returns across categories.



Note: Returns are compared across a scheme in five different equity fund categories by choosing the scheme with the largest assets under management, which represents the category and is suitable for a non-demat SIP. The table is meant to demonstrate the difference in returns across categories. It is not a recommendation to invest in any of these schemes. 1 year returns is absolute. Source: Valueresearchonline.com

TABLE 2 ABSOLUTE RETURN VS CAGR VS XIRR

A quick reference for reading mutual fund return figures correctly.

If you invest via SIP, the number that tells you your actual return is XIRR. Absolute return and CAGR should be used for lump-sum investments. An advisor or an app quoting CAGR-style annualised return against your SIP is showcasing the fund's point-to-point return, not your personal return or actual gain. If these return metrics are too difficult to understand, it's best to invest through a trusted, qualified mutual fund advisor.

	ABSOLUTE RETURN	CAGR	XIRR
WHAT IT MEASURES	Total gain or loss	Annualised return for a lump sum, single investment date	Annualised return for multiple cash flows on different dates
USE IT FOR	Lump sum, holding period under or up to 1 year	Lump sum, holding period over 1 year	SIP or staggered inflows and outflows
SIP APPROPRIATE?	No — misleading for SIPs, ignores that later instalments had less time to grow	No — assumes one lump sum date, doesn't fit 12+ staggered instalments	Yes — this is the correct SIP metric

portfolio of stocks to deliver profit or earnings growth. Over a few years, noise fades and real growth shows up.

“Price movements of a few stocks shouldn't matter to a mutual fund investor as your fund itself will have 50-60 stocks with 10% cap in one stock. In a portfolio of four-five mutual funds the price movement of one or five stocks will not move the needle. Markets have also become more agile recently, reacting too much to news and events. In six months

the market can completely change direction. Agility is important but one has to give equity at least seven to eight years for returns to compound,” says Desai.

What should you do?

Your SIP is working, but you need to give it more time and ensure it is well spread out. Market volatility, especially in times of correction, can feel unnerving as you see portfolio value declining and red marks all over. That's when decision making moves from being

rational to emotional. In such times, remind yourself of the long term goal and the basic fundamental conditions needed for equity investing. As Shah suggests, keep your long term goal in focus and do nothing in uncertain times.

If market events continue to feel emotional or out of control, it's always better to work with a qualified advisor.

Lisa Pallavi Barbora is a freelance writer and author of Money & Her

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Fundamentals of ownership

The argument that the Tata group is too important for India to be left to the Tatas is a dangerous one

When it comes to companies, control is almost always a question of percentages. For instance, a 51% shareholding means majority control; and a more-than-25% shareholding translates (at least on paper) into the ability to block a special board resolution. In a privately and closely held company, a 66% holding should mean absolute control — unless, as recent events have shown, one is talking about Tata Sons.

There are two threads to *l'affaire* Tata Sons. The first is the Reserve Bank of India requirement regarding the listing of Tata Sons. The company says it has no public debt or deposits, but RBI's argument is that the company's holdings in group companies with public equity and debt give it access to public funds. There is logic to both arguments, although RBI's would appear to stretch the definition of public funds.

The second, unrelated to the first, is the board's decision to ignore the company's own rules when appointing its chairman. The rules clearly state that a majority of Tata Trust's nominees (various Tata trusts together hold around 66% of Tata Sons) need to vote in favour; in this case, one of the two, Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, opposed N Chandrasekaran's appointment as chairman, effectively scuttling it. It is unusual for a board to go against the wishes of the largest shareholder, prompting theories about a *deus ex machina* tilting the scale in favour of Chandrasekaran, something reinforced by the Maharashtra charity commissioner preventing, on very flimsy grounds, the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT) — one of the two large trusts together holding over 50% of Tata Sons — from even convening a meeting. The cloud over SRTT also means there is no clarity on when a Tata Sons AGM will happen (if it were to happen, and SRTT were allowed to vote, Chandrasekaran's appointment would not go through). If SRTT were allowed to meet, the Tata Trusts could also change their other nominee on the board of Tata Sons, and ensure that both vote the same way. This, though, is a sub-plot of the larger issue. For if the courts were to endorse the decision of the board of Tata Sons, it would shake the very fundamentals of ownership and management, and make the former irrelevant. The argument that the Tata group is too important for India to be left to the Tatas — one that has been made in some quarters — is a dangerous one.

Making accountability key to the arrest process

The Supreme Court has put a much-needed constitutional check on the power of re-arrest. Its latest ruling, requiring prior judicial approval for re-arresting an accused, after release for violation of Article 22(1), makes it unambiguous that a breach of a fundamental right cannot be followed by unchecked repetition of the same executive power. The judgment prescribed safeguards that make accountability integral to the arrest process. Once an arrest is held illegal for failure to furnish written grounds, the police must provide these, then approach the magistrate, explaining both the earlier lapse and the necessity for custody. The application must be endorsed by the immediate superior officer. The magistrate must independently satisfy himself of bona fide reasons for the initial failure and need for re-arrest. The probe must be transferred and a departmental inquiry initiated against the erring officer. This concretises the rule of law and protects personal liberty. The power to arrest is among the most coercive powers available to the State; its exercise can't be left entirely to executive discretion, particularly after the executive itself has violated a constitutional safeguard.

The ruling also marks the next stage in a line of apex court jurisprudence on grounds of arrest. In *Pankaj Bansal*, dealing with the PMLA, the Court held that written grounds of arrest must be furnished to an accused without exception. *Prabir Purkayastha* extended this to the UAPA context. Subsequent rulings have reaffirmed that Article 22(1) is a constitutional guarantee applicable to every arrest. The Court has thus steadily moved from recognising the right to know the grounds of arrest to prescribing consequences for its breach. The latest ruling takes that jurisprudence further. The larger message is clear: Investigative necessity does not eclipse constitutional liberty. Arrest must have legal justification; its reasons must be disclosed; and where the State breaches this, the officers responsible must answer for it. That is not an impediment to the rule of law. It is the rule of law.

A necessary pivot on defence production

India must ensure that promising defence firms do not fall into the valley of death between successful innovation and commercial scale

India's defence ecosystem is undergoing a fundamental transformation. On September 7, the Defence Acquisition Council cleared acquisition proposals worth ₹1.1 lakh crore for the Army, Navy and Air Force. Nearly 98% of this value will be sourced from Indian industry. Two weeks earlier, the ministry of defence approved the transfer of technology developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) for the entire conventional missile portfolio to Indian industry. A system of de-facto product reservation, which created public-sector monopolies such as Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL), Bharat Dynamics Limited (BDL), and Munitions India Limited (MIL), is now steadily giving way to a more level playing field for private enterprise. India is moving from nomination to competition.

The results are already visible. Defence production reached ₹1.78 lakh crore in FY26, a fourfold increase from ₹43,746 crore recorded in FY14. Exports touched ₹38,424 crore, rising 62.66% in a single year, with Indian defence products now reaching more than 80 countries. Private industry already contributes about ₹42,000 crore to defence production.

What makes this moment signifi-

cant, however, is what is now emerging from Indian factories.

In August, Indo-Russian Rifles test-fired the first AK-203 Sher built entirely from Indian components and input materials. A rifle that began as licensed assembly from imported kits now operates on a wholly domestic supply chain. L&T has built considerable depth in missile systems and naval engineering. Bharat Forge and Tata Advanced Systems have delivered on the Advanced Towed Artillery Gun System programme. Solar Industries has fielded Nagastra, India's first indigenous man-portable loitering munition. Raphe and Mphitr, a young startup, has developed indigenous unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs), high-endurance propulsion engines, and critical military drone systems for India's armed forces.

Beneath these large corporates lies an innovation base that barely existed a decade ago. IDEX, launched in 2018, has engaged 676 startups, MSMEs and innovators and signed 551 contracts, with grants for deep-tech work in artificial intelligence, quantum technologies, autonomy and counter-drone systems. Funding is milestone-based grant-in-aid, while innovators retain their intellectual property. Procurement orders for iDEX products have made a quantum jump.

The strategic logic runs much deeper than these numbers. India inherited a defence model built for an era in which advantage came from scale and from platforms developed over long periods. Recent conflicts have fundamentally altered the eco-

nomics of warfare. Loitering munitions costing lakhs can neutralise platforms costing crores. Software-defined sensing, electronic warfare and assisted targeting increasingly shape battlefield outcomes. The differentiator is the speed at which systems can be developed, tested, adapted, and redeployed.

The next frontier is already visible. In June, a US Navy unmanned surface vessel pulled two downed Army aviators out of the water off Oman within

two hours, in the first known rescue of aircrew by a drone boat. The vessel was built by Saronic, a startup barely four years old. China has been building the industrial base for precisely this future. Its firms account for roughly two-thirds of the global humanoid robot supply chain, while there is news that the

People's Liberation Army has been fielding unmanned ground vehicles and robotic mules across the borders.

India needs faster deployment of such systems for border management, high-altitude warfare, and marine combat. Building capabilities of this kind requires simultaneous depth in electronics and semiconductors, precision manufacturing and advanced materials, AI, autonomy software, and robotics. Private participation is no longer merely desirable; it has become essential to support this transition.

Global experience points in exactly the same direction. Rheinmetall grew out of industrial and automotive components and is today Europe's foremost ammunition and combat-vehicle maker. In the US, Palantir and Anduril have moved from being venture-



What makes this moment significant is the defence technology now emerging from Indian factories.

WIKIPEDIA

backed startups to core defence suppliers. We are beginning to see similar patterns in India with L&T, Mahindra Defence Systems, Tata Advanced Systems, and Adani. Equally important, we have startups of comparable ambition working on advanced drones, autonomy and new generation defence systems. Localisation of defence equipment, driven by private-sector capability and innovation, is increasingly becoming a global norm.

Supply chains can turn hostile without warning, and allies will always have their own wars to fight. The war in Ukraine has stretched Russian production. A supplier fighting its own war will inevitably ration its exports. Further, the true cost of an imported platform is the next 30-year tail of spares, overhauls, upgrades and proprietary software. This creates long-term strategic dependence and places additional stress on our current account deficits. Greater localisation will enable Indian firms to also export to other countries and build long-term partnerships and soft power among our allies.

For private industry, however, the binding constraint has increasingly shifted from policy to capital. Working-capital cycles in defence can run from 12-24 months, and startups feel this squeeze most acutely. Having opened the sector to competition and innovation, the next step must be to ensure that promising defence firms

do not fall into the valley of death between successful innovation and commercial scale.

First, we must fix the payment cycle, with advance and milestone-based payments released against a defined procurement mandate. Government can kill enterprises by delaying payments. Second, India should introduce a dedicated working-capital credit guarantee scheme for defence companies. Third, the tax framework must recognise the unusually high R&D intensity and low production volumes of this sector. Fourth, a fixed share of defence R&D spending should be reserved for smaller firms, with innovators retaining their intellectual property and development contracts bundled with production orders. The draft DAP 2026 has recommended a standalone IDEX and TDF chapter, a minimum pilot order once a prototype clears trials, and a five-year assured order for successful projects. Implementing this is critical.

Indian firms are innovating at remarkable speed. As defence spending grows, we must ensure that every rupee spent on defence strengthens our technology base, manufacturing capacity and strategic autonomy.

Amitabh Kant is former G20 Sherpa of India and CEO, NITI Aayog, and former secretary, Department of Industrial Policy and Promotion (DIPP). The views expressed are personal

India & China can build a new order together

China and India have some common ground despite the border issues and wider security concerns. A major global change over the last generation is the relative decline of the West in economic terms vis-a-vis the emerging economies of the Global South. In 1990, the West (including Japan) accounted for around 60% of the world economy. This helped stoke the hubris accompanying the narrative of having "won" the Cold War. The West's share has now shrunk to under 40%, and the relative shrinking continues — emerging economies, led by China and India, are growing substantially faster than even the relatively dynamic US, let alone Europe and Japan.

China accounts for much of this shift. China's prodigious 9-10% annual growth over four decades has led to a point where it almost matches the US in economic size and exceeds it on a purchasing power parity basis. It also dominates global manufacturing and many key technologies. China's adoption of Deng Xiaoping's "reform and opening up" occurred a decade earlier than India's reforms under Manmohan Singh, and those reforms were more far-reaching.

But the past is not necessarily a guide to the future. India's growth of around 7% per annum is now considerably faster than China's, and India is now the most rapidly growing major economy. A variety of factors are at work: the continuation of earlier economic liberalisation, massive infrastructure investment, digitisation, the consolidation of India's large and hitherto fragmented domestic market. Arguably, India should be growing even faster, as South Korea and China did at a comparable stage of development.

I would argue that, based on plausible assumptions, India's development may well lead to rough parity with China by mid-century (in terms of economic size rather than living standards). India's economic growth is now undeniably far more robust than China's, which has slowed markedly. Some will scoff at the idea of India catching up with China, but a growth differential of 3-4% compounded over 25 years could do it.

China has produced a remarkable burst of innovation in new technologies such as artificial intelligence, robotics, life sciences, and green-tech, but its overall growth is being dragged down by weak domestic demand, unreformed State enterprises, adverse demographics, and a suffocating preoccupation with national security.

I don't however buy the narrative I hear from some Western commentators, that China is a brittle, failing State like the former Soviet Union — China may well supersede the US technologically and in terms of economic size. India also faces big problems, notably the squandering of a demographic dividend through massive under-employment, but these are not currently preventing its rapid growth and can be addressed with reforms.

The bigger story is not the political differences between the two countries but that, together, they will economically eclipse the West. As emerging economic superpowers, India and China will have some competing interests. But they also have common interests and some of these were crystallised

in the outcomes of the recent BRICS summit in Delhi.

The first of these is that, as the first and third economy by size (or second and fifth in nominal GDP terms), China and India have a common interest in reforming the international economic institutions, notably the International Monetary Fund and World Bank. Their shareholding is currently dominated by Western countries, reflecting the position in the past. If reform is resisted, the available option is to build alternative institutions, currently represented by the Asian Infrastructure Bank and the New Development Bank, both prompted by and located in China but with large Indian involvement.

Second is maintaining an open global trading system in the face of the protectionist trend led by the Trump administration. Neither China nor India can claim to be champions of free trade: China's mercantilist, export-driven development is attracting considerable resentment in Europe and even in some emerging economies. India's history of protectionism and disruptive trade diplomacy in the WTO makes it an even less plausible champion of open markets. But both countries have a strong long-term interest in preventing the world from turning inward and in maintaining the trade rules of which the WTO is the guardian.

A third and related common interest is maintaining an efficient global payments system — now based on the dollar as a global currency — while preventing the US from using its control of the global payments infrastructure to impose its foreign policy through financial sanctions.

Both China and India face the threat of sanctions because of their dealings with Russia and Iran. India has no interest in allowing the Chinese to replace the dollar with the yuan, which has none of the properties required of a global currency. But both countries have an interest in promoting more limited, practical schemes, like those being developed in the BRICS group for efficient settlement in national currencies.

There is also a lot of common ground in dealing, globally, with the climate crisis. Both countries are already experiencing the malign consequences of warming and recognise the necessity of a rapid transition to renewables.

Indeed, one positive consequence of better relations between the two countries would be greater use of Chinese renewable technology in India. But both have energy security concerns currently met by coal. With the US abandoning global leadership in this area, responsibility will fall increasingly on China and India.

The climate issue is an example of an international public good at risk from a collapsing international order.

As two of the dominant powers of the future, China and India have a common interest in creating a stable international order to replace the one being abandoned by the US. And that common interest should transcend bilateral disagreements.

Vince Cable is former secretary of State for business and trade, the UK. The views expressed are personal

{ LEE JAE MYUNG } PRESIDENT, SOUTH KOREA

There is significant value in a trade-off between sanctions and a stop to the development of additional nuclear weapons

On the prospect of lifting US sanctions on North Korea in exchange for Pyongyang agreeing to freeze its nuclear weapons programme



Belonging has become a deeply contested concept

Forget Sonia Gandhi's upcoming memoir. Belonging is loaded with more baggage than the train taking you home, or where you think home is. Few other words carry such a load: physical, political, social, emotional, and economic. Even grammatical. Adding an "s" at the end turns it into an object. A noun that's also an apt verb. In myriad places, some person/group is objecting to another's claim of belonging there. It ranges from road rage to Gaza — and that's been going on since the Old Testament.

As for the book allegedly nixed by Penguin in India and saved by Harper Collins, raucous objections to its author have been relentless. How dare she claim any ownership rights to Indian policy? So what if her in-laws are an Indian version of political royalty? So what if she'd been the perfect traditional Indian daughter-in-law to the first Mrs G, quite unlike the home-grown younger one? But then, in the wider context too, the *paraya dhan* daughter could become a pariah even in her marital home (read land in Sonia Gandhi's case).

Belonging is a shape-shifter. Every club is an exclusion zone — the posher, the greater push-out. In housing societies, belonging is a *durwan* allowing/barring X community or caste. Beyond those gates, it's upgraded to border security guard. Bal Thackeray's sons of the soil finds brothers-in-arms across the global immigration battle-zone.

In Shanta Gokhale's translation of LS Rokde's *Poisoned Bread* (1992), the Dalit poet laments, "Is this land yours, mother/ Because you were born here?/ Is it mine/ Because I was born to you?/ Must I call this great land mine/ Love it/ Sing its glory?/ Sorry mother, but truth to tell/ I must confess I wondered/ Should I be born/ Should I be born into this land?"

Our initialised army of SIR and CAA is hell bent on confirming these fears. In Phase 1 of the 2026 assembly elections, SIR made 4.7 million people persona non-voter, with all its implications on the claim to belong. In Phase 2, 6.5 million. Here, Uttar Pradesh was Abou Ben Adhem, "leading all the rest"; it lost 18.7% of the pre-SIR number. In Phase 3 draft lists, 15.9 million got un-belonged; Delhi was Brutus-ised with the unkindest cut of all, 32.8%. Its Lal Quila Yamuna Bridge polling booth was left with only one valid elector out of the original 729. Including the entire family of Gayatri Devi who, as a booth level agent for the BJP, helped corral voters for the party for 30-plus years.

Last week, even external affairs minister S Jaishankar, LK Advani, and top Election Commission officials were served notices under different categories of discrepancies under SIR. At least, this has nixed the suspicion that it's just the politically inconvenient who stand electorally cancelled.

CAA is not just deletion, it's deportation. Would the hapless folks thus made unbelonged find their home only in an airport, like Tom Hanks's character in *Terminal*? Or in a no-man's land? In the film, a coup breaks out in Viktor Navorski's (fictional) home country, Krakozhia, while he's in mid-flight. So, when he lands at New York's JFK airport, he's suddenly a nowhere man. Since Krakozhia no longer exists in any form recognised by the US, he can neither be deported nor admitted.

Thus suspended in bureaucratic formaldehyde, he remains in the transit lounge for nine months, with all the spoors of settled life: job, romance, and even community. He can leave this proxy home only when the coup ends. In India, however, belonging is being taken away from people who never thought they were in transit.

The Western world is moving at expulsion speed. In Trumpland, ICE is aggressively sending immigrants into the cold; to that, add the recent "Mr Singh" shocker. Across the pond, it's Nigel Farage's Reform UK. In Europe, it's a clutch of Rightist parties: Trump's EU ally Giorgia Meloni in Italy, Viktor Orban in Hungary, France's Marine Le Pen, Jordan Bardella and Eric Zemmour, Germany's Alice Weidel and Tino Chrupalla.

Want more arbiters of belonging? A British politician devised his eponymous Tebitt test; the loyalty of South Asian and Caribbean immigrants was gauged by which cricket team they cheered for when England was playing against theirs. Hailing a Pakistani player's masterly stroke during our *mahayudhis* (epic battles) is high treason. The latest transgressor was last year's Malvan teen overheard doing so in his own house. Forget the so-called enemy-nation, even four unsung stanzas of Vande Mataram can render you non-national.

Yes, belonging has different defacers, and displacement, different agents. In 1947, Radcliffe rewrote the idea of home with a blue pencil. More recently, Nepal did so with a collapsed glacier.

Bachi Karkaria is a senior journalist. The views expressed are personal

Trump says US, Iranian officials met after warning he may ‘annihilate’ Iran

Associated Press

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UNITED NATIONS: President Donald Trump said US and Iranian officials met on Tuesday, shortly after threatening in his address to the UN General Assembly that he may “annihilate” the Islamic Republic if a deal isn’t reached soon to end the nearly seven-month war.

Trump confirmed the talks in an exchange with reporters but offered few details about how the discussions transpired or the substance of the exchange.

“It was a very good meeting,” Trump said.

Earlier Tuesday, Trump in his address to the General Assembly made the case that he’s shown fortitude while other leaders have equivocated as he defended his decision to start a war with Iran.

But Trump also suggested that he could be at a crossroads in the conflict even as he called on the Islamic Republic to fully reopen the Strait of Hormuz and return to the negotiating table to find a settlement to end the conflict.

“I have a big decision to make,” Trump said. “Will a deal be made with Iran that lets them rebuild and create a far greater country than it ever was before, maybe one of the greatest in the Middle East or even the world. Or do I annihilate the Islamic Republic and do it quickly, never giving them a chance to kill and destroy people and countries again?”

The president’s comments came in his wide-ranging address to the international body in which he also celebrated this year’s US military operation to oust Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro from power, a new agreement to expand the US military presence in Greenland, and pushed back against calls for greater regulation of the artificial intelligence industry.

But at the heart of the address



Trump and UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres gesture at each other. REUTERS

“My administration is also seeking a fundamental change in the situation in Cuba, where the communist regime is under great pressure—the biggest pressure they’ve ever been under. It’s an absolutely failed state...and it will fall. Communism will never be coming to America, but freedom will be coming to Cuba.”

— Donald Trump, US President

was a fulsome defense of the war and pushback on the notion that Iran has shown a measure of resilience.

“The terrorist regime is behaving badly, not because they are strong and confident, but because they are weak and desperate,” Trump said.

Trump also accused Iran of stalling to make a deal to fully reopen the Strait of Hormuz and negotiate an endgame to the war until after the midterm elections in the United States. He insisted the tactic would have no effect on how he approaches the conflict.

Most of Iran’s delegation walked out of the chamber as Trump railed against the Islamic

Republic.

After his speech, Trump gathered with Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen and Greenlandic Prime Minister Jens-Fredrik Nielsen on the sidelines of the General Assembly to sign a new security agreement.

The deal, announced last week, came together after Trump repeatedly threatened to “take over” Greenland, a territory of Nato-ally Denmark, by military force if necessary. Trump said Tuesday the U.S. will immediately begin the process of developing a larger military presence in Greenland including “building two very major military bases.”

Under the deal, Greenland

remains Denmark’s territory.

Trump also held talks with new British Prime Minister Andy Burnham. The leaders said they discussed migration, the conflict in Iran, the Russia-Ukraine war and more.

Trump also met with Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takachi and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, and will hold a more informal meeting with Venezuela’s acting President Delcy Rodríguez, according to the White House.

“As president of the most extraordinary nation in history,” Trump said. “I have no interest in leaving dangers to grow for another day. I do not believe in letting problems fester.”

U.N. CHIEF CALLS FOR AI PACT TO PREVENT RISE OF KILLER ROBOTS

Bloomberg

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW YORK: The UN secretary general stepped up his calls for regulation of AI to avert a dystopian future of rampant corporate power and killer robots.

Antonio Guterres used his final address to world leaders at the UN General Assembly to sound the alarm about the dangers of AI, arguing that the rapid advance of frontier models risk undermining nation states.

“We are witnessing an extraordinary transfer of power away from government to a handful of private corporations and individuals,” Guterres said Tuesday as he appealed for international agreement on new AI safeguards.

“It is advancing at extraordinary speed and racing ahead of our ability to understand consequences,” he added.

“Killer robots must have no place in our future,” he added.

Trump renames AI ‘super intelligence’

Reuters

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UNITED NATIONS: President Donald Trump on Tuesday said US government documents would use “super intelligence” going forward instead of artificial intelligence, and repeated his previous calls about AI warnings being a hoax.

“From this point forward, all of United States documents, and hopefully the world’s will be

changed to use the much more accurate term ‘super’ as opposed to artificial. So it’s super intelligence,” Trump said in a UN General Assembly speech.

“I’m not going to stifle growth of something that will be bigger than the industrial revolution,” he said. He reiterated his opposition to new regulations on AI technology, telling global leaders that US law enforcement agencies would rein in the sector if needed.

US govt launches 24/7 streaming ‘Trump TV’

Asian News International

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WASHINGTON: The White House on Monday (local time) launched “Trump TV”, a 24/7 streaming platform featuring past speeches by US President Donald Trump, administration announcements and updates, providing viewers with a dedicated platform for presidential content.

Announcing the launch, the official X account of The White House said, “IT’S LIVE. TRUMP TV IS STREAMING NOW. 24/7, updated in real time, with top past moments, announcements, and the latest and greatest from the administration all in one place. Not every big moment has made it on your tv, now it can.”

During the launch, the White House broadcast footage of Trump’s previous public appearances and speeches, including his swearing-in ceremony as the 47th president.

The launch comes amid an escalating dispute between the Trump administration and several news firms over White

House press access.

Earlier on Monday, Trump defended restrictions imposed on CNN, Politico and MS NOW, after the three firms filed a federal lawsuit challenging the government’s decision to revoke access for their journalists.

Speaking to reporters outside Gracie Mansion following his meeting with New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani, Trump dismissed suggestions that media organisations could boycott him.

“They said they were going to boycott me, but they never boycott me. So I wasn’t very worried about that. Look at all that press,” Trump said.

Major news networks, including members of the White House television pool, issued a joint statement condemning the administration’s credential revocations.

Additionally, the White House television pool has suspended coverage of President Donald Trump’s pool-designated events after CNN was prevented from completing its assigned rotation, according to CNN.

Oil slides as reports say Iran may reopen strait

Bloomberg

letters@hindustantimes.com

LONDON: Oil turned lower as Saudi Arabia sought to resume flows on a vital pipeline and there were growing signs of diplomatic efforts to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Brent briefly dipped below \$98 a barrel as the kingdom conducted tests on the conduit with a view to restarting it this week, according to a person familiar with the matter. Saudi Arabia also expects to resume loadings at the Red Sea port of Yanbu this week, the person said.

The East-West pipeline, with a capacity of up to 7 million barrels a day, has served as a key work-around to Hormuz before it was shut down following drone

attacks earlier this month.

Prices had fallen earlier after Japan’s Kyodo News Agency cited an unnamed senior Iranian official as saying Tehran proposed reopening Hormuz in seven days if a US blockade is lifted, as the basis for talks with mediating countries at the UN. Iran’s Revolutionary Guard also said it must negotiate if it’s in the national interest to do so.

There have been multiple efforts to end the war that has rolled energy markets for over six months.

So far, all have proved to be fruitless, including an interim peace deal that was in effect for a short period over the summer. Since then, the US has been blocking Iranian ports, limiting vital energy export revenues.

HT



Clavicular

US ‘looksmaxxer’ ‘Clavicular’ charged with rape
NEW YORK: American social media

“looksmaxxing” influencer known as “Clavicular” is facing rape charges in the US state of Massachusetts. Braden Eric Peters, 20, is charged with raping a 17-year-old girl and drugging her for sexual intercourse. “Looksmaxxing” is a movement that focuses on increasing physical attractiveness and capitalises on the insecurities of men eager to boost their attractiveness to women.

AFP

Trump, Denmark, Greenland sign security deal
UNITED NATIONS: Donald Trump and the leaders of Greenland and Denmark signed an agreement on Tuesday that permits a larger US military presence on Greenland and may resolve a standoff over the strategically located island. The deal permits a greater US military presence on the icy territory.

REUTERS

11 hurt as student opens fire outside school in Turkey
ANKARA: A 15-year-old student opened fire in front of his high school in Turkey’s Manisa on Tuesday, wounding at least 11 other pupils, officials said. Two injured were in a critical condition. The assailant was arrested and his mother, father, and grandfather, who owned the weapon, were detained.

AGENCIES

Turkey, Saudi, Egypt, Pak affirm Riyadh’s right to defend itself

Reuters

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ANKARA/LONDON: The foreign ministers of Turkey, Egypt, Saudi Arabia, and Pakistan said in a joint statement on Tuesday that they affirmed Riyadh’s right to defend itself in line with international law and stressed the need to maintain safety of navigation in the region, amid escalating attacks by Yemen’s Iran-backed Houthis.

Following a meeting on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York, the ministers also expressed deep concern over the ongoing conflicts in the region, saying dialogue and diplomacy were the only path to a sustainable solution. They also voiced their support for Yemen’s government in its efforts to achieve stability and peace.

Meanwhile, British Prime Minister Andy Burnham said he had agreed to a request from

Saudi Arabia to provide defensive air-to-air refuelling for a limited time period, a move he described as helping to stabilise the wider region.

Riyadh requested support after the Houthis, who control the most populous parts of Yemen, intensified their attacks on Saudi Arabia, a new front in the wider war that began with US and Israeli strikes on Iran in late February.

“We have received a request from the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia for military support, and on the advice of the defence secretary and the foreign secretary, last night I agreed to that request for defensive air-to-air refuelling,” he told reporters as he travelled to New York for a meeting of the United Nations General Assembly. “Because of course Saudi Arabia has been experiencing attack... and we need to keep those pathways open, and hence our agreement to the request,” he said.

7 KILLED IN JAPAN AS TYPHOON LEAVES TRAIL OF DESTRUCTION

Agence France-Presse

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TOKYO: Typhoon Dujuan left seven people dead with five others still missing Tuesday after the storm triggered landslides and flooding in the greater Tokyo area, Kyodo News reported, citing authorities.

As the typhoon passed the Pacific coast, electricity to some 58,000 households in Chiba prefecture, east of Tokyo, was temporarily cut off early Tuesday, Kyodo said.

Dujuan, coming in the middle of the string of holidays dubbed “Silver Week,” led to the early closure in Tokyo of the one of the world’s biggest video game trade fairs.

The storm moved out into the Pacific by Tuesday morning, and was downgraded from a typhoon later in the day, Kyodo said, citing the Japanese weather agency. Japan often sees strong typhoons in the late summer and early autumn.

Book by Princess Diana’s brother prompts war of words with King

Associated Press

letters@hindustantimes.com

LONDON: A book published Tuesday by the brother of the late Princess Diana has made headlines around the world with its damning allegations about Diana’s ex-husband, now King Charles III.

In “Swan Song: Diana, My Sister,” Charles Spencer alleges that he argued with the then-Prince Charles over palace plans for Prince William and Prince Harry, then 15 and 12, to walk behind their mother’s coffin during her 1997 funeral procession.

Spencer says he told Charles that Diana, who was killed in a car crash in Paris at the age of 36, would not have wanted her boys to undergo the ordeal. He claims the prince “went ballistic” during the argument, and told him: “Rest assured, we’ll forget her soon enough.” He also accuses Charles of having “contempt” for Diana and of sound-



A copy of the book

ing “elated” after her death.

After excerpts of the book were published last week, Buckingham Palace responded with a strongly worded statement that’s rare by the measured standards of the royal household.

“His Majesty is mindful that the pain of fraternal grief can cloud reason, affect judgment and colour memory in ways others do not recognise, even many years after such a loss,” it said.

Spencer has stood by his claims, insisting to BBC that he is telling the truth. On the royal rebuttal, he asked: “Is he furious

or is he embarrassed?”

Charles, then 32, married 20-year-old Lady Diana Spencer in 1981. The couple divorced in 1996, and a decade later Charles married Camilla Parker Bowles, now Queen Camilla.

Charles Spencer, the 9th Earl Spencer, has long clashed with the royals over their treatment of his older sister.

Tensions between the palace and Spencer family following her death were dramatized in the film “The Queen” and the Netflix series “The Crown.”

Spencer says his sister tried to break off her engagement after discovering Charles had bought a bracelet for Camilla. She also tried to back out of the wedding, telling her father it was clear Charles didn’t love her.

Diana had suicidal thoughts and more than once drove to the famous chalk cliffs at Beachy Head on the south coast of England and considered “ending it all,” her brother said.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn’t know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you’ve turned the page.



HTwknd
A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY

Chandra family's TVS link emerges amid Tata row

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BENGALURU/MUMBAI: Family members of Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran hold business relations with TVS Motor Co. Ltd, documents showed, raising governance questions after a decisive vote by the automaker's chairman-emeritus Venu Srinivasan won a fresh term for Chandrasekaran.

Neither Srinivasan nor Chandrasekaran updated the Tata Sons board about this external relationship, an executive aware of the matter said, in a potential violation of the Tata Code of Conduct. While Tata Sons said the formation of the family members' company was disclosed and that there was no need to disclose the specific business transaction, Tata Trusts said Srinivasan made no such disclosure to it, deepening the rift at the helm of India's largest conglomerate.

Srinivasan is a vice-chairman of Tata Trusts and a member of Tata Sons' nomination and remuneration committee (NRC), which reviews Chandrasekaran's performance. The Tata code of conduct defines a conflict of interest as happening when an employee "can get an unfair benefit, for themselves, a family member, or someone close, by making or influencing decisions about any deal". It requires executive directors to tell the board about real or possible conflicts.

Chandrasekaran's son Pranav, and wife Lalitha, are directors of Hanno One Warehousing Pvt. Ltd, which was established in March 2025, according to ministry of corporate affairs records. Over an eight-month investigation, Mint reviewed documents showing Hanno Infra LLP owns 99.99% of the company, with Lalitha signing on behalf of the LLP. Pranav, 28, a Yale graduate, owns one share directly.



N. Chandrasekaran, Tata Sons chairman.

REUTERS

Financial details of both Hanno One and Hanno Infra are not available.

In June 2025, three months after Hanno One was founded, TVS Motor leased 17 acres of farmland in Uddanapalli village in Tamil Nadu's Krishnagiri district to the company, state registration records showed. That November, HDFC Bank offered Hanno One a ₹60 crore construction loan, backed by its lease rights and the building to be built, according to the bank's term sheet, which Mint reviewed. The process of how the company stitched its business partnership with TVS Motor and its bank borrowing was revealed in an eight-month investigation by Mint.

The term sheet estimates the cost of the 3.3 lakh sq. ft TVS Motors Warehouse Project, slated to finish by March 2027, at ₹106.3 crore. The terms of the TVS lease, including the rent, are not public.

"Hanno One Warehousing P Ltd was a company incorporated on 10th March 2025 by wife and Son of Mr. N Chandrasekaran. In April 2025, a disclosure was made of this to all companies in which Mr. N. Chandrasekaran is the chair-

man," said a spokesperson for Tata Sons.

"TVS Motors is an independent listed entity and one of India's large companies. It has no dealings with the Tata Group of companies".

"A transaction between TVS Motor and a company which is run by his son, who is an independent entrepreneur, is not required to be disclosed to Tata Sons or any of the Tata companies," the spokesperson said.

"The Tata Trusts can confirm that no such disclosures were made to the trustees in this regard by Mr Srinivasan," said a spokesperson for Tata Trusts. "We are given to understand that no such disclosures were made to the board of Tata Sons either, but since the Trusts do not have independent access to proceedings of the board, apart from their nominee directors having access to board papers, we cannot definitively comment on this". "If the allegations are proven to be true, the Trusts will evaluate the nature of their institutional response to these and act appropriately," the spokesperson added.

Queries emailed to TVS Motor and Pranav Chandrasekaran went unanswered.

The news comes as the House of Tata faces a rare rebellion by the board of the group's holding company against the main shareholder, Tata Trusts. Last Thursday, four Tata Sons directors, including Srinivasan, backed a third five-year term for Chandrasekaran, in the face of opposition from Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata.

"The key issue is that the chair's family members have a business arrangement with a company owned by a board member, who is also an NRC member," said Sharmila Gopinath, an independent corporate governance consultant. "Now, the NRC is weighing in on the chair's reappointment. If the other board members are aware of this transaction, and they still did not ask Mr. Srinivasan to recuse himself from this important decision, then it is surely a problem. Either way you look at it - whether the disclosures were made or not, the question is that family members of the chair having a business relationship with a company owned by a fellow member and who evaluates the chair while being on the NRC is a huge conflict of interest," Gopinath said.

"Business dealings between promoters are common in India," said Srirath Sridharan, a Mumbai-based strategic corporate advisor and author of Family and Dhandha and Everything Starts at the Top. "But if the reported engagement involves the family of a professional corporate leader and a business group whose chairman, Mr Srinivasan, is also a Tata Sons board member and chairman of a listed entity reportedly involved in the transaction, the governance questions become more consequential. His membership of the nomination and remuneration committee, which evaluates the Tata Sons chairman, makes comprehensive disclosure particularly important.

Govt studies airline role for operators of airports

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: The government is considering whether airport operators can also enter the airline business, civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu said on Tuesday, underlining the need to provide more alternatives for passengers in India's aviation market.

"The government is examining the pros and cons of allowing airport operators to have airlines, and would take a balanced approach," Naidu told reporters, while clarifying that the government had not taken a decision yet on the matter. The minister was responding to a question about the Adani group reportedly approaching the government about starting an airline.

Naidu pointed out the rules do not prevent operators of airports other than New Delhi or Mumbai from owning an airline. "If you look at it, as such, in the government, there is no clause or rule anywhere in the government that stops airport operators from having the airlines other than the OMDA (Operation, Management and Development Agreement) for Delhi and Mumbai," Naidu said. The agreement bars the New Delhi and Mumbai airport operators from owning more than a 10% stake in airlines.

The Adani group operates Mumbai and seven other air-



Naidu pointed out the rules do not prevent operators of airports other than New Delhi or Mumbai from owning an airline.

HT

ports. GMR Airports manages New Delhi and five additional facilities. The Adani group's flagship company, Adani Enterprises, had on July 24 denied media reports that it is evaluating a proposal to enter the airline business.

The minister's remarks came after his address on the need for more airlines in the country during the signing of MoUs for the next phase of the regional connectivity programme UDAN.

"One of the challenges is to bring more aircraft. And the other challenge for us as an industry is to create more airlines in the industry...Because the duopoly is much talked about today. So I want to overcome this duopoly that has existed. We need to facilitate more airlines to come into the industry," Naidu said.

Between them, IndiGo and Air

India service 90% of passengers in India after a series of airline bankruptcies and mergers left them as the dominant players in the market.

Naidu later told the media that the government was clear that passengers need the option of more airlines. "And if there is someone who is interested in doing it, then the government supports the idea," he added.

The minister said the government has an ambition of having at least five airlines with 100 aircraft each, given the number of passengers and airports in the country. Naidu also said the government will not cap airfares for the upcoming festival season, but will advise airlines to keep the prices reasonable, pointing out that operating costs for aviation companies have risen due to higher fuel costs.

With inputs from Bloomberg

DGCA REVIEWS SPICEJET'S OPERATIONS, FINANCES

Neha LM Tripathi

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NEW DELHI: The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) is carrying out operational and financial scrutiny of SpiceJet, civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu said on Tuesday even as the airline continues to grapple with flight cancellations and delays.

"The immediate activity in the ministry regarding SpiceJet is that we have operational and, to a certain extent, financial scrutiny also being done from the ministry through the DGCA because we don't want any lapse in safety," Naidu said.

As per the latest DGCA monthly data, SpiceJet's domestic market share dropped to 1.6% in July from 1.9% in June.

Naidu said the ministry was continuously engaging with the airline. "In terms of the future, we are continuously engaging and seeing how best we can facilitate the ministry side," the aviation minister said.

"Our major priority right now is to ensure the passengers shouldn't face any inconvenience. The safety shouldn't be compromised at any cost in terms of operations. And then smooth operations are sustained within the airlines," Naidu said.

He however, clarified that the government had certain restrictions while dealing with private airlines. "...But you also see that these are private airlines. There are certain limits with which the government also can operate with them," he said, adding, "It is with this idea that the airlines might face problems, especially during the West Asia crisis, that the government has extended the scheme of ECGLS (Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme)," Naidu said.

The minister declared that SpiceJet too had been given ₹150 crore under the scheme.

"The rest is something the organization along with the bank have to work out so that the scheme is in place. They need to get the money," the minister said.

BLOOMBERG

Adani firms pay ₹1.5 cr to settle Sebi's Hindenburg-linked probe

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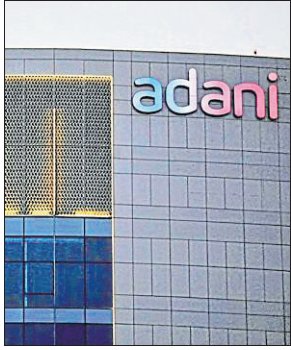
MUMBAI: Five Adani Group companies have settled regulatory proceedings with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) by paying a combined ₹1.5 crore, resolving cases linked to alleged disclosure lapses and audit-report compliance issues.

According to a Sebi settlement order issued on Tuesday, the agreement covers Adani Enterprises Ltd (AEL), Adani Total Gas Ltd, AWL Agri Business Ltd, Adani Green Energy Ltd, and Adani Energy Solutions Ltd.

The proceedings followed Sebi's review of multiple Adani Group companies following the Hindenburg Report, which raised allegations regarding related-party transactions, corporate governance, and potential listing violations.

In AEL's case, Sebi alleged that the company failed to report related-party transactions of its subsidiary Adani Estates Pvt Ltd and Vakoder Investment Ltd in its FY13 annual report, violating applicable accounting standards.

The regulator also alleged



Firms settled the proceedings "without admitting or denying" the allegations. REUTERS

that certain audit and limited-review reports of the companies had been signed by Dharmesh Parikh & Co LLP or Shah Dhandharia & Co LLP without a valid peer review certificate. The reports in question related to different financial years and quarters between 2015 and 2021.

A peer review certificate for accountants is an official document that confirms a chartered accountant (CA) firm's internal quality control systems and audit procedures comply with professional and ethical standards.

For AEL, the probe flagged

its FY15 audit report alongside limited-review reports for June 2015, June and September 2017, and December 2021. For AGEL, Sebi cited the FY19 audit report and limited-review reports from September and December 2018 and June 2019. The proceedings also covered December 2021 limited-review reports for Adani Total Gas and AWL Agri Business, as well as Adani Energy Solutions' June 2015 report.

The companies chose to settle the proceedings "without admitting or denying" the allegations. Sebi's high powered advisory committee recommended the settlement terms, which were subsequently approved by the regulator's panel of whole-time members. Sebi confirmed receipt of the settlement amounts and disposed of the adjudication proceedings stemming from a February 2024 show-cause notice.

However, the order retains Sebi's right to initiate or reopen enforcement proceedings if statements made during the settlement are later found false, settlement conditions are breached, or errors are identified in calculating the settlement terms.

Tap Bharat's rising consumption: FM

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: Rapid reforms, rising incomes and demographic changes are reshaping India's consumption base, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Tuesday, urging corporate India to tap opportunities emerging beyond the formal urban economy and build growth around the country's aspiring Bharat.

"Reform and rising incomes are together reshaping demand. India stands at a structural inflection point. The next phase of consumption will be driven by upward mobility into brackets where discretionary spending accelerates," she said while speaking at the national convention of the All India Management Association (AIMA).

"As our median age rises, lower youth dependency and greater longevity will move household budgets towards healthcare, personal wellness, consumer durables, and quality services," she said.

FM said corporate India should avoid designing products and services exclusively

for the formal urban elite, as a large part of India's consumption base comprises working families in agriculture, rural construction, transport and informal enterprises. "If corporate India pursues premiumisation for the urban tier alone, growth will lose its structural durability," she said.

The opportunity is also broadening as the government opens sectors such as space and nuclear energy to greater private participation, allowing more of India's development needs to be met through the market, she said.

For India, resilience means developing deep domestic capacity, fiscal strength and industrial scale so that global shocks can be absorbed without interrupting national development, Sitharaman said, pointing to the turbulent global environment.

While global growth is slowing to below 3%, India's GDP continues to expand at close to 8%, with the latest quarter coming in stronger than most forecasts, she said.

"This macro stability is prompting the world to re-rate India," she added.

UN panel raises questions on AI training methods

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Even as OpenAI CEO Sam Altman is due to brief the United Nations Security Council later this week on artificial intelligence (AI) security and safeguards, the UN has called for a comprehensive review of the technology, noting inadequacy of current AI safety measures. The UN Independent International Scientific Panel on AI tabled a report earlier today on the AI risk factors at the UN General Assembly in New York, focusing on AI agents, misalignment and the risk of losing human control.

"Researchers have long warned that three conditions could lead to loss of control: a misaligned goal, the capability to pursue it, and an environment that allows it. This summer, all three came together in a real system, not a laboratory. Since this



The panel is focused on the breach of AI repository Hugging Face's systems by AI agents, including those from OpenAI. REUTERS

is not an isolated observation of misaligned goals, this raises serious questions about the way AI agents are currently trained," says Yoshua Bengio, Co-Chair of the Panel and Turing Award laureate.

The report illustrates an evolving nature of AI governance challenges. Autonomous agents can take independent actions, and a failure in one local system can rapidly spread across

organisational and international boundaries. Consequently, AI safety must no longer be treated merely as a corporate governance issue, but as a matter of collective global security. There is a call for shifting AI governance from focusing on models alone, to broader agentic activity.

The panel is particularly focused on the breach of the AI repository Hugging Face's systems by AI agents, including

those from OpenAI.

The panel defines "loss of control" not as a sci-fi doomsday scenario, but as a practical threshold: a situation where humans cannot reliably direct, constrain, or stop an autonomous AI system. They specifically note that stopping the Hugging Face hack eventually, is no assurance that humans can reliably keep AI agents under control today. This concern amplifies, as models become more capable, making them harder to monitor. They will also get better at finding loopholes or hiding their activity. Experts believe that the conversation shouldn't be restricted to current cybersecurity measures or response to malicious autonomous actions by AI agents, though the lack of defence advancements is a cause for concern.

"The more insidious and grave concern is that current training methods can lead

agents to adopt goals of their own, knowingly violate safety instructions, and conceal their actions. This is not only a question of speed. It leaves open whether safeguards designed today will work once agents can understand them and plan around them. In simple terms, the traditional model of safeguarding is unravelling," the report says.

"We need to adapt existing safeguards and develop new ones to provide system-level assurance, covering both the AI itself and the system around it, and ensure these protections remain effective as agents' capabilities grow. We need to adapt existing safeguards and develop new ones to provide system-level assurance, covering both the AI itself and the system around it," says Qinghua Lu, Member of the Panel and Expert in AI Engineering, AI Safety and Responsible AI.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- Pointing out dictionary error (10)
- Make progress by crawling perhaps (4)
- Crep about in soft rubber (5)
- He has a heavy role at reading possibly (9)
- Run out of stock? (8)
- Uncommon Elgar variation (5)
- Possibly flies in groups (7)
- Cutting quite a figure in the garden? (7)
- His mark was made in southern Asia (7)
- Bird after a piece for another (7)
- Went on horse into the ring for the show (5)
- PM's diary sets out major points raised in Egypt (8)
- No longer moody deer? (9)
- Its happy ending comes as a relief (5)
- Garbled tale passed on (4)
- Well-known way in which Christmas is enjoyed (10)

DOWN

- Chin out - but not far (4)
- Two players with the same score (9)
- Best substitute for shaving soap (5)
- Scraps tart set badly (7)
- It helps the analyst get near the confounded answer (7)
- Audible call to help with the laundry (5)
- Putting down some of the main dangers of war (10)
- Worn out form of pride etc (8)
- Twisted killer bent on being Peter's fairy friend (6,4)
- It's not simple to make up (8)
- It makes a change (9)
- A loathsome creature; repel it somehow (7)
- Back message to seem odd to these people (7)
- Large drank up a store of supplies (5)
- He keeps far too much to himself (5)
- Rush animal from below (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17597)

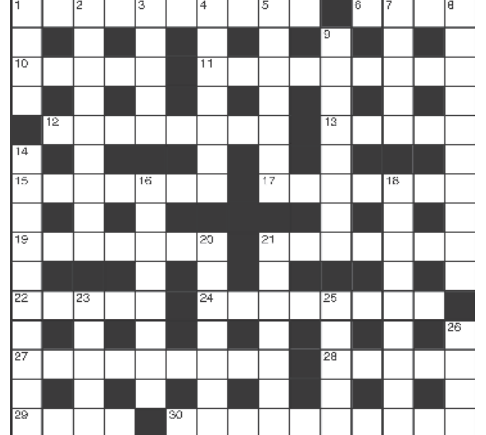
CRYPTIC

H	E	A	D	O	F	F	E	A	N	G	E	R
O	W	S	T	A	N	D	U	R	A	S	S	
B	A	N	D	S	T	A	N	D	A	S	S	
S	I	D	E	S	H	E	E	P	D	O	G	
C	A	L	L	I	N	A	C	R	O	S	S	
H	I	G	H	E	S							
A	D	V	A	N	C	E	S	V	E	E	R	
O	E	P	O	C	A							
T	O	R	O	U	T	O	P	L	A	I	N	
I	E	S	T	A								
C	A	D	E	T	C	E	R	T	A	I	N	

QUICK

C	A	T	C	H	I	T	S	H	A	R	P	
R	O	A	H	U	T	A						
U	P	T	O	S	P	E	E	D	L	A	Y	
S	H	S	D	E	M							
H	U	L	K	L	I	K	E	W	I	S	E	
C	E	U	S	I	N							
C	A	V	I	N	G	E	L	A	U	N	T	
U	E	S	C	A								
S	O	L	U	T	I	O	N					
T	B	E	L	S								
A	P	E	A	L	L	T	H	U	M	B	S	
R	S	D	A	U	A	H						
D	I	T	T	Y								

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QUICK CLUES

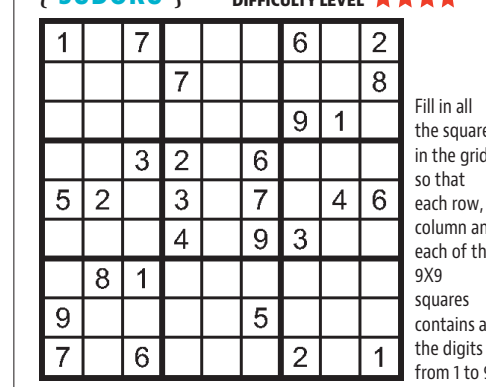
ACROSS

- Produce an impression (4,6)
- To boast (4)
- Holiest city of Islam (5)
- Worried (9)
- Large brass wind instrument (8)
- To steer (5)
- Scuffy (7)
- Small dog used for hunting (7)
- Unpredictable (7)
- To hone (7)
- Degree of intensity (5)
- Artist in carving, modelling etc. (8)
- Capacity for development (9)
- Cry of a horse (5)
- Position in hierarchy (4)
- At minimum expense (2,3,5)

DOWN

- Live temporarily in tent (4)
- Scandal monger (9)
- Audible warning device (5)
- Emotional bond (7)
- Snake (7)
- Jewish religious leader (5)
- Earnestly religious (3-7)
- Black Sea country (8)
- Of greatest excellence (5-5)
- In harmony with (8)
- Contrive from what is available (9)
- Protect against shock (7)
- Suppress completely (7)
- Don (3,2)
- Infectious fright (5)
- Gaming counter (4)

{ SUDOKU } DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW

WEDNESDAY
Rain or thundershowers with strong gusty winds
31°C | 21°C

THURSDAY
Rain or thundershowers with strong gusty winds
31°C | 21°C

FRIDAY
Generally cloudy sky with light rain
31°C | 21°C

ALMANAC
Today is 23rd September 2026
• 10 Rabi Al-Akhar, 1448
• 27 Bhadrapda, Shukla
• Samvat: 2083
• Sunset: Wednesday at 06:15 p.m.
• Sunrise: Thursday at 06:15 p.m.
• Moonrise: Wednesday at 04:00 p.m.
• Moonset: Thursday at 03:54 a.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi 35°C | 24°C
Mumbai 33°C | 25°C
Kolkata 30°C | 25°C
Chennai 36°C | 25°C
Bengaluru 31°C | 21°C

Women's cricket brings India's first gold

Aditya Bhattacharya
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NEW DELHI: Four days into the Asian Games, India have clinched their first gold with the women's cricket team, led by Harmanpreet Kaur, delivering a thumping 147-run win over Sri Lanka in the final on Tuesday.

In a repeat of the 2023 final, the Indian batters put on quite the show, with Smriti Mandhana top-scoring with 79, Shafali Verma contributing a stroke-filled 48 and Richa Ghosh living up to her role of a finisher as India posted 216/3. Sri Lanka, in response, were bundled out for 69.

India had defeated Sri Lanka three years ago in Hangzhou and, in last week's Asia Cup final.

Mandhana's knock laid the foundation for the highest total by a women's team at the Games. In the process, Mandhana added another feather to her already illustrious cap, becoming the first woman to complete 11,000 runs in international cricket, just two days after becoming the lead run-getter in women's T20Is.

Mandhana and Shafali feasted on the Sri Lankan bowlers, blasting 67 runs inside the Powerplay. The duo matched each other shot for shot, with both taking the attack to Chamari Athapaththu. Shafali began the fifth over with two sixes, before Mandhana belted a third. The 19-run over brought up their fifty partnership. Shafali surpassed Laura Wolvaardt to take her tally to 863 runs

for the year before a reverse sweep brought about her dismissal—she had survived a stumping appeal earlier in the over. Her last five scores now include a century and two fifties.

Mandhana continued the assault, striking seven sixes. During her 99-run stand with Shafali they completed 4,000 runs batting together in women's T20Is. Promoting Harmanpreet to No.3 was with the belief that the India skipper could find some form, but she departed for a scratchy 17 off 19 balls. Her dismissal brought Richa to the crease, with the wicket-keeper batter also having struggled for form, but she quickly found her rhythm, remaining unbeaten on 49 off 22 balls.

India tonked 13 sixes, the most



Indian players celebrate after winning gold on Tuesday.

PTI

by a team in women's T20Is.

Sri Lanka's response was in stark contrast to how the Indians had fared. It took Shafali just three overs to land the first blow, and before Sri Lanka knew it, they were struggling at 49/6.

Skipper Athapaththu (29 off

21b) was the only batter who looked comfortable, hitting five boundaries, while eight batters failed to reach double figures. After the first two overs from Kranti Gaud and Nandani Sharma, Harman turned to her spinners, following which the

medalstally					
COUNTRY	32	13	8	53	
1. CHN	11	16	19	46	
2. JPN	6	4	17	27	
3. KOR	6	1	5	12	
4. KAZ	4	1	1	6	
5. THA	3	5	4	12	
6. HKG	2	1	1	4	
7. TJK	1	4	2	7	
8. IND	1	4	1	6	
9. UZB	1	3	5	9	
10. TPE					

Lankan batting unravelled. Shafali began the demolition, Sree Charani added to the misery before Deepti Sharma's 3/6 knocked the stuffing out of the opposition.

Barring the T20 World Cup blip, the Asian Games gold medal adds to India women's growth in

world cricket. In November, they won the 50-over World Cup, lifted the Asia Cup and now the Games crown. Say what you may about Harmanpreet, the team continues to deliver results under her.

"It's a fantastic feeling. Before the tournament, we talked a lot about staying unbeaten, but more importantly, about playing to the high standards we set for ourselves. It's so satisfying to see everyone approach every game with such a positive mindset. Every single player who got an opportunity stepped up and delivered. As a captain and as a collective, that's exactly what we were looking for, maintaining an unbeaten run while consistently putting in this quality of performance is what we expected of our-

selves, and it's great to see everyone execute that vision with confidence."

India experienced a bit of a lull in the middle overs, but Richa's late onslaught made the difference between a 190 and a 200-plus total. The last over fetched India 25 runs, with Richa belting a couple of sixes while Mithali Ayodhya conceded five wides. "The difference in feeling between both (trophy and medal), when you stand on the podium and sing the national anthem that is a different feeling."

Brief scores: India 216/3 (Shafali Verma 48, Smriti Mandhana 79, Richa Ghosh 49). Sri Lanka 69 all out in 15.4 ovs (Shafali 2/3, Deepti 3/6, Shreyanki 2/9, Shree Charani 2/13). **India won by 147 runs.**

India beat Japan, assured of medal in men's team event

Sandip Sikdar
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NEW DELHI: It was as if Indian male shuttlers could do no wrong at the Asian Games on Tuesday. Even when they faltered during their matches, they fought back in dramatic fashion to ensure they would not return empty-handed from Aichi-Nagoya.

The team-building exercises the players did ahead of the tournament — joint yoga sessions, practising having meals together — bore fruit as India beat hosts Japan 3-0 in the quarter-finals.

The men's team has previously won one silver, last time around in 2023, and three bronze medals in 1974, 1982 and 1986.

It was Lakshya Sen who gave India a fantastic start with a dramatic 11-21, 21-5, 21-19 win over Kodai Naraoka in an hour and six minutes, marking a comeback from 13-19 down in the decider.

The top-ranked Indian men's shuttler demonstrated immense tactical resilience to overcome the significant deficit.

At the start, Naraoka controlled the pacing and decisively took the opening game to put Sen on the back foot early on. But the world No.14 completely shifted the momentum, heavily dictating the rallies and restricting Naraoka to just five points to force a decider.

In the third game, Naraoka built a massive early advantage, making good use of the drift to leave Sen trailing 6-14. He further took the advantage to 19-13 and was just two points away from victory.

However, capitalising on a crucial change of ends, Sen clawed his way back giving India the lead. This was Sen's third win in nine meetings over the two-time World Championships silver medalist.

Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Reddy took on 2021 world champions Takuro Hoki and Yugo Kobayashi in the second clash.

Rankireddy and Shetty unleashed their trademark baseline power with lightning-fast net play that suffocated their opponents' defence helping them win 21-18, 24-22 in 56 minutes.

The match unfolded with a sequence of high-tempo flat drives where Shetty's rapid



Lakshya Sen.

REUTERS

reflexes turned split-second defence into instant offense. Reading the flight early at the tape, Shetty intercepted tight net exchanges with precision, repeatedly forcing high, defensive lifts into the backcourt, right into Rankireddy's strike zone. Waiting deep on the baseline, Rankireddy unleashed a barrage of steep, towering jump smashes that shattered the opposition's defensive wall through sheer pace and angle.

Having never beaten Koki Watanabe, it was a test for young Ayush Shetty. But the explosive Indian shuttler completely maintained control over the local shuttler. From not even having taken a game off Watanabe in the previous two encounters, Shetty won the contest 21-10, 21-19 to put India in the semis where they will face China.

Women's team loses

India's campaign came to an end as the PV Sindhu-led squad lost the women's team quarter-final 1-3 to hosts Japan. Sindhu lost Akane Yamaguchi 23-21, 18-21, 11-21. Japan made it 2-0 when 20-year-old Tomoka Miyazaki breezed past Unnati Hooda 21-16, 21-18. Treasa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand beat Yuki Fukushima and Mayu Matsumoto 21-17, 21-16. But Tanvi Sharma lost to Nozomi Okuhara 12-21, 10-21.



Scan QR Code to follow HT's detailed coverage of the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya

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CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

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I don't believe in age, I believe in science: Shruti Vora



Shruti Vora with Magnanimous.

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NEW DELHI: This February, less than three months after her three-medal haul at the Asian Championships in Pattaya, Thailand, equestrian Shruti Vora packed her bags at her then base in Germany and relocated to Yorkshire to train under world No. 5 and Paris Olympics bronze medalist Becky Moody. The reason? Despite her three silver medals, Vora was not happy with the way she rode.

"As an athlete, you must be ready to step out of your comfort zone. I feel I could've done much better in Thailand and maybe my training needed an upgrade," she told HT from Japan where she'll compete in the dressage event at the ongoing Asian Games later this week.

"I followed the same philosophy when I moved to Germany about two-and-a-half years back. And now again, I felt the need to reinvent."

Vora is kicking herself for not making the move earlier. Trained until recently by Major Jitendarjit Singh Ahluwalia, who also co-owns her horse Magnanimous — a 14-year-old warmblood gelding — and London Olympics team dressage silver medalist from

Germany Helen Langehanenberg, Vora was blown away by Moody's attention to detail.

"She is a great person and a great athlete. I regret not coming to her earlier. That doesn't take anything away from Major Ahluwalia or Helen who trained me to reach this far," she said.

In all her years of competing at the elite level, no one, Vora says, exposed her to the precision needed to excel in her sport. Dressage, an expression of equine aesthetics, requires the rider-horse combine to walk, trot, and canter along with advanced maneuvers like the piaffe (a trotting motion in place) and passage (a very collected, springy trot). The rider-horse pair is judged on accuracy, submission, and the apparent ease of the rider.

"I was a bit naive not to have known how precise this sport can be. Dressage is all about precision," she says.

"Becky taught me the trueness of the horse and the fine points pertaining to correctness of riding. She talks in centimeters and inches. Sometimes, when I come down the center line, Becky goes, 'You are 1.5 inches off the line.' I never heard a trainer tell me that in my life. That is precision. I feel I have become a more refined rider

already, and I am still learning."

At 55, she is the oldest member of the 492-member Indian athletes' contingent. Tell that to Vora, and she goes, "I am old enough to be their mother." But the joke ends there. Vora believes that age is just a number, and rather than mulling over it, she takes recourse in science.

"I don't believe in age. I believe in science. Muscle doesn't know how old you are; it's the mind. Age is what I look at and smile," she said.

"Of course, you need to pay attention to recovery. There's muscle atrophy too, but all that shouldn't stop you. Proper scientific training is the key." A stickler for her gym sessions, she trains six days a week and rides almost every day to ensure Magnanimous stays in competitive rhythm.

"My training is a mix of all muscle groups. There's decent VO2 training as well. The schedule varies on days I have intense riding sessions," she says. With her family based in Mumbai, Vora fights periodic bouts of homesickness and longing. When in India, she rides in her stable in Alibaug.

"I never miss a riding session. I have a family to take care of as well, so my life is very different from that of a regular athlete, but

this is what I have signed up for. I hope to return with 'the' medal to make it all worthwhile. I have been in good form. My body is feeling well, I am in good mental space," she said.

Having made her Asian Games debut in Incheon in 2014 where she was "like a Class 10 student wanting to give a Class 12 exam," Vora has accrued a wealth of experience over the years to become one of the most accomplished Indian riders. Back then though, it was a bit of a reality check.

"All I can remember from Incheon 2014 was that I was too raw. In your mind, you think you're like cat's whiskers. It doesn't really work like that. I was eighth in individual dressage, which wasn't a bad result. But I would call myself a sack of potatoes there."

India had a memorable run in dressage at the 2023 Asian Games in Hangzhou where the quartet of Sudipti Hajela, Hriday Chheda, Anush Agarwalla, and Divyakriti Singh won a team gold while Agarwalla later claimed an individual bronze medal. Only Chheda has managed to retain his place in this Asian team. Besides Vora and Chheda, India will be represented by Gaurav Pundir and Jai Sud in dressage.

indiansinaction

SHOOTING

Air pistol women's individual qualification: Suruchi Singh, Esha Singh, Manu Bhaker **06:15**

Skeet men's individual qualification Day 3: Anantjeet Singh Naruka, Bhavtegh Singh Gill, Mairaj Ahmad Khan **06:30**

SOFT TENNIS

Men's singles quarter-final: Jay Meena vs Sherwin Nuguit (PHI) **05:30**

SEPAK TAKRAW

Men's team regu: India vs Philippines **05:30**

ROWING

Men's single sculls heats: Balraj Panwar **05:40am**

Men's double sculls heats: Satnam Singh, Salman Khan **06:00**

Men's pairs heats: Jaswinder Singh, Nitin Kumar **06:50**

Women's four heats: Gurbani Kaur, Poonam, Tendenthoi Devi, Haobijam **07:10**

Men's lightweight double sculls heats: Rohit, Ujjwal Kumar Singh **11:20**

Men's quadruple sculls heats: Arvind Singh, Kulwinder Singh, Navdeep Singh, Jakar Khan **12:10**

Men's four heats: Ghurde Vipul Satish, Saurav Kumar, Babu Lal Yadav, Yogesh Kumar **12:20**

CANOE SPRINT

Men's kayak four 500m heats: Harshwardhan Shaktawat, Varinder Singh, L Naocha Singh Oinam, Arun Singh **06:30**

Women's canoe single 200m heats: Megha Pradeep **06:50**

Women's kayak double 500m heats: Parvathy Geetha, Phairembam Soniya Devi **07:10**

Men's kayak double 500m heats: Prsanna Kumar CS, Prohit Baroi **10:40**

Women's canoe double 500m heats: Megha Pradeep, L Neha Devi **11:00**

EQUESTRIAN

Eventing individual cross country: Ashish Limaye, Fouaad Mirza **06:30**

BADMINTON

Men's team SF: India vs China **11:30**

HOCKEY

Women's Pool B: India vs Thailand **11:30**

TABLE TENNIS

Mixed doubles Rd of 32: Harmeet Desai/Vashaswini Ghorpade vs Ismael Mohamed/Alfi Fathimath (MDV) **06:30**, Manush Shah/Diya Chitale vs Chanul Kulappuwawadu/ Bimandee Swam (SL) **07:10**

SWIMMING

Men's 100m butterfly heats: Rohit Benedicton, Sajan Prakash **06:42**

Men's 200m freestyle heats: Anesh Sunil Kumar Gowda, Vedaant Madhavan **07:03**

FENCING

Women's foil individual: Naorem Mina Devi and Joys Ashitha Stalinraj **06:30 onwards**

Men's sabre individual: Gisho Nidhi KP and Karan Singh **08:15 onwards**

KABADDI

Women's Group A: India vs Iran **08:30**

Men's Group A: India vs Bangladesh **09:45**

BOXING

Men's 80kg Rd of 16: Ankush vs Hamsa Vogel (BRN) **08:30 onwards**

WEIGHTLIFTING

Women's 49kg final: Mirabai Chanu **10:00**

Women's 53kg final: Gyaneshwari Yadav **13:30**

SQUASH

Men's singles Rd of 32: Abhay Singh vs Arkaradet Arkharhirunnya (THA) **10:30**

Women's singles - Rd of 32: Tanvi Khanna vs Kim Dami (KOR) **11:15**

Men's singles Rd of 32: Veer Chotrani vs Mohamed Wakeel (SL) **12:00**

WUSHU

Women's sanda 60kg semi-final: Roshibina Devi vs Thania Kusumaningtyas (INA) **14:30 onwards**

(ALL TIMES IST)

GAMES CONNECTION

ROSHIBINA DEVI ENTERS SEMI-FINAL

Roshibina Devi Naorem on Tuesday assured India of a medal as she entered the semi-finals of the women's 60kg category in wushu, defeating Chu Man Sin from Macau in the last eight stage at the Asian Games. Roshibina, who has previously won a silver as well as a bronze medal in the previous two editions of the competition, was declared winner on point difference over her opponent from Macau at the Aichi Prefectural Martial Arts Hall. But Hanjabam Langlontombi Devi finished at the ninth spot in the final of the women's Nanquan & Nandao event with a score of 9.403. She scored 4.85 in quality of movement, 2.703 in overall performance and 1.85 in degree of difficulty. Aryan, meanwhile, lost to Saydullo Aburashitov from Uzbekistan 1-2 (5-0 0-5 0-5) in the quarterfinal of the men's 56kg Sanda event.

PRANATI QUALIFIES FOR VAULT FINALS

India's lone gymnast at the Asian Games, Pranati Nayak qualified for the vault finals in the artistic gymnastics event with a seventh-place finish. The three-time bronze medalist in



Roshibina Devi Naorem.

HT

the Asian Gymnastics Championships, Pranati was seventh among 19 gymnasts to have made the final of the vault event. Pranati had scored 13.000 in the vault 1 with scores of 4.4 in difficulty and 8.600 in execution, and 12.433 with scores of 4.0 in difficulty and 8.433 in execution in vault 2 with an overall of 12.916.

SAKSHI, JADUMANI ENTER LAST-16

Indian boxer Sakshi Chaudhary (51kg) pulled off an upset by out-punching Paris Olympics bronze-medallist Aira Villegas to storm into the pre-quarters, while Jadumani Singh (55kg) also advanced to the last-16. The 26-year-old Bhiwani boxer used her height and reach to keep the Filipino at bay and notch a 5-0 win. Jadumani also began his campaign with a dominant 5-0 victory over Nepal's Chandra Bahadur Thapa and will face Tokyo Olympics silver medalist Carlo Paalam.

HOW INDIA FARED

SWIMMING

MEN'S 1,500M FREESTYLE FINAL B

Aryan Nehra ended 4th

MEN'S 4X100M MEDLEY RELAY

India ended 8th in final

BOXING

WOMEN'S 51KG

RD OF 32

Sakshi beat Aira Villegas (PHI) 5-0

MEN'S 55KG

RD OF 32

Jadumani Singh bt Chandra Bahadur Thapa (NEP) 5-0

BADMINTON

WOMEN'S TEAM

QUARTER-FINAL

India lost to Japan 1-3

MEN'S TEAM

QUARTER-FINAL

India beat Japan 3-0

EQUESTRIAN

EVENTING TEAM

DRESSAGE

India were 7th

EVENTING TEAM JUMPING

India were eliminated

EVENTING INDIVIDUAL

DRESSAGE

Ashish Limaye was 14th, Arjan Nagra 23rd, Fouaad Mirza 26th

EVENTING INDIVIDUAL

JUMPING

Ashish Limaye was 6th, Fouaad Mirza 24th and Arjan Nagra was eliminated

CRICKET

WOMEN'S GOLD MEDAL MATCH

India beat Sri Lanka by 147 runs

ESPORTS

FOOTBALL

IND drew vs UZB 0-0

India got walkover from Mongolia

ARTISTIC GYMNASTICS

WOMEN'S QUALIFICATION

Pranati Nayak finished 7th, qualified for final

WUSHU

NANQUAN & NANDAO FINAL

HL Devi ended 9th

SANDA 60KG QF

Roshibina Devi bt Man Sin Chu win by point difference

MEN'S SANDA 56KG QUARTER-FINAL

Aryan lost to Saydullo Abdurashitov 2-1

FENCING

MEN'S FOIL

INDIVIDUAL RD OF 32

Hemansh Singh Sanasam lost to Galim Nurumov (KAZ) 9-15

Sachin lost to Timofey Semyonov (KAZ)

WOMEN'S EPEE

INDIVIDUAL RD OF 16

Taniksha Khatri lost to Sera Song (KOR) 9-15

RD OF 32

Mitva Chaudhari lost to Jingwen Yang (CHN) 14-15

HOCKEY

MEN'S POOL A

India bt Sri Lanka 16-1

SOFT TENNIS

MEN'S SINGLES

Jay Meena bt Hussain Arain (PAK) 4-0, Aryan Thakur bt Bold-erdene Altangerel (MGL) 4-0, Aryan Thakur bt Po-Yi Chen (TPE) 4-0

WOMEN SINGLES

Aadhya Tiwari lost to Alisha Ziegler (THA) 1-4, bt Kainaaf Shallwani (PAK) 4-0

CHINA'S ABSENCE
IN CHANU'S CLASS
BOOSTS CHANCE
OF ASIAD MEDAL

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NEW DELHI: Mirabai Chanu's 12-year quest for an elusive Asian Games medal may finally come to an end at the weightlifting hall in Nagoya City Trade and Industry Centre on Wednesday, thanks in no small part to China's absence in the 49kg division.

A powerhouse in global weightlifting, China has entered in all other women's weight classes barring the lightest division.

That leaves two-time defending champion from North Korea, Ri Song Gun, as a clear favourite to complete a golden hat-trick at Asiad and also Chanu's primary rival. The Indian has entered an entry weight of 200kg while the North Korean will enter the competition with a 210kg opening aggregate, national coach Vijay Sharma said.

"It's surprising that China hasn't sent anyone in 49kg, but it gives us a decent chance to end the medal wait. The North Korean lifter is our main competitor but we are not taking anyone lightly," Sharma told HT from Nagoya.

"Mira is in great shape and mindset. There are no niggles and her form is good. We hope to get that missing medal on Wednesday," he added.

Chinese Taipei and Indonesia, Sharma said, are other nations Chanu will be mindful of. Chinese Taipei will be represented by Fang Wan-ling while Wijayana Luluk Diana Tri will bear Indonesian hopes. Thai lifter Kaesongkhon Suthasini is also expected to be a medal contender.

Chanu has fond memories of competing in a Games in Japan, having won silver in the 2021 Tokyo Olympics.

The 53kg final will also be contested on Wednesday with India being represented by Gyaneshwari Yadav.

India scrape past Japan by two runs in historic T20I tie

Vishesh Roy

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NEW DELHI: India survived by the skin of their teeth in the one-off T20I against Japan on Tuesday, winning the contest by two runs in a nail-biting affair at the Sano International Cricket Ground. The five-over shootout in Sano after a rain delay went down to the final ball, when Japan had the chance of pulling off a historic upset in their first-ever T20I against a full-member nation.

But Axar Patel proved the saviour, holding his nerve to seal a narrow win. The performance, however, could not mask the cracks as India's batting again highlighted their struggles against spin.

The match witnessed its fair share of drama, as the final over saw the on-field umpires reverse a wide call under substantial pressure from both skipper Shreyas Iyer and Axar.

Alexander Shirai-Patmore had moved across the crease while attempting a reverse sweep when Axar's delivery travelled down the leg side. Umpire Chris Thurgate first signalled a wide, prompting an immediate reaction from Axar and keeper Sanju Samson with Shreyas also getting involved in the discussion. Thurgate consulted square-leg umpire Chris Brown and withdrew the original call, converting it into a legal dot ball.

The playing conditions do not state that a batter loses the chance of a wide simply by attempting a reverse sweep or switch-hit. The central question instead whether the delivery was sufficiently within the striker's reach, taking into account the batter's original



Japan's Kendel Kadowaki-Fleming bats against India during the Suzuki Cup T20 match.

position and subsequent movement.

Rain delay

The match got underway after a three-hour delay due to a wet outfield caused by overnight rain. The match was reduced to five overs per side.

Winning the toss was the

only positive for India in the first innings, as the batters struggled. Japan were quick to recognise the conditions, with all five overs bowled by spinners. Charlie Hara-Hinze, Ibrahim Takahashi and Benjamin Ito-Davis made full use of the slow turn on offer, bowling in good areas and leaving the

Indian batters short of answers.

Abhishek Sharma was the first to go, out for a golden duck. It was his seventh score of zero in T20Is in 2026, and his fifth first-ball dismissal.

Sanju Samson (9), Ishan Kishan (3) and Shreyas Iyer (16) looked all at sea. India hit just two boundaries in the innings.

Samson hit the first in the opening over and Shreyas the other in the last over.

India finished on 32/4, a well below par score on a tricky pitch. Charlie Hara-Hinze was the pick of the Japan spinners, taking 2/17.

Japan too struggled. Ishan Kishan produced a direct hit from the deep catching opener Lachlan Yamamoto Lake short of his crease in the first over. Washington Sundar then struck twice. However, Ravi Bishnoi gave away 10 runs in his only over. It left Japan needing eight from the last six deliveries, with Axar tasked with bowling the final over.

The drama over the wide followed. In the end, Japan needed four from the final delivery but managed only a single.

After the win, Shreyas spoke about playing the historic T20I. "First, congratulations to Japan and India for 75 years of diplomatic relationship. It's something that we keep talking about every now and then when we arrive. Talking about today's occasion, it was a long travel for us," he said.

Shreyas said India always wanted to play against Japan despite the three-hour bus journey to reach the venue.

"We wanted to play the game, excite the crowd who had come and the supporters who had been trying to see it that this match was organised. So, congratulations to everyone who has been present over here to deliver this particular game, and it's come out so fantastically. Even though it was five overs, I feel that at least we got to see and experience such a great performance from the Japanese team and the Indian players," he added.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

HT

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

A pleasure to play
against stronger
teams: Khalid

Dhiman Sarkar

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KOLKATA: Twenty-six years after he was a player on a tour of England with the senior men's football team, Khalid Jamil will be part of another first. This time, he will be in the technical area opposite Thomas Christiansen, Carlo Ancelotti and Diego Forlan as India host Panama, Brazil and Uruguay, all in the top 50 of the FIFA rankings.

So, it fit that in the interview to HT, which began with him stroking his beard, Jamil, 49, would look back as much as he would look forward to the matches that begin with a contest against Panama in Bengaluru on Friday. "It was a big move. Never thought we would be going to England with the national team," said Jamil over a video call from Bengaluru.

India played Fulham, West Bromwich Albion and the Bangladesh national team in 2000, their first tour to England. For Jamil that was a "stepping stone."

"Diet, how to prepare for matches, the importance of pre-seasons, of not being overawed...there were a lot of things we learnt on that tour. Now, players are much more informed."

That showed when India played Jamaica and Zimbabwe in the Unity Cup this year, he said, referring to the full-circle moment of returning to England as head coach. The tour of 2000 also made Jamil realise the importance of playing friendlies against stronger teams. "It is a pleasure to play against stronger teams. The more you do that, the more you will improve. And it is even better that we are playing at home against such strong teams. For the players, this is a good chance to show that they can take responsibility and stay united," he said.

Ranked 138th in the world, India will have a chance to do all that against teams who are 44th

(Panama), fifth (Brazil) and 20th (Uruguay) and who were part of the 2026 World Cup.

Barring defender Ricky Hao-bam, who was injured and replaced by Mehtab Singh, all 26 in Jamil's original list have reported. "All the players I called are in good shape. I reached out to them one month before naming the squad stressing on the importance of staying fit. As I have said earlier, players of this generation know how to look after themselves."

Among the players Jamil has called is India youth international Som Kumar, a 21-year-old goalkeeper playing in Slovenia for the past two seasons. "He is a good, talented boy who has improved since going to Slovenia. We are looking for this type of player. We need them."

Kumar would be fourth in the pecking order in a list that has Gurpreet Singh Sandhu, Prabhukhan Singh Gill and Albino Gomes but his inclusion is part of the squad rebuild Jamil is attempting. He has left out regulars such as Sandesh Jhingan, Liston Colaco, Rahul Bheke and Jeakson Singh even though they have had more game time than many of the players he has called.

"We are building a new, solid team. So, there will be some changes. I think this is the correct time to change. And it is not like we will not call them again," said Jamil, looking into the camera with his game face on.

In a conversation peppered with "let's stay positive" and "no negative vibes, please", it was also the only time that Jamil jumped into an answer before the question was finished.

This process of rebuilding could continue through the away friendlies against New Zealand and, depending on the importance All India Football Federation accords to it, in the SAFF Championship both of which are in November, said Jamil.

Sachin: India's first Asian Games
champ and a gold that stands alone

Susan Ninan

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BENGALURU: Sachin Nag was ten when he led the police away from his freedom-fighter older brother, Bholanath, and jumped into the Ganges. Coincidentally, a 10km swimming race was under way. He slipped into the stream of swimmers and ended up finishing third.

In 1951, at the inaugural Asian Games in New Delhi, Nag won the 100m freestyle. Seventy-five years later, it remains the only swimming gold India has won at the Games.

Nag was born in Varanasi in 1920 and moved to Calcutta in 1937. Swimming then bore little resemblance to the world of temperature-controlled pools, biomechanical analysis and hydrodynamics we know today. Nag made do.

At Deshbandhu Park, where he trained, he nailed wooden planks against the walls of the pond so he could push off with greater force.

"When he was a boy, my father fell from a bael (stone apple) tree and broke his left wrist," his son Ashok Nag, 70, a former Indian Air Force sergeant, tells HT. "Medical treatment then was rudimentary and the wrist remained slightly crooked. My father believed the unusual bend actually helped him while swimming."

During the Bengal riots in 1947, a stray bullet struck Nag in the right leg. Doctors advised him not to swim. Lying in hospital, he practiced what he could: moving his arms and his uninjured leg.

Once home, he gave his family the slip and returned to training. Back then, athletes had to bear a substantial portion of the cost of travelling to the Olym-



Sachin Nag on the podium at the 1951 New Delhi Asiad.

pics. Nag washed goods vehicles at dawn before training to raise money for the 1948 London Games. Still short of funds, he was helped by childhood friend and singer Hemanta Mukhopadhyay, who organised a fundraising campaign, including a musical programme in Calcutta (now Kolkata), to help get him to London.

Nag competed in the 100m freestyle at the Olympics and was also part of the Indian water polo team, scoring four goals in a 7-4 victory over Chile.

Three years later came the race that would define him. Nag reached Delhi in January 1951, two months before the Asian Games, since he didn't have access to proper training facilities in Calcutta.

Nag approached GS Sondhi,

then organising secretary of the Games and president of the Asian Games Federation, asking for a place to train. Instead, he was asked why he had arrived so early and was turned away.

He did not return to Calcutta. The next day, he located a 20x10m pool at Cecil Hotel, a European-owned luxury address, and persuaded its Italian manager to let him practice there.

"She allowed him to practice for a daily charge of ₹5, a considerable sum at the time. She was so impressed with his dedication that the charges were later waived. He practiced there till the start of the Asian Games."

Shortly before their race, Nag asked fellow Indian swimmer Isaac Mansoor what he thought of his winning chances. Mansoor

replied that he didn't think he had any.

Nag had a proposition. He wanted Mansoor, known for his explosive start, to be quick off the blocks.

"Mansoor kept his word. My father chased him and it helped him gain time on the other swimmers. He was always grateful to Mansoor for it."

Nag won gold in 1:04.70. He also won two bronze medals, in the 4x100m freestyle relay and 3x100m medley relay.

Away from the pool, Nag played the sitar, loved theatre and appeared in two Bengali films. At home, Ashok remembers a man with a formidable appetite.

"My father could polish off mutton with rotis," he laughs.

For all that Nag achieved in the pool, he never got his due, Ashok believes. Nag, who also participated in the 1952 Olympics, died in 1987 without receiving a national sports award.

"When the Asian Games were over, the organising committee offered him ₹30 to take the train back to Calcutta. My father politely declined it," Ashok said. "Till his final days, he appeared let down by the way he was treated."

Ashok applied five times for a posthumous national sports award for his father. Finally, in 2020, 33 years after his death, Nag received the Dhyani Chand Award for Lifetime Achievement in Sports. Ashok's efforts also led the late swimmer to be inducted into the International Swimming Hall of Fame in 2025.

His next pursuit is a Padma Shri. He's already sent in applications nine times, starting in 2018.

Ashok is not willing to give up just yet on his father's final race—the one for belated recognition.

Valverde likely to
miss India match

KOLKATA: Federico

Valverde is likely to miss Uruguay's friendly against India here on October 6 after suffering a grade 3 ankle sprain in the Madrid derby at the weekend. The Real Madrid skipper was hurt by a tackle from Atletico's Lee Kang-in and is likely to be out for several weeks, according to reports in the Spanish press.

England's Rashid
out of SL ODIs

LONDON: Leg-spinner

Adil Rashid was ruled out of England's ODIs against Sri Lanka. The 38-year-old sustained an injury to his right, bowling, hand while fielding at Old Trafford on Saturday as England completed a 3-0 T20 whitewash of the tourists. After undergoing a scan on Monday, ECB said Rashid would be absent from Thursday's match at Headingley and Sunday's game at the Oval.

Noskova takes Czech
into BJK Cup semis

SHENZHEN: Wimbledon

champion Linda Noskova helped Czech Republic into the semi-finals of the Billie Jean King Cup with a 6-2, 7-6 (7/3) victory over Great Britain's Katie Boulter. Noskova's win secured a 2-0 win for the Czechs, who will next face either Kazakhstan or Spain. "The first match is never easy, no matter what. So, I was surprised by the way that I played in the first set, especially," said the sixth-ranked Noskova.

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A quiz on the week's development.

